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Chapter 1

India's Foreign Policy

Foreign policy is a set of self-interest strategies chosen by a state to safeguard its national interests and achieve goals within its international relations milieu.

Determinants of India's Foreign Policy

1. **Geography:** India's strategic location in the Indian Ocean and shared land borders dictate its security priorities. Eg. **"Necklace of Diamonds"** strategy to counter maritime encirclement.
2. **Historical Legacy:** Eg. India's consistent support for the **Palestinian cause** and African decolonization.
3. **Economic Needs:** Eg. negotiating **Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreements (CEPA)** with nations like the UAE.
4. **Energy Security:** Eg. maintaining oil imports from **Russia** despite Western pressure during the Ukraine conflict.
5. **Strategic Culture:** Ancient philosophies like **Kautilya's Arthashastra** influence India's realistic and pragmatic power calculations. Eg. India's **"Multi-alignment"** approach.
6. **Political Leadership:** Eg. the shift from "Look East" to the more proactive **"Act East"** policy.
7. **Domestic Milieu:** Eg. managing relations with **Sri Lanka** while considering the political sentiments of Tamil Nadu.
8. **Global Power Structure:** Eg. participation in both the **QUAD** and the **Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO)**.
9. **Military Capability:** Eg. implementation of the **"No First Use"** nuclear doctrine to signal responsibility.

Principles of India's Foreign Policy

1. **Panchsheel:** Five principles of peaceful coexistence, including mutual non-aggression and non-interference in internal affairs.
2. **Strategic Autonomy:** Eg. refusing to join the **RCEP** to protect domestic dairy and manufacturing sectors.
3. **Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam:** Eg. **Vaccine Maitri** initiative providing COVID-19 vaccines to over 90 countries.
4. **Neighbourhood First:** Prioritizing political and economic ties with immediate neighbors to ensure regional stability.
5. **Non-Alignment (NAM 2.0):** Avoiding permanent military alliances while engaging in issue-based partnerships with global powers.
6. **Anti-Terrorism:** Eg. proposing the **Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism (CCIT)** at the United Nations.
7. **Multilateralism:** Eg. leading the **G20** presidency with a focus on the "Global South."
8. **Soft Power:** Eg. The UN declared June 21 as **International Day of Yoga**.
9. **Nuclear Responsibility:** Maintaining a credible minimum deterrent while advocating for universal, non-discriminatory nuclear disarmament.

Major Achievements of India's Foreign Policy

1. **G20 Presidency:** Successfully forged consensus on the New Delhi Declaration.
2. **Permanent Membership Push:** Secured backing from four out of five UNSC members.
3. **Vaccine Diplomacy:** Positioned India as the "Pharmacy of the World."

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4. **Civil Nuclear Deal:** Ended India's nuclear isolation through the 2008 US agreement.
5. **Diaspora Evacuations:** Missions like **Operation Ganga** and **Operation Kaveri**.
6. **ISA Leadership:** Co-founded the **International Solar Alliance** with France.
7. **Maritime Leadership:** Emerged as a "First Responder" in the Indian Ocean.
8. **Strategic Ties:** Elevated relations with West Asian powers like UAE/Saudi Arabia.
9. **Boundary Settlements: Land Boundary Agreement** with Bangladesh.
10. **Global South Voice:** Successfully championed African Union's inclusion in the G20.

Major Challenges in India's Foreign Policy

1. **China's Assertiveness:** Eg. the protracted military standoff in **Eastern Ladakh** since 2020.
2. **Two-Front Threat:** Simultaneous security challenges from the combined nexus of Pakistan and China.
3. **Neighborhood Volatility:** Eg. **Taliban takeover** in Afghanistan and the 2024 political shift in Bangladesh.
4. **Balancing Great Powers:** Eg. handling the CAATSA sanctions threat while purchasing **S-400 systems** from Russia.
5. **Trade Protectionism:** Rising global trade barriers and the stalling of WTO negotiations.
6. **Climate Justice:** Balancing national development goals with global demands for rapid decarbonization. Eg. negotiating "phase down" vs "phase out" of **coal** at COP summits.
7. **Energy Vulnerability:** Volatility in the Middle East threatens oil prices and supply chains.
8. **Maritime Competition:** Eg. Regular docking of Chinese **spy ships** at ports like Hambantota.
9. **Resource Scarcity:** Transboundary water disputes with neighbors that could escalate into conflict.

Way Forward to Strengthen India's Foreign Policy

1. **Strategic Hedging:** India must avoid choosing sides in the US-China rivalry, maintaining "equidistance" to maximize its own strategic space. **(C. Raja Mohan)**
2. **Economic Integration** into Global Value Chains (GVCs) to provide a credible alternative to China. (**Suhasini Haidar**)
3. **Revitalizing SAARC:** Strengthening regional institutions is vital to prevent neighbors from drifting toward China's orbit.
4. **Digital Diplomacy:** Leveraging India's Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) as a diplomatic tool for the Global South.
5. **Naval Expansion:** Increasing the budget and pace of naval modernization to maintain "Command of the Seas" in the IOR.
6. **Bureaucratic Reform:** Expanding the Indian Foreign Service (IFS) cadre to match the diplomatic footprint of other major powers. (**Shivshankar Menon**)
7. **Para-diplomacy:** Encouraging Indian states to engage directly with foreign counterparts to boost trade and cultural ties. (**Happymon Jacob**)
8. **Technology Alliances:** Focusing on Critical and Emerging Technologies (iCET) to ensure future economic and military edge.
9. **Sustainable Neighborhood:** Moving from "Big Brother" to "Lead Partner" by offering non-reciprocal economic concessions to neighbors. (**S.D. Muni**)

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Chapter 2

India and Global Powers

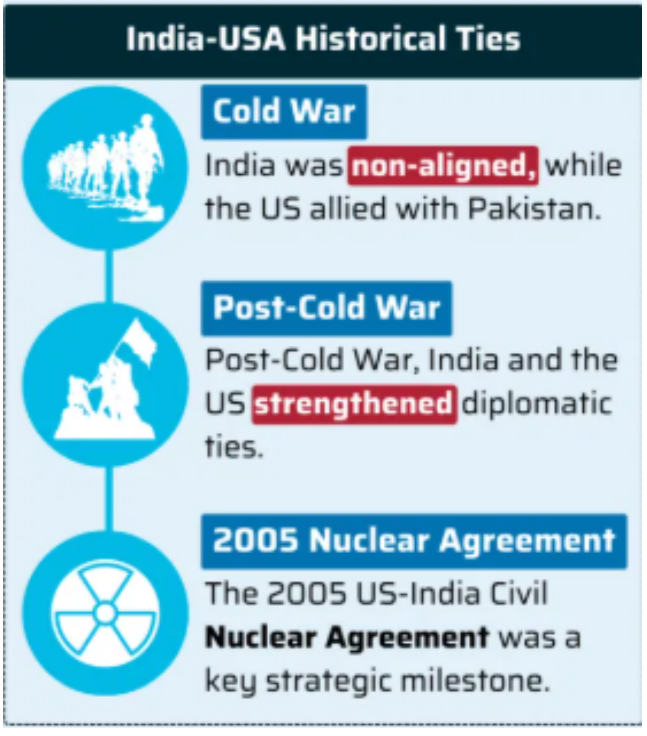
PYQs

[2024] The West is fostering India as an alternative to reduce dependence on China's supply chain and as a strategic ally to counter China's political and economic dominance.' Explain this statement with examples. (10)
[2020] What is the significance of Indo-US defence deals over Indo-Russian defence deals? Discuss with reference to stability in the Indo-Pacific region. (15)
[2019] "What introduces friction into the ties between India and the United States is that Washington is still unable to find for India a position in its global strategy, which would satisfy India's National self-esteem and ambitions" Explain with suitable examples. (15)
[2018] In what ways would the ongoing US-Iran Nuclear Pact Controversy affect the national interest of India? How should India respond to this situation? (15)
[2017] 'China is using its economic relations and positive trade surplus as tools to develop potential military power status in Asia', In the light of this statement, discuss its impact on India as her neighbor. (10)
[2014] With respect to the South China sea, maritime territorial disputes and rising tension affirm the need for safeguarding maritime security to ensure freedom of navigation and over flight throughout the region. In this context, discuss the bilateral issues between India and China. (12.5)
[2013] Economic ties between India and Japan, while growing in recent years, are still far below their potential. Elucidate the policy constraints which are inhibiting this growth. (10)

India-US Relations:

S. Jaishankar, "Our relationship with the U.S. today is one of comfort with convergence, and both sides see great value in working together to address shared global challenges."

C. Raja Mohan, "India and the US are moving from a 'hesitations of history' to a 'confluence of interests,' yet the relationship must survive the 'transactional' tests of trade and energy."



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Recent News

- **Advanced defence partnership:** Extension of **Major Defence Partner Status**
- **Interim Trade Deal (Feb 2026):** The US reduced effective tariffs on Indian goods from 50% to **18%**.
- India has agreed to significantly reduce the purchase of Russian crude oil.
- India is expected to reduce its tariffs and non-tariff barriers on US goods to **"zero"**.
- India has committed to importing $100 billion worth of U.S. goods annually for five years
- **COMPACT Launch (2025):** The "Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce & Technology" was established as the new bilateral umbrella.
- **AI Opportunity Partnership (2026):** Agreement on ethical AI policies and shared GPU/data center facilities to counter technological monopolies.
- **SMR Collaboration (2025):** Commitment to deploy US-designed **Small Modular Reactors** (SMRs) to boost India's clean energy grid.

India-US COMPACT Initiative

- Defence Collaboration.
- **10-year Defence Framework (2025-2035)** for expanding cooperation.
- **Co-production of Javelin Anti-Tank Guided Missiles**.
- Expansion of **joint exercises (Tiger Triumph)**.
- Introduction of the **Reciprocal Defence Procurement (RDP) Agreement**.
- Launch of **Autonomous Systems Industry Alliance (ASIA)** for **AI-driven defence systems**.
- Trade & Investment Expansion:
  - Launch of **Mission 500** to achieve **USD 500 billion bilateral trade by 2030**.
  - **Tariff reductions** on **ICT products, vehicles, and beverages**.
  - Enhanced **market access** for **agriculture and industrial goods**.
- Energy Security - Increased cooperation in oil, gas, and nuclear energy. US support for India's IEA membership.
- Technology Advancement.
- **iCET rebranded as TRUST** (Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology).
- Focus on **semiconductors, AI, and quantum computing**. Expansion of **critical mineral supply chains (lithium, rare earths)**.
- Enhanced **space cooperation (NASA-ISRO)** including:
  - **Indian astronaut mission to ISS.**
  - **NISAR satellite mission.**
- Multilateral & Regional Cooperation.
- Strengthening the **Quad partnership**. Cooperation on **counterterrorism and Indo-Pacific security**.
- Support for connectivity projects like the **India-Middle East-Europe Corridor (IMEC)**.
- People-to-People Engagement.
- Increased **academic and workforce mobility**.
- **Easing legal migration pathways**.
- Cooperation against **trafficking and transnational crime**.

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Areas of Cooperation:

Defense:

1. 4 Fundamental defense agreements: **GSOMIA, LEMOA, COMCASA, BECA** for seamless military-to-military interoperability.
2. **Joint Exercises: MALABAR, YUDH ABHYAS, RED FLAG, etc.**
3. **2+2 Ministerial Dialogues** between Foreign and Defense Ministers.
4. India received **Strategic Trade Authorization Tier 1 (STA-1)** status for easier access to US military technology in 2018.
5. **iCET & INDUS-X:** Landmark initiatives for co-developing advanced jet engines, armored vehicles, and space tech.
6. **Counter-Terrorism:** Eg. US support for designating Pakistan-based militants as **global terrorists** at the UN.

Economic

1. **India's trade surplus with the US narrowed to $34.4 billion in 2025-26 from $40.89 billion in the previous fiscal year.**
2. The bilateral trade between both countries **stood at $149.84 bn in 2025-26.**
3. USA is the **3rd largest investor** in India with cumulative FDI inflows of **$70.65 billion** (2000-2025).
4. **According to the CII, about 163** Indian companies present in the US have created over **USD 40 billion in tangible investments in the country.**

Energy:

1. **Civil Nuclear Cooperation (2008):** Both sides have started the preparatory work on site in India for **6 AP 1000 reactors** to be built by Westinghouse.
2. **Strategic energy partnership:** Both countries launched the **US-India Climate and Clean Energy Agenda 2030 Partnership** during the Leaders' Summit on Climate in 2021.
3. **Global Biofuels Alliance 2023:** Sustainable biofuels in the transportation sector.
4. **Supply Chain Resilience:** Eg. Expansion of **semiconductor hubs** and GPU facilities in India under the **iCET** framework.

Strategic:

1. **Indo-Pacific Stability:** Both nations collaborate to ensure a free, open, and inclusive maritime order through **QUAD.**
2. **Global Governance:** Eg. US support for India's **permanent UNSC seat** and entry into the Nuclear Suppliers Group.
3. **IMEC Corridor:** Joint support for the **India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor** to bypass traditional bottlenecks.
4. **I2U2 Engagement:** Working with Israel and the UAE to address global food and energy security.
5. Participation in the **Indo-Pacific Economic Framework** to harmonize trade and tax standards.

Science & Technology:

1. **Initiative on Critical and Emerging Technologies 2022 (iCET):** Cooperation in areas of AI, quantum computing, etc.
2. **Critical Mineral Partnership:** To boost global critical energy and mineral supply chains.
3. **Collaboration in space:** NASA to train ISRO astronauts aiming for a **joint ISS mission in 2024.**
    a. **Artemis Accord:** For collaboration in planetary exploration and research.
    b. **NASA ISRO Synthetic Aperture Radar(NISAR):** For understanding changes in Earth's ecosystem and other environmental changes.

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Frictional Points in Relationship:

1. India-Pakistan "hyphenation": Eg. Trump's offer of mediation on Kashmir and claim of stopping Operation Sindoor.
2. Differing Geopolitical Priorities
   a. India's strong focus on **neighbourhood stability (Pakistan, China, Afghanistan)** doesn't always align with U.S. strategic theatre priorities.
   b. U.S. withdrawal from **Afghanistan** (2021) and its aftermath posed regional security concerns for India.
   c. **West Asia** - India's energy and connectivity interests in **Iran (Chabahar Port)** have faced hurdles due to U.S. sanctions. Eg. **India-based Gabbaro Ship Services sanctioned** by the US.
   d. **Trade and Tariff Disputes.**
   e. The U.S. revoked India's **GSP (Generalized System of Preferences)** benefits in 2019, citing a lack of "equitable access."
   f. Disputes over **data localization**, e-commerce rules, and price caps on medical devices (like stents).
   g. **Trump's MAGA campaign** conflicts with India's "China-plus-one" strategy. Eg. Trump discouraging Apple from expanding manufacturing in India.
   h. **Strategic Autonomy vs. Strategic Convergence.**
   i. India's **non-alignment/multi-alignment policy** occasionally conflicts with U.S. expectations, especially regarding **Russia** and **Iran.**
   j. India's continued purchase of **Russian S-400 missile systems** led to U.S. CAATSA sanctions concerns (though a waiver was given).
   k. India's engagement with **SCO and BRICS** despite US-Russia tensions.
   l. **Human Rights and Domestic Policies**: Eg. Congressional hearings on **"democratic backsliding"** in India create public-relations challenges.
   m. Stringent **US immigration policies and H-1B limits** hamper the competitiveness of India's IT sector. Eg. **increase in H1B Visa Fees** ($100,000 fee).
   n. **Data Sovereignty:** India's insistence on data localization (DPDP Act) conflicts with US tech giants' business models.
   o. **IPR Standards:** US places India on the "Priority Watch List" for perceived weak patent protection in pharmaceuticals. Eg. Clash over **Section 3(d)** of the Indian Patent Act.
   p. **Structural asymmetries in influence and communication**: India's institutional footprint in Washington lags behind its ambitions. (**Amitabh Mattoo**).

Way Forward:

1. **Institutionalize iCET:** Ensure technology transfers are insulated from political shifts through long-term **SoSA (Security of Supply)** pacts.
2. **Comprehensive FTA:** Transition the 2026 Interim Deal into a **Full Bilateral Trade Agreement** by 2028.
3. **Sign Totalization Treaty:** Resolve the social security issue to benefit the mobile Indian IT workforce.
4. **Harmonize AI Ethics:** Lead global discourse on **AI safety** through a joint US-India standards board.
5. **Bridge Perception Gaps:** Increase the frequency of **Track-1.5 dialogues** to address human rights and democratic governance concerns.
6. **Stabilize Energy Trade:** Formalize long-term **fixed-price LNG contracts** to protect India from global price volatility.
7. Actively pursue **co-production** and **co-development** of defense technologies like **advanced surveillance systems**, **cybersecurity, and drone technology.**
8. Rediscovering the **moral purpose** of their partnership - shaping a democratic, pluralist, and rules-based world order. (**Amitabh Mattoo**).

As U.S. President Bush once said, "The world will see what two great democracies can do when they trust each other."

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India-China Relations:

India-China relations are a journey from **'Inch towards Miles'. INCH is 'India-China',** while **MILES is 'Millennium of Exceptional Synergy'. - PM Modi**

EAM **Dr. S. Jaishankar,** in his book **'The India Way: Strategies for an Uncertain World,'** argued that managing China is about **realism, agility, and strategic clarity.**

Recent news

- On **75 years of diplomatic ties**, the Chinese President called for a **"Dragon-Elephant tango"** for a vision of peaceful and cooperative relations between China and India.
- Agreement reached to resume **data-sharing on rivers** and restart **Kailash Mansarovar Yatra** by summer 2025.
- The **23rd Special Representatives' meeting** and **the Vice Minister-Foreign Secretary Meeting** were held, and both agreed to enhance **practical cooperation** along the border.
- During the meeting of foreign ministers in Delhi, both sides agreed on **3-Ds approach-disengagement, de-escalation, and de-induction** & **3 mutuals of respect, sensitivity, and interest.**
- In May 2026, India relaxed **FDI norms** for **overseas companies** (not registered in land-border countries) that have a Chinese or Hong Kong shareholding of **up to 10%.**
- China currently accounts for only **0.32%** of India's total **FDI inflows.**

History:

1. **On 1 April, 1950, India became the first non-socialist bloc country to establish diplomatic relations** with the People's Republic of China.
2. **Panchsheel Agreement was signed between India and China on 29 April 1954. Five Principles:**
   a. Mutual respect for territorial integrity and sovereignty
   b. Mutual non-aggression
   c. Mutual non-interference
   d. Equality and mutual benefit
   e. Peaceful coexistence
3. While the **India-China border conflict in 1962** was a serious setback to ties, **Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi's landmark visit in 1988** began a phase of improvement in bilateral relations.
4. **Agreement on the Maintenance of Peace and Tranquility** along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in 1993.



Major Issues:

1. Rising **Chinese assertiveness and a shift in US stance** (under the **U.S. National Security Strategy 2025,** China is no longer framed as a systemic rival but primarily as an economic competitor) have **narrowed strategic space** for India. **(Ashok K. Kantha)**

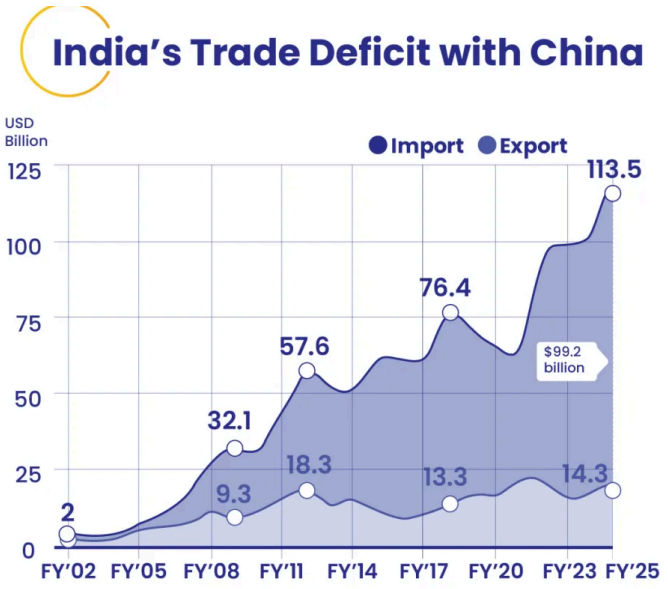
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2. **Boundary Issue: The 3,488 km Line of Actual Control (LAC) remains undefined and disputed, leading to frequent standoffs.**
   a. China occupies **38,000 sq km of Aksai Chin** and claims **~90,000 sq km of Arunachal Pradesh ("South Tibet")**.
   b. Strategy of **"salami slicing"** through **dual-use villages** alters ground realities incrementally.
   c. **Friction points** like **Depsang Plains and Charding-Ninglung Nala** remain unresolved.
   d. **Western Sector (Ladakh):** India considers the **Johnson Line (of 1865),** whereas China claims the **Macartney-McDonald Line of 1899.**
   e. **Middle sector (Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand):** Largely undisputed area.
   f. **Eastern Sector (Arunachal Pradesh and Sikkim):** China claims the state of **AP as part of the Tibetan Autonomous Region.** LAC in this region is along the **McMahon line** drawn during the **Simla Convention of 1914.**

2025 developments

- **Stability was maintained along the LAC** with reduced immediate tensions.
- Creation of new mechanisms.
- **Expert Group** for **boundary delimitation/demarcation.**
- **Working Group** for **border management.**
- **Military-level mechanisms** in **Eastern & Middle sectors.**
- Adoption of a **sectoral approach** and push for **"early harvest" agreements**.
- Renewed reference to the **2005 Agreement on Political Parameters**.
- **Partial decoupling of the border issue** from overall bilateral relations.

1. **China-Pakistan Nexus**
   a. **China's close ties with Pakistan**, including infrastructure development in **Pakistan-Occupied Kashmir (PoK)** under **CPEC**, threaten Indian sovereignty.
   b. **Diplomatic support** to Pakistan. Eg. China backing Pakistan's proposal for an independent probe into the Pahalgam Attack.
2. **Water Resource Disputes:**
   a. **There's no water-sharing treaty** between the two countries, and following the Doklam standoff, **China stopped releasing hydrological data on the Brahmaputra.**
   b. **China has plans to construct a super dam in Medog County, which is located near Arunachal Pradesh in India.**
3. **Economic Issues:**
   a. India's trade deficit with China hit an all-time high of **$112.16 billion** in March 2026.
   b. **Production Dependence:** 98.5% of Indian imports from China are industrial goods, making Indian manufacturing vulnerable to Chinese supply shocks.
   c. **Market Access Barriers:** Indian IT and pharmaceutical firms face opaque regulatory hurdles (Non-Tariff Barriers) in the Chinese domestic market.
4. **Opposition to India's Global Aspirations**



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a. China blocks India's entry into the **NSG (Nuclear Suppliers Group)** and opposes its **permanent seat in the UN Security Council**.
b. Repeatedly **vetoes UN sanctions** on Pakistan-based terrorists (Eg. Masood Azhar - until 2019).

5. **One Belt One Road Initiative:** Launched in **2013,** BRI aims to link **Southeast Asia, Central Asia, the Gulf region, Africa, and Europe** with a network of land and sea routes.

Major Projects:

1. **China Pakistan Economic Corridor:** A US$62 billion project connects Kashgar in China's Xinjiang province to Gwadar in Pakistan's Baluchistan province.



Implications for India:

a. Violation of **territorial integrity**(passing through Gilgit Baltistan).
b. **Increased Chinese military presence:** China placed over 30,000 army personnel in occupied Kashmir.
c. **Gwadar dilemma for India** (proximity to the **Strait of Hormuz** - responsible for the movement of **84% of India's oil imports**).

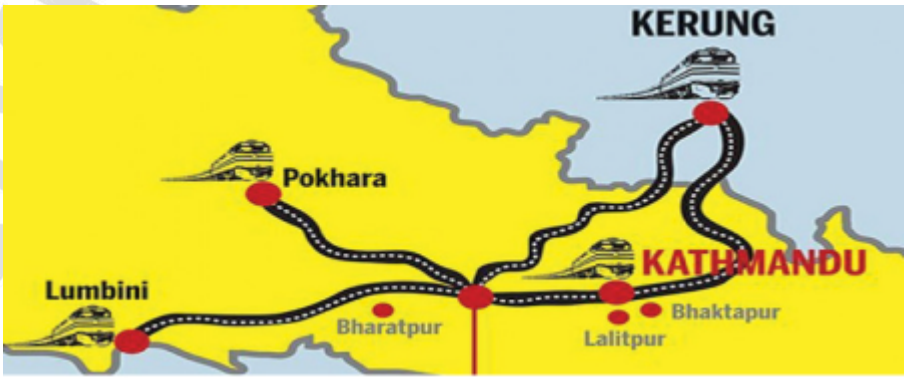
2. **China Myanmar Economic Corridor:** Connects China's Yunnan Province with Mandalay, Kyaukphyu SEZ on the Bay of Bengal, and Yangon in Myanmar.

Implications for India:

a. **Reducing China's "Malacca Dilemma"** and increasing access to the Bay of Bengal region.
b. Stiff competition for Indian projects like **Kaladan multi-modal transit project, IMT** project, etc.
c. Security implications due to Chinese alleged **links to insurgent groups like NSCN-IM**, Arakan Army, etc.

3. **Trans Himalayan Economic Corridor.**

Implications for India:



a. **Reduced trade dependence on India:** Nepal's imports from China have increased by 34.8%(2023-2024).
b. **Proximity to Indian Border**: The Kerung Kathmandu corridor brings Chinese infrastructure within **100 kilometers of the Indian border.**
c. **Water Disputes Potential:** Around **45% of Indian irrigation** in the Indo-Gangetic plain depends on water from the Himalayan rivers.

4. **Maritime Silk Road: Implications for India:**
a. **Strategic Encirclement and "String of Pearls" Theory:** Hambantota in Sri Lanka, Gwadar in Pakistan, and Kyaukpyu in Myanmar.
b. **Impact on Regional Initiatives:** Challenge to India's **SAGAR Initiative** and vision of Free, Open and Inclusive Indo-Pacific.



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c. **Increased surveillance:** Eg. **Presence of Yuan Wang 5(2022)** within 750 km of India's missile test site.

China and India's Neighbourhood:

Neighbour	Relations with China
Nepal	**Infrastructure Investments:** • **The China-Nepal Railway,** which is planned to link Lhasa in Tibet to Kathmandu. **Trade Relations and Preferential Access:** • **Trans Himalayan Economic Corridor** **Defense and Security Cooperation:** • Joint military exercise named **"Sagarmatha Friendship" in Nepal.**
Sri Lanka	**Infrastructure Investments:** • As part of the Maritime Silk Route (MSR) policy, **China built Colombo and Hambantota ports (99 yr lease to China).** • Chinese collaboration in satellite launching activities with **Supreme SAT (Pvt.), Sri Lanka's only satellite operator.** **Trade Relations and Preferential Access:** • **Sri Lanka has a total foreign debt of $46.9bn, 52% of which is owed to China, its largest lender.** **Defense and Security Cooperation:** • Defense purchases from China include **112-meter patrol vessels, the P625, Karakorum-8 (K-8) trainer jets, Type 85-II and Type 96 main battle tanks, etc.**
Maldives	**Infrastructure Investments:** • **China-Maldives Friendship Bridge:** connects the capital Malé with the neighboring islands of Hulhulé and Hulhumalé. • **Velana International Airport expansion.** **Trade Relations and Preferential Access:** • Both concluded **an FTA in 2017.** • **Maldives already owes US$1.3 billion to China, which represents the largest percentage of its debt.** **Defense and Security Cooperation:** • Maldives has signed a **defense agreement with China for obtaining non-lethal weapons and training.**
Myanmar	**Infrastructure Investments:** • **China-Myanmar Oil and Gas Pipelines run** from Myanmar's Rakhine State to Kunming in China's Yunnan province. • **China-Myanmar Economic Corridor (CMEC):** As part of CMEC, China is developing the **Kyaukphyu SEZ.** **Trade Relations and Preferential Access:** • The bilateral trade is roughly **1/3rd of the total trade of Myanmar.** • **Major source of FDI:** Eg. Invested in a deep-sea port at **Kyaukphyu.** **Defense and Security Cooperation:**

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Neighbour	Relations with China
	• China has supplied Myanmar's navy with ships and submarines, including **Type 053H frigates and Type 035 Ming-class submarines.** • **According to SIPRI,** Myanmar purchased guns from China between 2010 and 2019, **amounting to $1.3 bn.**
Bangladesh	**Infrastructure Investments:** • **Padma Bridge Rail Link Project.** • **Karnaphuli Tunnel Project.** **Trade Relations and Preferential Access:** • **Duty-free access to 97% of Chinese tariff lines**. • **In 2018, Bangladesh allocated 750 acres of** land for a Chinese industrial park in Chittagong. **Defense and Security Cooperation:** • **Second-largest recipient** of Chinese arms(2019-2023). **$900 Million pledges in 2025** • **$400 million** for the **modernization of Mongla Port.** • **$350 million** for expanding the **Chinese Economic and Industrial Zone (CEIZ)** in Chattogram. • **$150 million** in **technical assistance.**

South China sea:

Harsh V. Pant, "The South China Sea is not just a regional flashpoint; **it is a testing ground for how China seeks to shape the future of global order.**"

Importance of the South China Sea:

1. **Rich oil and gas reserves:** Approximately **3.6 billion barrels of petroleum** and **40.3 trillion cubic feet of natural gas** in the SCS.
2. **Important shipping lane:** One-third of the global shipping passes through it.
3. **Strategic maritime link** between **the Pacific Ocean and the Indian Ocean**.
4. **Remarkable biological diversity**, including **30% of the world's coral reefs**.
5. **Rich fishing grounds**: Account for about **12 percent of global fish catches**.

India's Involvement:

1. **Economic security:** 55% of India's trade with the Indo-Pacific region passes through the waters of the SCS.
2. **Diversifying Energy Resources: ONGC Videsh** had signed a contract with Vietnamese authorities to explore **blocks 127 and 128 off the Spratly Islands.**
3. **Offsetting China's Advantage in the Sino-Indian Border.**
4. **India's Growing Stakes in the Region:**
   a. ASEAN is one of the major trade partners of India with a share of **11% in India's global trade.**
   b. **In May 2019, the Indian Navy, for the first time, conducted joint exercises** with the U.S., Japanese, and Philippine navies in the South China Sea.

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c. **In January 2022,** India reached a deal with the Philippines for the export **of 100 BrahMos supersonic anti-ship missiles.**

5. India's advocacy for **a Rule-Based International Order and Freedom of Navigation.**

Indian Efforts to contain China:

Strengthening Military Capabilities along the LAC:

1. Border Infrastructure: Eg. **Atal Tunnel in Himachal Pradesh,** strategic roads like the **Darbuk-Shyok-DBO Road in Ladakh,** and the **Sela Tunnel in Arunachal Pradesh.**
2. Deployment of advanced weapons systems such as the **Rafale fighter jets, S-400 missile defense systems, and the BrahMos** cruise missile in border regions.

Economic:

1. **"Atmanirbhar Bharat" (Self-Reliant India) policy,** encouraging domestic manufacturing to reduce dependence on Chinese imports.
2. **Revised FDI norms:** The government's ban on Foreign Direct Investments (FDI) through the **automatic route from land border-sharing neighboring countries.**
3. **India banned over 200 Chinese apps,** including popular platforms like **TikTok and WeChat,** citing security and data privacy concerns.

Enhancing Diplomatic Engagements and Alliances:

1. India has strengthened its involvement in the **Quad with the United States, Japan, and Australia.**
2. India has intensified its diplomatic engagement with **ASEAN countries and in the South China Sea.**

Expanding Naval Presence and Maritime Security in the Indo-Pacific:

1. **Necklace of Diamonds Strategy:** Developing strategic bases Eg. **Changi Naval Base (Singapore), Sabang Port(Indonesia), Duqm Port(Oman), Chabahar Port(Iran).**
2. Military upgradation of Andaman and Nicobar Islands, located **just 55 km away from the Chinese-occupied Coco Island of Myanmar.**
3. **The great Nocibar project.**

Way Forward:

1. **Deepening Strategic Dialogue:** Regular engagement through **SCO and BRICS** can help address the **"security dilemma".**
2. Both should seek to adapt the **principle of "mutual and equal security,"** i.e., military deployments of mutually acceptable size near the border.
3. **Track 2 diplomacy can provide alternative channels for dialogue** and help in **expanding "trust society"** by facilitating personnel exchanges at all levels and in all fields of society.
4. **Strengthen Border Infrastructure**
   a. India needs to build and **maintain a credible military deterrence capability** in the mountains and the Indian Ocean.
   b. **Proper Implementation of Vibrant Villages Programme:** It will ensure seamless connectivity with bordering districts.
5. **Leveraging China+1 strategy** to diversify supply chains & attract FDI inflows.
6. Regional integration through **BIMSTEC** and **timely completion of projects** in the neighborhood.
7. **Calibrated engagement** to reduce immediate risks while strengthening **asymmetric deterrence** and accelerating **domestic technological and industrial capabilities.** (**Ashok Kantha**).

As PM Modi stated, "Competition must not turn into conflict." Strategic maturity is key to managing bilateral differences peacefully.

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The future lies in **"competitive cooperation"**, where economic pragmatism coexists with sovereign red lines and calibrated deterrence at the LAC.

India Russia Relations:

Russia's Ambassador in New Delhi, Nikolay R. Kudashev said, "The Indo-Russian cooperation that is built on mutual trust and enriching each other is a living formula for the rest of the world."

PM Narendra Modi, "India gives top priority to its relations with Russia. In this rapidly changing world, our relationship has become more relevant."

The **India-Russia** relations were elevated to **"special and privileged strategic partnership" in 2010.**

Recent news

- 23rd India-Russia Annual Summit (Dec 2025).
  - India and Russia signed **16 agreements** covering defence, trade, economy, healthcare, and culture.
  - Leaders endorsed a **new economic cooperation programme** targeting **$100 billion in trade by 2030**.
- India-Russia **RELOS Defence Pact** Operationalised (Jan 2026): Allows **deployment of up to 3,000 troops, 5 warships, 10 aircraft** in each other's territory.
- Agreement to **fast-track India-EAEU Free Trade Agreement negotiations &** parallel push for **India-Russia Bilateral Investment Treaty (BIT)**.
- Negotiations finalized for the lease of a **third Akula-class nuclear-powered attack submarine** (Chakra-III) to the Indian Navy.

Areas of Cooperation/Significance of Russia:

Geopolitical

1. **Strategic Autonomy Buffer:** Russia acts as a reliable partner that allows India to balance its growing ties with the West.
2. **Balancing China**: Eg. Russia's support for India's SCO membership.
3. **Eurasian Stability:** Shared interest in a stable Afghanistan and preventing the spread of radicalism across Central Asia.

Defence and Strategic Cooperation

1. **India's largest defense partner** (accounts for ~45% of India's arms imports).
2. **S-400 Triumf**, **INS Vikramaditya**, **BrahMos missile** (jointly developed), AK-203 rifles.
3. Regular bilateral military exercises: **INDRA (Army/Navy)** and **Avi-INDRA (Air Force)**.
4. Cooperation in joint production and technology transfer under **Make in India**.



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Connectivity

1. The **International North-South Transport Corridor** provides a 40% shorter route than the Suez Canal and bypasses Pakistan.
2. **Chennai-Vladivostok Maritime Corridor** became **operational in 2024**, reducing transit time from **40 to 24 days** and cutting shipping distance to **5,600 nautical miles** compared to the European route.
3. Joint engagement in the **Arctic Council (Northern Sea Route)** to secure future energy routes and scientific research.

Nuclear Energy

1. **Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant** (KNPP) is the only project in India with foreign collaboration.
2. **Long-term roadmap for 10 more reactors, under IAEA safeguards.**

Space Cooperation

1. India's first satellite **Aryabhata (1975)** was launched by the USSR.
2. Collaboration between **ISRO and Roscosmos**, including training of Indian Gaganyaan astronauts in Russia.

Trade and Economic Ties

1. Bilateral trade crossed **$68 billion in 2025**, driven by **oil, defense, and fertilizers**.
2. India also participated in the **Eastern Economic Forum** and extended a $1billion line of credit for the development of the **far-right region of Russia**.
3. India and Russia use **rupee-rouble trade, bypassing SWIFT** for 99% of trade.
4. **Fertilizer Security:** Long-term contracts for potash and phosphate fertilizers are vital for India's agricultural sector.

Energy Security

1. Russian companies like **Rosneft, Gazprom** invest in India's energy sector.
2. India invests in Russian oil fields (Eg. **Sakhalin-I, Vankor**).
3. **St. Petersburg Declaration:** Both countries agreed to **joint exploration of hydrocarbons** in the Arctic region.

Multilateral Cooperation

1. Common platforms: **BRICS, SCO, RIC (Russia-India-China), G20, UN**.
2. Russia supports India's candidature for **permanent membership in UNSC** and **NSG**.

Cultural and Educational Linkages

1. Over **15,000 Indian students** (mostly in medicine) study in Russian universities.
2. 2025 was declared the **India-Russia Cultural Year**.

> International North-South Transport Corridor:
>
> INSTC is a **multi-modal transportation** route linking the **Indian Ocean and the Persian Gulf to the Caspian Sea** via Iran and onward to northern Europe via **St. Petersburg in Russia**.
>
> **Route**: St. Petersburg (Russia) → Kazakhstan → Turkmenistan → Bandar Abbas port (Iran) → Mumbai port (India).
>
> **In 2024, Russia sent two trains carrying coal to India for the first time.**
>
> The INSTC **reduces transit times to around 25 days,** compared to approximately 40-45 days via the Suez Canal.

Points of Friction in the relation:

1. According to SIPRI, Russia's share in Indian arms imports dropped from **70% to under 45%** in a decade.

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2. **Deepening of India-US relations:**
   a. Exemplified in the **India-US nuclear deal in 2008, the US emerged as the top arms supplier** to India by overtaking Russia, and India-US Foundational agreements such **LEMOA, COMCASA, BECA**.
   b. Indo-Pacific: Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov called Indo-Pacific **"an artificially imposed construct" being promoted by the US, Australia and Japan.**
3. **Russia-China-Pakistan Axis:**
   a. Russia's "No-Limits" partnership with China is potentially limiting its neutrality during **Sino-Indian border** clashes.
   b. Russia **overtook Saudi Arabia as the leading supplier** of Oil to China.
   c. China has also **received an S-400 missile defense system** from Russia.
   d. In 2014, **Moscow removed the arms embargo imposed on Pakistan** and sale of Mi-35 helicopters.
   e. Russia has also funded a **new gas pipeline between Lahore and Karachi** via a $2-billion loan.
   f. Pakistan has already granted permission to **Russia to use its Gwadar port** under the CPEC.
4. **Slow Connectivity Implementation-** Infrastructure gaps and geopolitical instability in Iran/Caucasus delay the full operationalization of the INSTC.
5. **Issues In India-Russia Trade Partnership:**
   a. **Trade deficit**: over $60 billion.
   b. N**on-energy bilateral trade remains below potential**. Issues like **payment settlement** due to Western sanctions, lack of banking channels, and logistics hamper expansion.
   c. **Russian oil exporters are requesting payments from Indian refineries in Chinese currency**, while the use of the rupee has remained restricted.
   d. **Payment Deadlocks:** Over **$40 billion in Rupee assets** remained "trapped" in Vostro accounts due to a massive trade imbalance favoring Russia.
6. **Divergence on the Indo-Pacific Strategy:** Russia views the "Indo-Pacific" and "QUAD" as **Western-led containment tools**, while India champions them.
7. **Lagging Technological Collaboration**: Russia's capacity to provide **cutting-edge tech** (especially in AI, semiconductors, cyber) lags behind Western partners like the US or EU.
8. **The Ukraine crisis and India: 3-dilemmas -**
   a. Expectations of a close **strategic partner in the US**.
   b. The need to maintain **strong ties with Moscow**.
   c. To avoid any perception of proximity to the **emerging Sino-Russian axis**.

Way Forward:

1. **Deepen Strategic Autonomy-Based Partnership**: Strengthen a **non-Western multipolar world** vision by reaffirming ties based on **strategic autonomy**, not bloc politics.
2. **Rupee Reinvestment:** Encourage Russia to reinvest its Rupee surplus into **Indian infrastructure and PLI schemes** to balance trade. **(C. Raja Mohan)**
3. **Diversify Beyond Energy:** Transition the relationship from a "crude oil silo" to include **Agri-tech, Fintech, and Pharma** exports. **(Harsh V. Pant)**
4. **Institutionalize RELOS:** Use the new logistics pact to conduct joint **HADR (Disaster Relief)** operations in the Indian Ocean.
5. **Strategic Neutrality:** Maintain a "principled distance" from the Ukraine conflict while acting as a **diplomatic bridge** for peace.
6. **Joint Arctic Research:** Scale up Indian presence in the **Russian Arctic** to study climate change and secure mineral rights.
7. **EAEU-India FTA:** Fast-track the **Free Trade Agreement** with the Eurasian Economic Union to reduce non-tariff barriers. **(Arvind Subramanian)**

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8. **Track-II Cultural Connect:** Launch "Indo-Russian Youth Summits" to counter the **generational disconnect** in the post-Cold War era. **(S.D. Muni)**
9. **Operationalize a "Skilled Migration Corridor" to the Far East.**

"India-Russia ties have stood the test of time," said PM Modi - a testimony to trust-based strategic continuity in uncertain geopolitics.

In an age of "**strategic hedging**," India's Russia policy must reflect realism, resilience, and respect for historical friendship.

India Japan Relations:

Shinzo Abe, in his book "Towards a beautiful nation," termed India as Japan's natural ally as they have no conflict of strategic interest and share common goals to build institutionalized cooperation and stability in Asia.

Recent News

15th India-Japan Annual PM Summit (Aug 2025)

- Adoption of **"Joint Vision for the Next Decade"** - Includes **8 priority areas** like **security, economy, clean energy, and technology cooperation**.
- **13 key agreements** and a commitment of **10 trillion yen (USD 68 billion) investment** in the next decade.
- **Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation,** institutionalization of **NSA-level dialogue.**
- **DRDO-ATLA collaboration** on missile defence and maritime surveillance.
- **Next-Gen Mobility Partnership** across transport sectors, including the Bullet Train.
- **Action Plan on Human Resource Exchange** to enable mobility of 5 lakh people.
- Collaboration on the Chandrayaan-5 **lunar exploration mission**.

Areas of Cooperation:

1. **Current Status:** Upgraded to a **Special Strategic and Global Partnership (2014),** reflecting deep political, economic, and security convergence.
2. **Geopolitical cooperation**
   a. India's **Act East Policy** and **Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI)** align with Japan's **Free and Open Indo-Pacific (FOIP)** vision.
   b. Cooperation through QUAD.
   c. Cooperation under the **Supply Chain Resilience Initiative** to diversify supply chains and reduce over-reliance on a single country. (**China+1 strategy**).
   d. **Cooperate closely in G4 on UNSC reforms.**
3. **Economic Cooperation:**
   a. Japan is the **5th largest investor in the Indian economy** with 6.6% of India's total FDI inflows.
   b. **India-Japan Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA)** (2011) covers **trade in goods, services, investment, and IPR.**



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c. **Bilateral trade: USD 25.17 billion (FY 2024-25)**
d. **India-Japan Industrial Competitiveness Partnership (IJICP)** (2021) enhances India's **manufacturing and supply chain resilience.**

4. **Security Cooperation:**
   a. **2025 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation** and **2015 defence pacts** on equipment transfer and classified information.
   b. **2+2 Ministerial Dialogue** institutionalizes coordination between foreign and defence ministers.
   c. **Acquisition and Cross-Servicing Agreement signed in 2020** to facilitate reciprocal provision of supplies and services between the defense forces.
   d. **Joint exercises: JIMEX (naval)**, **Dharma Guardian (army)**; multilateral participation in **MALABAR** and **MILAN.**
5. **Development Cooperation:**
   a. **Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail (MAHSR)** is a flagship connectivity project.
   b. **India-Japan Act East Forum** promotes joint development of **Northeast India. (**Japan is the only country undertaking developmental work in India's sensitive North-East**).**
6. **Connectivity:**
   a. Linking South Asia to Southeast Asia through India's **"Act East" and Japan's "Partnership for Quality Infrastructure" policy.**
   b. **Asia-Africa Growth Corridor (AAGC)** aims to bring East Asia, Southeast Asia, and South Asia closer to Africa.
   c. **India Vision 2025** involves the development of the Northeast region and acts as a convergence point for India's **Act East Policy and Japan's FOIP policy.**
7. **Energy, Science and Tech:**
   a. India-Japan **Clean Energy Partnership** (CEP) was announced in 2022 for economic growth and addressing climate change.
   b. India-Japan **Agreement for Cooperation in the Peaceful Uses of Nuclear Energy** (2017).
   c. ISRO and JAXA are working on a joint **Lunar Polar Exploration Mission** (LUPEX).

Frictional Points in the relationship:

1. **Geopolitical**
   a. **Russia Factor: India participated in the Vostok Exercises**, which were held close to South Kuril Island (a disputed territory between Russia and Japan).
   b. **Balancing between QUAD and BRICS:** India has long adopted a non-aligned approach as opposed to the pro-US foreign policy stances of Japan and Australia.
2. **Slow Progress in High-Speed Rail (Bullet Train Project)** due to land acquisition delays, cost escalations, and timeline slippages.
3. Despite the **India-Japan Investment Promotion Partnership**, actual FDI flows remain limited due to **red tape** and regulatory uncertainty in India.
4. **Technology Transfer Constraints**
   a. Japan remains cautious about **transferring advanced defense or dual-use technology** due to its pacifist constitution and strict export control
   b. Both India and Japan have **diverging interests** concerning issues like **E-commerce rules (Osaka track) and the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership.**
5. **Trade Imbalance**
   a. India runs a **large trade deficit** with Japan. (FY 2023-24: India's imports from Japan ~$18B; exports ~$6B).
   b. Limited access to the Japanese market for **agricultural and pharmaceutical products** continues to be a concern.
6. **Different Priorities in Indo-Pacific Vision**

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   a. While both endorse a **Free and Open Indo-Pacific**, Japan's approach is more closely aligned with the **US and G7**, whereas India maintains **strategic autonomy**.
   b. **Defense cooperation** lacks depth in areas like **joint production**, **combat platforms**, or **defense exports**. Eg. Delays in the **US-2 amphibious aircraft deal.**
7. **Limited People-to-People Connectivity** - Language barriers and lack of mutual awareness hinder **soft power engagement**.

Way Forward:

1. **Strengthen Indo-Pacific Convergence**
   a. Institutionalize strategic alignment under **Free and Open Indo-Pacific (FOIP)** by co-developing connectivity corridors in **ASEAN, Africa, and the IOR**.
   b. As Prof. C. Raja Mohan notes, India and Japan can be **"anchor democracies in the Indo-Pacific"**, balancing China's rise.
2. **Deepen Defense & Security Cooperation**
   a. Operationalize long-pending projects like the **US-2 amphibious aircraft deal** and enhance **maritime domain awareness sharing**.
   b. Expand **joint exercises (Eg. Dharma Guardian, Malabar)** and co-develop **non-lethal dual-use technologies** under Japan's updated export laws.
3. Establish a **Bilateral Investment Facilitation Mechanism** to resolve FDI-related regulatory issues.
4. Adopt a **Japan-style project management model** to meet deadlines and build trust for future mega investments.
5. Scholars like **Prof. Takenori Horimoto** suggested **sectoral working groups** for bilateral trade alignment under the **Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA)**.

India-Japan ties should serve as a model of **'Asian multilateralism without dominance',** ensuring **equity and strategic balance** in the region.

European Union:

The European Union is a group of **28 countries that operate as a cohesive economic and political block.**

History:

Origin and Evolution of the EU

1. Roots in the **European Coal and Steel Community (1951)** and the **Treaty of Rome (1957)**, aimed at making war between European neighbors "not only unthinkable but materially impossible."
2. The **Maastricht Treaty (1993)** officially established the European Union and introduced Euro and European citizenship.
3. **Expansion:** Evolved from 6 founding members to 27, surviving the exit of the UK (Brexit) in 2020.
4. **Structure:** Operates through the **European Commission** (executive), **European Parliament** (legislative), and **European Council** (strategic direction).
5. **The Eurozone:** A subset of 20 countries using the **Euro** as their official currency.

Evolution of EU-India Relations

1. India was one of the first countries to establish diplomatic relations **(1962)** with the European Economic Community (EEC).
2. **1994 Cooperation Agreement:** A foundational legal framework that moved the relationship beyond trade to include political and social cooperation.
3. Ties were elevated to a **"Strategic Partnership" (2004).**

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4. The **Broad-based Trade and Investment Agreement (BTIA)** negotiations began in 2007 but were suspended due to gaps in ambition.
5. The **Trade and Technology Council** was established in 2022, making India only the second partner (after the US) to have such a high-level tech mechanism with the EU.
6. **The "Mother of All Deals":** India and the EU concluded political negotiations for a comprehensive FTA, with EU leaders attending India's Republic Day as Chief Guests.

India EU Cooperation:

1. **Strategic Multipolarity** - Both powers serve as "stabilizing poles" to prevent a bipolar world dominated by US-China rivalry.
2. The EU is **India's largest trading partner** for goods, with trade reaching **$137 billion** (2024-25). FTA is expected to unlock **$75 billion** in additional exports.
3. The EU contributes **17%** of India's total FDI, supporting millions of jobs in the manufacturing sector.
4. **Technological Sovereignty** - Collaboration on AI, 6G, and semiconductors via the **TTC** ensures digital independence from external monopolies.
5. **Maritime Security** - Mutual interest in keeping the **Indo-Pacific "free and open"** against coercive maritime statecraft.
6. **Green Industrial Transition:** Linking the EU's "Green Deal" with India's "Net Zero 2070" to scale clean technology.
7. **Connectivity:** The **India-Middle East-Europe Corridor** offers a transparent, sustainable alternative to China's Belt and Road.
8. **Demographic Complementarity:** India's young workforce addresses Europe's labor shortages through legal, high-skilled migration and mobility pacts.
9. **Space Cooperation:** Eg. Successful launch of the **Proba-3 mission** for the European Space Agency by ISRO in 2024.
10. **Developmental Partnership:**
    a. Both have become key stakeholders in global efforts to combat climate change through the **Clean Energy and Climate Change Partnership, 2017.**
    b. India supported the **European Green Deal** (to make the EU **carbon-neutral by 2050)** and collaboration with France on **the International Solar Alliance and the One Planet Summit.**
11. **Defense and Security:**
    a. **The Information Fusion Centre: Indian Ocean Region in New Delhi (IFC - IOR)** has linked up with the Maritime Security Centre - Horn of Africa (**MSC - HOA) of the EU.**
    b. India and the EU adopted a declaration to counter terrorism at the **14th India-EU summit.**

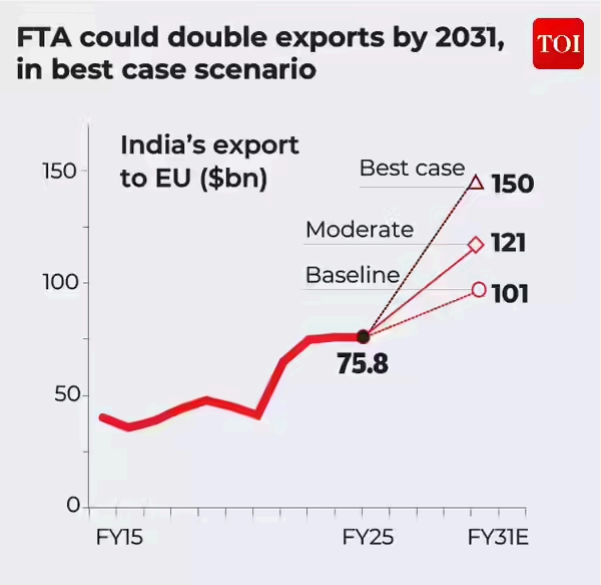
Points of Friction:

1. **Trade:** Currently, India accounts for only **1.9% of the EU's total trade in goods, well behind China (13.8%).**
2. **China Balancing Act:** Occasional misalignment in "de-risking" strategies-Europe prioritizes economic balance while India focuses on strategic containment.
3. **Carbon Border Tax (CBAM):** The EU's tax on carbon-intensive imports is seen by India as a "protectionist barrier." Eg. Indian steel exporters are facing **20-35% additional charges**.
4. **Regulatory Hurdles:** Stringent European sanitary standards frequently lead to rejection of Indian exports. Eg. Periodic bans on **Indian rice and mangoes**.
5. **Data Adequacy Status:** The EU has not yet designated India as "data secure," hindering free digital business data flows.
6. **Divergence on Russia:** Eg. EU's criticism of India's **sharp rise in Russian oil imports** despite G7 and EU sanctions.

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7. **Human Rights Posturing:** Resolutions in the European Parliament on **Manipur or Kashmir** cause diplomatic irritation.
8. **Labor & Sustainability Clauses:** EU's insistence on linking trade to strict labor and environment rules is seen as "regulatory leverage."
9. **Migration Sensitivities:** Growing anti-immigrant sentiment in the EU complicates the implementation of "Migration and Mobility" pacts.

Key Provisions of the India-EU FTA (2026):



- **Tariff Elimination on Goods: The** EU eliminates duties on **99.5%** of Indian export value. India eliminates duties on **97.5%** of EU export value.
- **Services Liberalization:** EU opens 144 sub-sectors **(Eg. IT, Engineering).** India opens 102 sub-sectors **(Eg. Maritime, Telecom).**
- **Professional Mobility: "Migration and Mobility Partnership"** provides Indian professionals (Mode 4) with multi-year visas and student post-study work permits.
- **Agricultural Safeguards:** India excluded sensitive sectors like Dairy, Wheat, and Rice to protect 44% of its workforce.
- **MSME-Friendly Rules of Origin** - Flexible rules with **self-certification** and benefits for sectors like **seafood and aluminium value chains**.
- **Automobile Concessions:** India's 110% car tariffs drop to 10% over 5-10 years (subject to a 250,000-unit quota per year).
- **Liquor & Wines:** Indian duties on EU wines slashed from 150% to 75% initially, eventually hitting 25% over 10 years.
- **Labor-Intensive Sectors:** Immediate zero-duty access for Indian textiles, leather, and gems/jewelry **(previously 4-12%).**
- **Symmetry in Pharma:** Removal of 11% tariffs on Indian generics; mutual recognition of GMP (Good Manufacturing Practices).
- **Product Specific Rules (PSR):** Origin rules require substantial processing **(usually 35-40% value addition)** to prevent "trade deflection."
- **Sustainability Chapter:** Binding commitments to the Paris Agreement and workers' rights, though CBAM remains a separate dialogue.

Other Major Initiatives

- **Trade and Technology Council (TTC):** A platform for co-developing AI, semiconductors, and cybersecurity frameworks.
- **Global Gateway:** EU's **€300 billion** infrastructure fund is being utilized for green transport projects in India.
- **Clean Energy and Climate Partnership (CECP):** A framework for offshore wind, gas infrastructure, and hydrogen cooperation.
- **Mobility and Migration Pact:** A framework ensuring legal, safe, and regulated movement of people.

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- **International Solar Alliance (ISA):** The EU as a key partner in India-led efforts to scale solar energy.
- **Horizon Europe:** Providing Indian scientists access to the world's largest research and innovation program.

Way Forward:

1. **Accelerate IMEC:** Fast-track the Middle East corridor to demonstrate its viability as a reliable alternative to Suez.
2. **Co-produce Defence:** Move from "buyer-seller" to joint production of maritime and cybersecurity capabilities.
3. **Civil Society Engagement:** Strengthen university-to-university networks to reduce the "democratic deficit" in bilateral understanding.
4. **A Balanced Global Voice:** Lead joint efforts for Global South debt relief and climate finance at the G20.
   a. Negotiate a "Carbon Credit Reciprocity" where the EU recognizes India's domestic Carbon Market. This can help in offsetting EU taxes through Indian Green Credits.
   b. Digital Infrastructure Alignment: Harmonize the "European Digital Wallet" with India's "Aadhaar/UPI" for seamless trade.

India-Canada Relations:

India and Canada transitioned from diplomatic frost to a **"pragmatic reset"** in 2026.

Recent News

- India and Canada finalised **Terms of Reference (ToR)** to formally restart negotiations for a **Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA)**. (March 2026)
- Agreement involving **C$2.6 billion uranium supply** (via Cameco) to support India's nuclear energy needs.
- **NSA High-Level Meeting:** Indian NSA Ajit Doval met Canadian NSIA Nathalie Drouin in Ottawa (**Feb 7, 2026**) to establish a "clear mandate" for joint security investigations.
- Canadian PM **Mark Carney** concluded a landmark visit to India (**Feb 27-Mar 2, 2026**), the first such visit since the 2023 diplomatic crisis.

Key highlights of the Canadian Prime Minister's visit

Trade & Economic Integration

1. Both nations signed the **Terms of Reference (ToR)** to resume talks on the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA).
2. An ambitious bilateral trade target of **USD 50 billion by 2030** has been set.
3. The **India-Canada CEO Forum** was revived to drive private-sector investment.

Energy & Resource Security

1. **Civil Nuclear Deal:** A **USD 2.6 billion contract** with Canada's Cameco ensures a steady supply of Uranium Ore Concentrates.
2. **Critical Minerals MoU** to secure resilient supply chains for Lithium and Cobalt, aligning with the **G7 Critical Minerals Action Plan**.
3. Canada officially joined the **International Solar Alliance (ISA)** and the **Global Biofuels Alliance (GBA).**

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Strategic & Political Ties

1. The establishment of the first-ever **India-Canada Defence Dialogue** marks a shift toward maritime security cooperation and counter-terrorism intelligence sharing.
2. India formally backed Canada's bid to join the **Indian Ocean Rim Association (IORA)** as a Dialogue Partner.
3. The creation of the **India-Canada Parliament Friendship Group** to stabilize diplomatic relations through direct legislative engagement.

Innovation, Talent & Food Security

1. **ACITI Partnership:** A trilateral MoU between **India, Canada, and Australia** was signed to collaborate on emerging technologies like AI and Quantum Computing.
2. **Research Internships:** An agreement between **AICTE and Mitacs** (Canada) will provide **300 fully-funded research internships** for Indian students in Canadian labs.

Importance of Canada for India

Geopolitical

1. Shared interest in a **"free and open" Indo-Pacific** to counter regional hegemony.
2. **Counter-Terrorism Cooperation:** Eg. The **2026 NSA-level mandate** focuses on dismantling cross-border "gang-terror" networks.
3. **Multilateral Governance:** Cooperation in G20, G7, and the Commonwealth helps reform global trade and data sovereignty.

Energy Security Anchor:

1. Canada is a reliable, rules-based supplier of uranium, oil, and LNG for India's growth.
2. **Critical Mineral Pipeline:** Canada's vast reserves of Lithium and Cobalt are vital for India's **PM E-DRIVE** mission.

Economic

1. In 2024, **India was Canada's 7th largest trading partner,** with **two-way trade worth USD 30.9 billion**, and India maintaining a trade surplus in goods.
2. **Portfolio Investment:** Canadian pension funds (CPPIB, CDPQ) have invested over **$100 billion** in India.
3. **Service Trade:** Services trade reached **$14.15 billion** in 2025, dominated by education-related travel and IT services.
4. **Corporate Presence:** More than **600 Canadian companies** currently operate in India.

Human Capital Pipeline

1. Canada is home to over **1.8 million Canadians of Indian origin** and 1 million NRIs.
2. **Student Mobility:** India remains the largest source of international students in Canada (**4 lakh study permit holders**)

Food Security Synergy:

1. Canada remains the **largest supplier of lentils** to the Indian consumer market.
2. Canada provides roughly **25% of India's Muriate of Potash (MOP).**

Major Challenges in India-Canada Relations

1. **Sovereignty & Security Allegations:** Past accusations regarding extrajudicial activities remain a sensitive "under-the-surface" friction point for both. Eg. 2023 **Nijjar case allegations**.
2. **Organized crime syndicates** operating from Canadian soil. Eg. NIA identified over **20 "persons of interest"** in Canada allegedly coordinating extortion rackets in Punjab.
3. **FTA Hurdles:** Eg. **Indian dairy protections** vs Canadian market access demands.

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4. **Diaspora Politics:** Domestic political compulsions in Canada sometimes influence its foreign policy stance toward India. Eg. comments on Farm laws in the Canadian parliament.
5. **Slow Operationalization:** Converting high-level MoUs into concrete "on-the-ground" projects remains a chronic institutional bottleneck.
6. **Sanitary & Phytosanitary (SPS) Barriers:** Eg. negotiations for the **2026 CEPA** were delayed by disagreements over "weed-seed" fumigation norms for Canadian pulses.
7. **Divergent Data Sovereignty Models:** India's strict data localization laws conflict with Canada's vision for an open digital economy.
8. **Visa Processing Volatility:** Eg. 2025 saw a **15% dip in study permit applications** from India due to prolonged "security background checks."
9. **"Persons of Interest" Row (Oct 2024):** Canada naming the Indian High Commissioner as a "person of interest" led to a total withdrawal of top envoys.

Way Forward

1. Conclude the **Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement** to institutionalize trade.
2. **Critical Mineral JVs:** Facilitate direct investment by Indian PSUs in **Canadian mining assets** for Lithium and Cobalt.
3. **Institutionalizing NSA Dialogues:** Maintain regular, non-public channels between NSAs to resolve "red-line" security issues quietly.
4. **Sub-National Engagement:** Encourage direct "State-to-Province" partnerships (Eg. Gujarat-Alberta) for specialized sectors like energy.
5. **Standardization of Skills:** Create a **Mutual Recognition Agreement (MRA)** for professional qualifications to ease labor mobility.
6. **Multilateral Alignment:** Coordinate stances in the **G20 and IORA** to shape global rules on AI and data sovereignty.

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India UK relations:

From historical complexity to strategic opportunity, India-UK ties represent a balancing act of legacy and modern geopolitical alignment.

Recent News

- PM Modi and PM Starmer adopted the **"Vision 2035"** roadmap during the London Summit, setting the strategic agenda for the next decade.
- **Defence Industrial Roadmap (2025):** Ten-year roadmap for the co-development and co-production of jet engines and complex weapon systems.
- The UK Deputy PM and AI Minister participated in the Delhi **AI Impact Summit**, launching the **India-UK Technology Security Initiative (TSI)**.
- **Climate Finance Initiative (Oct 2025):** Announced during PM Starmer's Mumbai visit to unlock green growth and scale up sustainable investment opportunities.

Key Highlights of the India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA):

- **Duty-Free Access.**
- India gains **99% duty-free access** to the UK market, boosting **textiles, leather, marine products, EVs, and auto components.**
- India will **cut or eliminate duties on 90% of tariff lines** (covering 92% of UK imports), including **cars and alcohol.**
- **Electric vehicle tariffs** will be removed in the **sixth year**, with **zero duties on EVs under £40,000.**
- **Services Sector Liberalization** with **eased visa norms** for professionals in **engineering, architecture, and hospitality.**
- **Double Contribution Convention:** Exempts **Indian professionals and employers** from **UK social security payments** for three years.
- **Agricultural:** Tariff cuts on **processed foods, edible oils, and seafood.**

Areas of Cooperation:

1. **Economic:**
   a. Establishment of **the Joint Economic and Trade Committee** (JETCO) in 2005.
   b. Bilateral trade is $56 billion in 2025-26, intending to double by 2030.
   c. The UK prioritizes strong economic ties with India as part of **its post-Brexit 'Global Britain' strategy.**
2. **Defense and Security:**
   a. Both signed the **Defence and International Security Partnership** in 2015.
   b. At present, **70 companies in the UK supply goods** for aircraft and related equipment, besides supporting platforms like Jaguar, Mirage, and Kiran aircraft.
   c. Joint Exercises include **Ajeya Warrior, Indradhanush, Konkan etc.**
   d. Signing of **Electric Propulsion Capability Partnership** aimed at equipping Indian naval vessels with electric propulsion.
3. **Geopolitical:**
   a. The UK supports India's proposal for **permanent membership of the UNSC**.
   b. Relations elevated to **Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in 2021**.

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   c. **India-UK acting as 'Net Security Provider'** across the Indo-Pacific: Eg. Share information on **grey and dark shipping,** and the **UK joined the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI).**
4. **Energy:**
   a. **Civil Nuclear Cooperation Declaration signed in 2010.**
   b. **Nuclear Collaboration Agreement signed in 2015.**
   c. **India-UK Green Growth Equity Fund** has been established, which helps in the mobilization of institutional investments **in renewable energy.**
5. **Science and Tech: The UK-India Technology Security Initiative (TSI)** was launched to expand cooperation in critical and emerging technologies.
6. **Cultural:**
   a. **The Nehru Centre (TNC)**, established in 1992 in London, is the cultural outreach of the High Commission of India in the UK.
   b. Around **1.8 million people of Indian origin** live in Britain.
   c. **UKIERI Programme (2019)** promotes **student exchange**.

Frictional Points in the relationship:

1. **Colonial Hangover:** "Anti-colonial posturing prevented the establishment from seizing the full range of possibilities with Britain," writes **C Raja Mohan.**
2. **Diverging geopolitical stands:**
   a. **The UK has openly criticized the Russian invasion of Ukraine,** while India maintains good relations with Russia.
   b. **Khalistan Issue: The Five Eyes alliance** investigating India's involvement in the death plot of **Nijjar includes the UK as well.**
3. **High visa fees and restrictive health surcharge**s for Indian students and working professionals in the UK.
4. **Illegal Migrants:** There are **more than 1 lakh illegal Indian immigrants** in the UK. Both the countries have **not signed the migration and mobility agreement**.
5. **Extradition Issues:** The UK's **hesitation to extradite fugitives** like **Vijay Mallya and Nirav Modi** undermines **legal cooperation and mutual trust.**
6. The UK's proposed **Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM)** threatens **Indian exports** such as **steel and aluminum**, seen by India as **disguised protectionism.**
7. **Intellectual Property Rights (IPR):** The UK's insistence on **tighter IP norms** conflicts with India's priority of **affordable medicines and innovation flexibility**

Way Forward:

1. **Implementation Oversight:** Establish a "Joint Implementation Committee" to ensure the **CETA benefits** reach SMEs.
2. **Social Security Agreement:** Fast-track the **Double Contribution Convention** to exempt Indian temporary workers from UK National Insurance.
3. Streamline legal cooperation to resolve the status of **economic fugitives** and rebuild mutual judicial trust.
4. Create a permanent mechanism to monitor and curb **extremist activities** affecting bilateral sovereignty and safety.
5. **Education Harmonization:** Expand the **Mutual Recognition of Qualifications** to include vocational and technical degrees to boost mobility.
6. Conduct more frequent **trilateral naval exercises** (Eg. India-UK-France) to secure the Western Indian Ocean.

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7. Launch a "Living Bridge Fellowship" to connect second-generation Indian-Britons with **India's startup ecosystem**.
8. **Multilateral Synergy:** Jointly lead a **"Commonwealth Digital Mission"** to provide low-cost digital infrastructure to African member nations.

As **PM Modi** noted, "India and the UK are natural partners in progress." Realizing this vision requires consistent political will and trust.

Chagos Islands Handover

- On 22 May 2025, **the UK and Mauritius signed a historic agreement to transfer sovereignty of the Chagos Archipelago to Mauritius**, excluding Diego Garcia, which will remain under UK-US control for 99 years.
- The deal includes a financial package of £101 million annually for Mauritius.
- Diego Garcia continues to host a key military base used jointly by the UK and the US for power projection in the Indian Ocean.

The Chagos agreement is a trilateral win-UK secures its base, Mauritius regains sovereignty, and India gains strategic leverage. It enhances India's regional maritime footprint, counters Chinese assertiveness, and reinforces its image as a principled supporter of decolonization and regional peace in the Indian Ocean.

India France relations:

India and France share a time-tested strategic partnership, rooted in trust, defense cooperation, and convergence on multilateral global challenges.

1. **Diplomatic relations were established after India's Independence.**
2. French aircraft and helicopters like **Ouragan, Mystère, Alize, Alouette, and Jaguar** have been **part of the Indian air fleet since the 1960's.**
3. **In 1984, France stepped in to supply nuclear fuel to the Tarapur power plant** after the US backed out, citing domestic constraints.
4. France **supported India's space programme** since its inception, such as **setting up the Sriharikota launch site and Centaur and Viking rocket technologies in the 1970s.**
5. **India and France entered into a Strategic Partnership in 1998.**

Recent News

- During the French President's visit to India, both countries **formally elevated ties** to **"Special Global Strategic Partnership".** (Feb 2026)
- Launched the **India-France Year of Innovation** and the creation of the **Innovation Network**.
- Inter-governmental agreement signed for **26 Rafale-M fighter jets**: Includes **technology transfer + MRO facilities + local production components**.
- **Airbus-Tata joint venture** inaugurated: H125 helicopter assembly line in India.
- **TRISHNA Mission (2026):** Successful launch of the joint ISRO-CNES satellite for high-resolution thermal imaging and climate monitoring.
- **AI Impact Summit (Feb 2026):** Co-hosted in Delhi, establishing a "Joint Advanced Technology Development Group" for ethical AI governance.

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Areas of Cooperation:

1. Both nations are **resident powers in the IOR**, collaborating to ensure a "free and open" Indo-Pacific.
2. France is the most **vocal and consistent supporter of India's permanent seat at the UN.**
3. **Strategic Autonomy:** A shared commitment to avoiding bloc politics while maintaining independent foreign policies in a polarized world.
4. France's support was vital in India's accession to the **Missile Technology Control Regime (MTCR), Wassenaar Arrangement (WA) and Australia Group (AG).**
5. Bilateral trade reached **€12.67 billion** in 2025-26, supported by the India-EU FTA.
6. **Digital Financial Links:** France became the first European nation to integrate UPI.
7. **Nuclear Energy cooperation:** Eg. Joint Special Task Force meetings (2026) to resolve the technical-financial roadmap for **Jaitapur's 9.9 GW** capacity.
8. **Co-production & Co-design:** Eg. **Safran-HAL partnership** to develop the 110kN aero-engine for the AMCA (Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft).
9. **Maritime Security:** Eg. **24th Varuna Naval Exercise** (2026) involved advanced carrier-borne operations and undersea combat drills.
10. **Counter-Terrorism:** Unified stance against cross-border terrorism and radicalization through high-level intelligence sharing and "No Money For Terror" initiatives.
11. **Space Connectivity:** French assistance in the **Gaganyaan mission** and tracking support for India's 2025-26 Moon missions.
12. **STEM Talent Flow:** Eg. Streamlined **multi-year visas** for PhD students and researchers.
13. **International Solar Alliance (ISA):** Co-leading the global transition to solar energy, with a new European office planned for Paris.
14. **CDRI Leadership:** Jointly presiding over the Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure to protect vulnerable SIDS and Global South nations.

Frictional points in the relationship:

1. **Jaitapur Liability Hurdles:** Despite the SHANTI Act (2025), concerns over "supplier liability" in case of nuclear accidents persist in French legal circles.
2. **Trade Imbalance:** Bilateral trade remains skewed toward defence and aviation, with a lack of diversification in smaller sectors. Eg. high Indian **tariffs on luxury goods and wine**.
3. **Procurement Delays:** Eg. **The MRFA (114 jets)** project has faced several "request for information" cycles without a final tender.
4. **Indigenous Content (Offset) Disputes:** India's push for 50-60% indigenous content in Rafale and submarines sometimes clashes with French quality/IP standards.
5. **Divergent Views on Ukraine:** Eg. **occasional** voting abstentions by India at the **UNGA** that contrast with France's proactive military aid to Kyiv.
6. **IPR Protection:** France seeks TRIPS-plus standards for its luxury and pharmaceutical brands, whereas India prioritizes affordable generics.
7. **Student Visa Barriers:** High administrative costs and language barriers (French proficiency) continue to deter some Indian students from choosing France.

Way Forward:

1. **Nuclear energy cooperation:** Finalize the "Government-to-Government" framework for Jaitapur using the 2025 SHANTI Act to resolve long-standing liability concerns.
2. **Maritime Integration:** Establish a reciprocal logistics agreement allowing Indian vessels routine access to French bases in Djibouti and Reunion Island. **(Rajesh Rajagopalan**

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3. **Economic Diversification:** Expand the "Horizon 2047" goals to include green hydrogen and agri-tech, moving trade beyond the "Defence-Aviation" silo.
4. **Multipolar Synergy:** Collaborate on a "Third Way" global framework that prevents a bipolar US-China world order while protecting Indian interests. **(S.D. Muni)**
5. **Resolve IPR Conflicts:** Use the "Strategic Partnership" goodwill to carve out specific IPR exemptions for **life-saving drugs** in the FTA. **(Arvind Subramanian)**

India-France ties show that **values-based diplomacy and mutual respect** can thrive even without geographical proximity.

India-Australia Relations:

The Australian Government in its **National Defense Strategy (NDS) 2024** identified India as a **'top-tier security partner'** in the Indo-Pacific Region (IPR).

Recent News:

- Australia's **National Defence Strategy (NDS) 2026** officially labels India a **"Top-Tier Security Partner,"** prioritizing operational military integration.
- India-Australia Defence Ministers' Dialogue & Agreements (Oct 2025): First **annual Defence Ministers' Dialogue institutionalised**.
- Expansion of Military Exercises & Operational Cooperation (2024-2026):
  - India participated in **Exercise Talisman Sabre 2025 (Australia)** for the first time.
  - The Royal Australian Air Force joined **Exercise Tarang Shakti (India, 2024)**.
- Australia released **"New Roadmap for Economic Engagement with India"**.
- Australia launched the **Mobility Arrangement for Talented Early Professionals Scheme (MATES)**. Provides **3,000 annual visa slots for Indian graduates** for work opportunities.

Areas of Cooperation:

1. **Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (2020):** Covers defence, trade, tech, climate, education. Enabled 32+ high-level visits in 5 years.
2. **Indo-Pacific Convergence:** Shared vision of a "free, open, and inclusive" region where international law (UNCLOS) prevails.
3. **ASEAN Centrality:** Both nations champion ASEAN as the core of the regional security and economic architecture.
4. **Trade Liberalization (ECTA):** Effective 2022/23, removing tariffs on 96% of Australian exports and 100% of Indian goods.
5. **Critical Minerals:** Securing India's green transition through Australia's vast reserves of lithium, cobalt, and rare earths. Eg. **the KABIL-CMH partnership.**
6. **Maritime Domain Awareness:** Eg. **posting** an **Australian Liaison Officer** at India's Information Fusion Centre (IFC-IOR) in Gurugram.
7. **Mutual Logistic Support Agreement 2020** to allow the two countries to access each other's military bases.
8. Joint Exercises inc**lude AUSINDEX, Malabar, PITCH BLACK (Air Force), AUSTRAHIND, Talisman Sabre,** Etc.
9. **Energy**:
   a. Signing of the letter of intent on **New and Renewable Energy in Feb 2022.**

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b. Signing of the **Civil Nuclear Cooperation Agreement.**

10. **Supply Chain Resilience (SCRI):** Working with Japan to build non-fragile, diverse value chains independent of China.
11. **976,000-strong Indian-Australian community** (the fastest-growing large diaspora) driving trade and soft power.

India-Australia Renewable Energy Partnership (REP)

- Launched in **November 2024** to deepen **renewable energy cooperation**.
- Focus on **decarbonisation, energy security, and economic growth**.

Priority Areas

- **Solar PV technology** and rooftop solar workforce development.
- **Green Hydrogen**: Joint R&D and market creation.
- **Energy Storage Systems**: Grid stability.
- **Critical Minerals**: Lithium, rare earth supply chains.
- **Circular Economy**: Sustainable renewable lifecycle.
- **Two-way Investments**: Giga-scale projects.
- **Capacity Building**: Training youth and women in solar skills.

Governance Mechanisms: Australia-India 1.5 Track Dialogue (Govt + Industry + Academia).

Frictional points in the relationship:

1. Controversy over the **Adani coal mine project in Australia, with some activists protesting against it**.
2. **Visa issues:** Australia tightened student visa rules to curb migration**, leading to a 48% drop in visas granted to Indian students.**
3. **Australia has criticized the Russian invasion** of Ukraine and sided with the U.S. and Western countries. **However, India has refrained from criticizing Russia over the issue.**
4. **Trade Imbalance:** India runs a significant trade deficit (~$7bn), primarily due to bulk imports of coal and minerals.
5. **Vandalism of Hindu temples and anti-India activities** by extremist groups in Australia create domestic friction.
6. **Stringent Australian sanitary and phytosanitary (SPS)** standards often block Indian agricultural and dairy exports.
7. Concerns over **AUKUS (nuclear submarines) potentially altering the balance in the Indian Ocean.**

Way Forward:

1. **Finalize CECA:** Conclude the full trade deal to include digital trade, government procurement, and services.
2. **Chokepoint Strategy:** Implement a "coordinated denial" strategy at the Malacca and Sunda straits using assets in the Andaman and Cocos Islands.
3. Create an **"India-Australia Education Council"** to oversee the quality and safety of the 1.5 lakh students abroad.
4. **Address Diaspora Extremism:** Establish a **"Joint Security Taskforce"** to monitor extremist activities and protect religious harmony in multicultural spaces.
5. **Sub-National Synergy:** Connect **"sister states"** (like Western Australia and Odisha) specifically for mining and renewable energy technology transfers.

Anchored in **trust, technology, and the Indo-Pacific,** India-Japan ties must evolve from **symbolic diplomacy to transformative cooperation.**

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Chapter 3

India & Neighbourhood

PYQs

[2022] India is an age-old friend of Sri Lanka.' Discuss India's role in the recent crisis in Sri Lanka in light of the preceding statement. (10)
[2015] Project `Mausam' is considered a unique foreign policy initiative of the Indian Government to improve relationships with its neighbors. Does the project have a strategic dimension? Discuss. (12.5)
[2015] Terrorist activities and mutual distrust have clouded India-Pakistan relations. To what extent the use of soft power like sports and cultural exchanges could help
generate goodwill between the two countries? Discuss with suitable examples. (12.5)
[2013] The protests in Shahbag Square in Dhaka in Bangladesh reveal a fundamental split in society between the nationalists and Islamic forces. What is its signifi- cance for India? (10)
[2013] What is meant by Gujral doctrine? Does it have any relevance today? Discuss. (10)

India-Pakistan

In **"Choices: Inside the Making of India's Foreign Policy,"** Shivshankar Menon writes, **"India's approach to Pakistan has often oscillated between optimism for peace and realism about security."**

Shyam Saran (Former Foreign Secretary) has stated that **"Pakistan's fixation on Kashmir and its quest for 'strategic depth' in Afghanistan have been major obstacles to stable relations."**

Current Affairs

- On 23 April 2025, following the Pahalgam terrorist attack, the Government of India declared the **suspension of the treaty** with Pakistan, citing national security concerns.

History:

Background phase of active aggression(1947-2001):

1. **October 1947 War:** Pakistan's capture of PoK, which led to Maharaja Hari Singh signing an Instrument of Accession with India in exchange for military aid.
2. **August 1965 War:** Clashes between border patrols in the Rann of Kutch led to the signing of the **Tashkent Agreement, and** both agreed to withdraw to pre-war lines.
3. **December 1971**: Bangladesh Liberation War. Signing of the **Simla Agreement in 1972.**
4. **During 1988**: Both sides tested their nuclear weapon capabilities.
5. **May 1999**: Pakistani forces and Kashmiri fighters occupied strategic positions on the LoC in Kargil, culminating in the Kargil War.

Phase of Reconciliation(2001-2008):

1. PM Vajpayee: **'We can change history but not geography. We can choose our friends but not our neighbors.'**
2. Atal Bihari Vajpayee signed the **ceasefire agreement of 2003** and the **Islamabad Joint Statement of 2004.**

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3. **2008 Mumbai Attacks** planned by Pakistani intelligence agencies.

Phase of Passive Bilateralism(2008-2015):

1. Marked by **the Neighbourhood First Policy(2014),** India accorded **priority to its South Asian members** in Foreign policy.

Phase of Renewed aggression(2015-2023): marked by

1. Signing of **CPEC** in 2015: Affront to Indian sovereignty.
2. The series of attacks: **Gurdaspur terror attacks(2015)**, Pathankot attack (2016), **Uri attack, Pulwama attack,** and Indian response via surgical strikes.

Major Issues in India-Pakistan Relations:

1. **Border issue** - stretches approximately 3,323 kilometers.
   a. **International Border (IB):** Officially recognized boundary, spans from **Gujarat to Jammu**, covering Rajasthan and Punjab regions.
   b. **Line of Control (LoC):** Established after the **1948 and 1971 wars,** and formalized by the **Simla Agreement in 1972.** Not an internationally recognized border, but a military control line.
   c. **Actual Ground Position Line (AGPL):** Extends from the northern point of the LoC at NJ9842 to the border with China in Siachen.
   d. **Sir Creek Boundary (110-kilometer marshy strip):** Not formally demarcated, with disagreements on whether the boundary follows the middle of the creek (India's claim) or the eastern bank (Pakistan's claim).
2. **Indus Water Treaty:** Recent suspension of the treaty by India post the Pahalgam attack.
3. **Terrorism:** Pakistan supports and harbors terrorist groups that conduct attacks on Indian soil, particularly in the Kashmir region.
4. **Ceasefire Violations** despite a ceasefire agreement in 2003.
5. **Political and Diplomatic Relations:** High-level talks have been sporadic, often disrupted by terrorist attacks or political developments.
6. **Economic and Trade Relations:** Following the 2019 Pulwama attack, India revoked Pakistan's Most Favored Nation (MFN) status.
7. **Dysfunctional SAARC:** SAARC has become a **Jammed Vehicle (S. Jaishankar)**, making it challenging to promote regional development and economic collaboration.
8. **China-Pakistan Russia Axis:** The China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) and India's growing ties with the U.S. influence the regional power dynamics and bilateral interactions.
9. **Afghanistan:** Pakistan's aspirations of **Strategic Depth** in Afghanistan lead to competing interests in Afghanistan, with security concerns, such as terrorism.



Boundary Conflicts:

1. **Kashmir Issue: C. Raja Mohan** suggests that **"the Kashmir issue is more about prestige and identity than territory."** Both countries have fought 3 wars over the Kashmir issue.
2. **Gilgit-Baltistan Issue:** Pakistan's declaration of **"Provisional Provincial Status"** to GB in May 2020 and the **passage of CPEC** mark an attack on India's sovereignty and territorial integrity.

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3. **Siachen Glacier Issue:** According to **Stephen P. Cohen, the Siachen conflict is like 2 bald people fighting over a comb.**
4. **Sir Creek Issue:** Pakistan claims the entire creek as per **Bombay Government Resolution of 1914.** But India claims that the boundary lies mid-channel as it **draws on the Thalweg Principle,** which is **rejected by Pakistan,** considering Sir Creek as a non-navigable channel. **The 1965 war** began with clashes in the Rann of Kutch.



Indus Water Treaty:

Signed in 1960 and brokered by the World Bank, the treaty governs the utilization of tributaries of the River Indus between India and Pakistan.

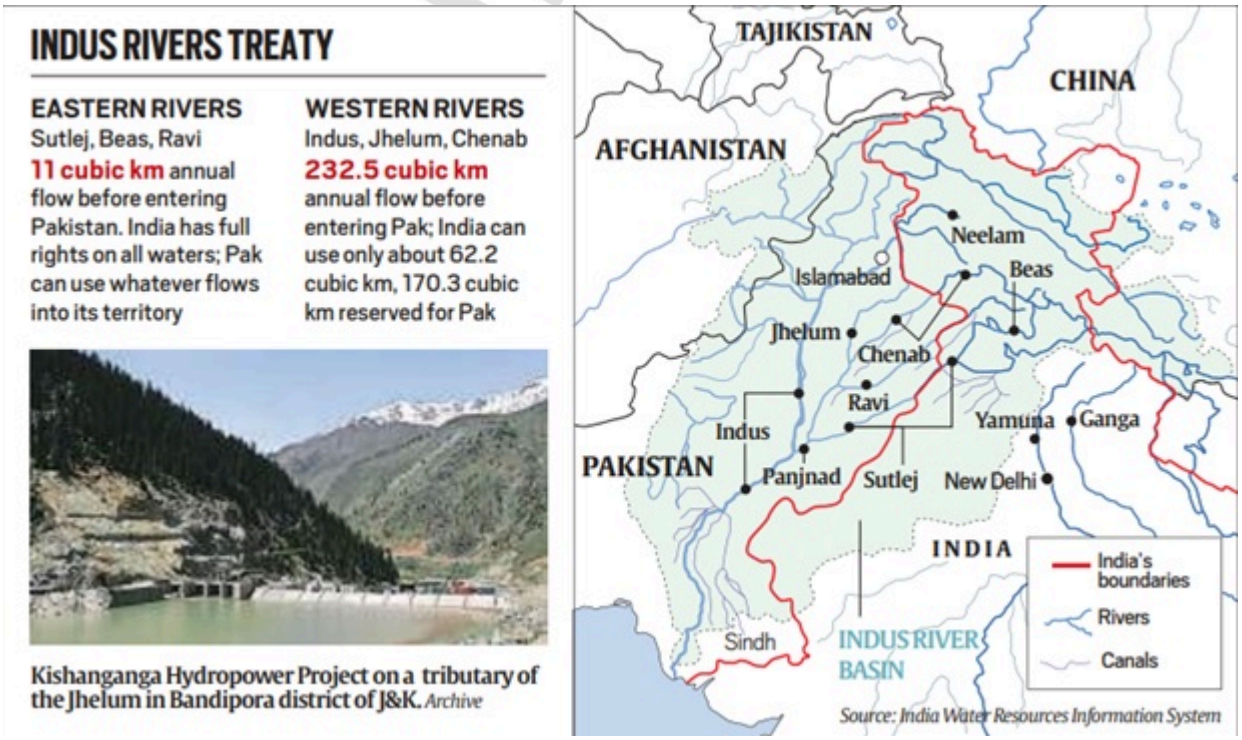
Recently, India has formally called for a **review of the Indus Water Treaty (IWT)** with Pakistan, citing **changes in population demographics, environmental issues, and the need for clean energy development to meet emission targets** under **Article XII(3)** of the treaty.

Provisions of the treaty:

1. **Eastern rivers** (for Indian unrestricted use) and **Western rivers** (for Pakistan. However, limited usage to India for agricultural usage and to build run-of-the-river hydropower projects.)
2. **3 Stage Dispute Resolution Mechanism:** First stage - **Permanent Indus Commission**(for cooperation and information exchange), Second stage - **Neutral expert,** and then **Court of Arbitration.**
3. **Storage Rights:** India can store up to **75 MAF** of water on Western rivers.
4. **Exit Provisions**: The treaty remains in force until both countries mutually agree on a new pact.

Related Issues:

1. **Disappointment over apportionment:** 80% of water allocation to Pakistan.



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2. **Sovereignty Concerns:** Pakistan's **Left Bank Outfall Drain (LBOD) project passes through the Rann of Kutch in India's Gujarat**.
3. **Pakistan's frequent opposition to the Indian projects:** Eg. Kishanganga and Ratle Hydroelectric Project on Jhelum and Chenab, respectively.
4. **Disagreement over Negotiation:** Eg. in the current dispute over the Kishenganga and Ratle project, the World Bank has appointed both a neutral expert and a CoA chairman. India argues that **starting both the expert mechanism and arbitration simultaneously violates the treaty.**
5. **Suboptimal data sharing** due to diplomatic tensions.
6. As per **Article XII of the IWT**, it "may from time to time be modified" with ratification from both countries.

India's Suspension of the Indus Waters Treaty:

On May 22, 2025, India formally declared that the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT), signed in 1960, would remain in "abeyance" until Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures support for cross-border terrorism. This came after the Pahalgam terror attack that killed 26 civilians, which India attributed to Pakistan-backed groups like The Resistance Front.

Quoting Prime Minister Narendra Modi: "Water and blood cannot flow together."

Legal and Diplomatic Basis

- The IWT has **no unilateral termination** clause. **Article XII(4)** mandates that it can be terminated **only by mutual agreement** via a duly ratified treaty.
- India can invoke the principle of **"fundamental change of circumstances"** (Article 62, Vienna Convention on the Law of Treaties) as the justification - citing:
  - Cross-border terrorism.
  - Demographic pressures.
  - Need for accelerated clean energy development.
- While India is not a signatory to the VCLT, the ICJ recognizes Article 62 as customary international law, giving India a potential legal basis.

India's Strategic Leverage

- **India can now:**
  - Withhold hydrological data.
  - Flush reservoirs at will.
  - Redesign hydropower projects to expand storage.
  - Time water releases (causing droughts or floods downstream).
- **India is entitled under IWT to:**
  - Store 3.6 MAF on western rivers.
  - Develope 1.34 million acres for irrigation in J&K and Ladakh.
  - Construct run-of-the-river projects like Kishanganga, Ratle, and Baglihar dams.

However, India currently utilizes only ~1 MAF and irrigates ~0.64 million acres - indicating infrastructure limitations.

Geostrategic and Regional Implications

- **Impact on Pakistan.**
  - Over 80% of Pakistan's agriculture and a third of its hydropower depend on the Indus basin.
  - While India lacks massive storage currently, uncertainty of flow can destabilize Pakistan's agrarian economy.
  - Possible inter-provincial conflicts in Pakistan, Eg. Punjab vs Sindh over canal projects like the Cholistan Canal.

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- **Risk of Internationalization**
  - Pakistan may escalate the issue to:
    - World Bank,
    - Permanent Court of Arbitration,
    - UN Security Council,
    - International Court of Justice (ICJ).
- **Regional Ripple Effects**
- China may reconsider hydrological data sharing with India (Brahmaputra and Sutlej).
- May affect the Ganga Treaty with Bangladesh (expiring in 2026).
- Could raise caution in Nepal and Sri Lanka in water-related treaties with India.

Way Forward

- **Renegotiating the treaty** for future cooperation is underlined in **Article VII of the IWT.**
- **Effective utilization** of 3.6 million-acre-feet (MAF) of "permissible storage capacity" on the western rivers.
- **Careful regional diplomacy** to avoid backlash from neighbours,
- **Strategic legal framing** to mitigate risks of international arbitration.

Terrorism:

Dr. S Jaishankar - Dialogue with Pakistan cannot proceed **without a commitment to ending terrorism**, as any engagement without this foundation lacks credibility.

Reasons for Border Terrorism:

1. **Historical Tensions** have reinforced Kashmir as a focal point for both state and non-state actors.
2. **Asymmetric balancing after military defeat in 1971:** General Zia-ul-Haq started a **'thousand cuts, zero-option war'** policy against India in the 1990s.
3. **Geographical Advantage:** Rugged terrain facilitates **infiltration.** Eg. in 1999, Pakistani forces and militants infiltrated Kargil.
4. **Radical Ideology and State-Sponsored Terrorism:** Eg. as witnessed by the 2008 Mumbai attacks, 2016 Pathankot and Uri attacks.

Steps taken by India to address Cross Border Terrorism:

1. **Strengthening Border Security and Surveillance:** Implementation of **CIBMS, Border Security Grid, Border Area Development Program,** etc.
2. **Counter-Terrorism Operations and Tactical Responses: Operation All Out** has been launched to eliminate militant threats, conducting **surgical strikes, the Balakot Air Strike, etc.**
3. **International Advocacy:** Lobbying successfully for Pakistan-based terrorists to be designated **under UN sanctions.** Eg. **Masood Azhar(2019), advocating for the adoption of CCIT, etc.**
4. **Amendments to the UAPA in 2019** have allowed India to designate individuals as terrorists, establishing the **NIA** as a central agency for **investigation and prosecution.**
5. **Community Engagement and Counter-Radicalization Efforts: Civic action programs like Operation Sadbhavna, Awaam ki Awaz program, Army Goodwill schools, etc.**

Red Lines Redrawn: Shift from restraint to decisive retaliation.

What explains Operation Sindoor, and what lies ahead?

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- **Strategic shift in India's policy** - decisive strategic shift towards **CREDIBLE DETERRENCE** by **declaring that any act of terrorism will now be considered as an act of war.**
- The doctrinal innovation of **'military response to terrorist attacks'.** The high-intensity, open, and public military action, Operation Sindoor, underscores this.
- **The NEW NORMAL: Each terror attack will be responded to with greater scale and scope** -
  - 2001-2002 (mobilisation but no action).
  - 26/11 attacks (no overt response).
  - 2016 surgical strikes (limited in scope and impact).
  - 2019 Balakot strikes (limited objectives).
  - 2025 Operation Sindoor takes it to one step above in terms of scale and scope.
- **Debunking nuclear deterrence of Pakistan**: India just became the **first country to** bomb multiple major cities of a **nuclear-armed country**.
- **End of distinction between subconventional (terrorism) and conventional (military) aggression:** It prevented an Indian military response to terror attacks in the past.
- With the above 2, India has challenged two of Pakistan's important **deterrent assumptions** vis-à-vis India. - Nuclear deterrence and distinction between **subconventional (terrorism) and conventional (military) aggression.** This brings Pakistan into the conventional space where India enjoys superiority. This is India's response to Pakistan's policy of 'Bleeding India by thousand cuts'.
- **Tripwire doctrine**: Any terrorist attack on India will be treated as a conventional military conflict, effectively placing the burden on Pakistan to prevent such attacks.
- **New Modus Operandi of India-Pakistan relations:** Striking terrorist infrastructure in Pakistan is aimed at increasing the cost for 'Thousand Cuts' strategy.

The era of waging sub-conventional warfare against India under the protective cover of deterrence is over.

China-Pakistan Partnership:

Aspect		Challenges For India
Geopolitical Cooperation("all-weather" partnership)	China has historically **supported Pakistan's stance on Kashmir** in multilateral forums. China advocated for **Pakistan's membership of SCO**.	**Diplomatic Isolation.** Eg. India is **not part of the SCO FTA**, unable to facilitate counterterrorism via **SCO's Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS)** due to Pakistan's involvement.
Geoeconomic Partnership and Connectivity	**CPEC, part** of China's BRI, aims to enhance trade connectivity, bypassing the Strait of Malacca. **According to AidData**, Pakistan's total external debt owed to China is **$68.91 billion as of** November 2023 (the highest in the world). **Chinese investment** in **Gwadar Port,** a strategic base near the **Strait of Hormuz** a vital choke point for global oil supplies.	**CPEC run through Gilgit Baltistan** region is seen by India as a **threat to territorial integrity.** **A Two Front War,** in the wake of increasing **Chinese economic cooperation** with Pakistan as acknowledged by **CDS General Rawat in 2020.** While eliminating the Malacca dilemma for China, CPEC aims to create the **Gwadar Dilemma for India.**

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Aspect		Challenges For India
Defense and Security Collaboration	China delivered **J-10C aircraft and Wing Loong II armed drones**, both co-produced **Hangor class** submarines and **JF-17 Fighter Jets.** China supported Pakistan's missile development program. Eg. **Shaheen and Babur missile series development**.	**While** India spends 2.9% of its GDP on military (**SIPRI**), it must maintain a **force of roughly 15 lakh soldiers** due to two active and unresolved borders with China and Pakistan.
Multilateralism	**Blocking India in International Forums** such as the UN, Nuclear Supplier Group, etc. Blocking the **UNSC resolutions** against **Masood Azhar with a technical hold.**	India had proposed the adoption of the **Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism (CCIT) to the UN General Assembly in 1996,** but a consensus could not be achieved so far.

Way Forward:

1. **Functionalist Approach** to develop **interdependence:** The trade and cultural relations should not be held hostage for terrorism and other issues (**Sharat Sabharwal**)
2. **Shyam Saran in "How India sees the world":** Improved relations with Pakistan can only be the cumulative outcome of a series of modest and incremental steps rather than the result of any big-bang affair which disturbs the deep state.
3. **Kofi Annan (Former UN Secretary-General)** emphasized upon achieving sustainable peace through **dialogue, understanding, and mutual respect.**
4. **Shahid Javed Burki (Former World Bank Vice President): Suggested trade relations and shared economic interests** could help ease tensions and create a sense of interdependence.
5. **Karan Singh**: emphasizing cultural and historical ties, believes that **people-to-people interactions** can help bridge the divide and promote understanding.

India-Afghanistan Relations:

PM Modi: India and Afghanistan share a special friendship, based on ties of history, geography, and culture.

M. K. Narayanan: Due to its geographical positioning and influence on regional stability, the political future of Afghanistan will be of considerable significance to India.

Rajiv Sikri (Rethinking India's foreign policy): As per **Kautilya's Mandal Siddhant**, a neighbor's neighbor is our friend. Thus, peace and stability in Afghanistan are important for India for security in Kashmir, securing Indian investment in Afghanistan, as well as India's power projection as a major global power.

Recent News

- **Afghanistan's Foreign Minister visited New Delhi in October.**

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- **Policy of "engagement without recognition":** India upgraded its **Kabul technical mission to a full embassy,** without formally recognizing the Taliban government. In line with the **Vienna Conventions on Diplomatic Relations (1961) and Consular Relations (1963)**, embassies are allowed to function without formal recognition of the government.
- In February, Pakistan launched **Operation Ghazab-lil-Haq**, conducting airstrikes in Nangarhar, Paktika, and Khost.
- UNAMA and UNHCR estimate over **700 Afghan civilians killed** and approximately **115,000 people displaced**.

Historical background of Indo-Afghan relations:

1. **India signed a "Friendship Treaty" with Afghanistan in 1950.**
2. **1979-89: India** was the **only South Asian nation to recognise** the Soviet-backed Democratic Republic of Afghanistan.
3. **Throughout the 1980s,** India was **marginalized** by the US, Pakistan & Gulf states, which sponsored mujahideen militias to fight against the Soviet and Communist forces.
4. During the Taliban **regime in Afghanistan in 1996**, India maintained a presence by supporting the then-Afghan government in exile and the so-called **Northern Alliance forces.**
5. **2005:** India proposed **Afghanistan's membership** in the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation.
6. **2011:** Indo-Afghan relations have been strengthened by the **Strategic Partnership Agreement** signed between the two countries.
7. **2021: Operation Devi Shakti** to evacuate Indian citizens and Foreign nationals from Afghanistan after the takeover by the Taliban.

Afghanistan's Post-Pahalgam Shift: Evolving Diplomatic Alignment with India

1. **April 22, 2025: Terrorist Attack in Pahalgam (India).**
2. **April 23-24, 2025: Afghanistan condemns the Attack**, expressing solidarity with the victims and rejecting terrorist violence.
3. **Late April 2025: Indian Delegation Visits Kabul** - Afghanistan reiterated its commitment to holding perpetrators accountable.
4. **May 2025: Direct Contact Between EAM S. Jaishankar and FM Muttaqi**, appreciating the Taliban's condemnation and discussing **future cooperation**.
5. **May 2025 onward: Signals of Strategic Repositioning.** These developments suggest **Afghanistan is recalibrating its diplomatic alignment**, reducing reliance on Pakistan and **engaging India on regional security**, particularly in counter-radicalism and anti-terror efforts.



India's Developmental Assistance:

Political:

1. India promoted Afghanistan's inclusion in **SAARC in 2005**.

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2. **Istanbul Process**(2011) to address shared challenges and interests.
3. **Strategic Partnership Agreement(2011):** It recommitted Indian assistance to help rebuild Afghanistan's infrastructure and institutions.

Economic:

1. **Overall $3 Billion**
2. **Preferential Trade Agreement(2003)**that led to duty cuts to a specific category (38 products) of Afghan dry fruits.
3. **India announces Rs. 200 Crore Development Aid for Afghanistan in Budget 2024**.
4. A **line of credit of $50 million** to expand entrepreneurship and business-to-business cooperation.

Defense:

1. India delivered **Russian Mi-25 attack helicopters** to Afghanistan in 2015.
2. **Military Training** to around 700 Afghans every year since 2011 in IMA, NDA.

Developmental Aid:

1. Constructing the **Afghan Parliament, Salma Dam(42 MW).**
2. **Zaranj Delaram Highway**(218 Km), **Kabul to Pul-e-Khumri** 220 kV DC transmission line.

Fostering Connectivity:

1. **TAPI:** Joint project by member countries to access **33 billion cubic meters of natural gas** each year extracted from the **Galkynysh gas** field in Turkmenistan.
2. **Chabahar Port:** IPGL took over the port operations for 10 years, and since then, it has been used by India to provide "humanitarian assistance to Afghanistan including wheat, pulses, pesticides, and medical supplies".
3. **INSTC: Bypass Pakistan to access Afghanistan, Central Asia, and beyond.**

Humanitarian Assistance:

1. **Free Healthcare** to over 30,000 Afghans and medication each month from five Indian Medical Missions.
2. Reconstructing the **Indira Gandhi Institute of Child Health in Kabul.**
3. **Covid-19 vaccine delivery of over 500,000 doses to Afghanistan in January 2022.**

Importance of Stability in Afghanistan for India:

Geostrategic

1. **Location**: Positioned at the intersection of East, West, Central, and Northeast Asia, with proximity to major powers such as Russia, China, India, and Iran.
2. **Historical Influence**: A focal point of the "Great Game" between the USA and Russia since the Cold War era and between the USA and China at present.
3. **Regional Power Dynamics**: Stability in Afghanistan is essential for regional peace and aligns with India's aspirations as a regional leader and global power.

Safeguard Economic interests:

1. **To safeguard $3 billion** of Indian Investments in diverse projects.
2. To harness an estimated **1 trillion USD** of untapped resources, according to a joint report of **the Pentagon and the US Geological Survey.**

Ensure Security:

1. **By curbing the narcotics trade: As per UNODC,** India is one of the world's largest opiate markets in terms of users and is vulnerable **to increased supply from Afghanistan.**
2. **By ensuring cooperation on counterterrorism measures.**

Energy Security

1. **Natural Gas via TAPI pipeline.**

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2. **Energy Security**: Afghanistan possesses significant untapped hydrocarbon reserves, including oil and natural gas.

Secure Connectivity:

1. To Central Asia via **the Zaranj-Delaram highway.**
2. As India advocates for **Afghanistan's inclusion in INSTC,** which boosts its regional interest.

Challenges posed by the Taliban:

1. **Geopolitical:**
   a. **Rising Pakistan influence**: According to **M. K. Narayanan**, Pakistan has emerged as **the 'patron saint'** of the new Taliban government in Afghanistan.
   b. According to **Srinath Raghavan** (The Most Dangerous Place: A History of the United States in South Asia): The vacuum created by US withdrawal can be filled by China and Pakistan, which can be detrimental to India's security.
2. **Geoeconomic**: India has invested more than $3 billion in Afghanistan. Political instability under the Taliban can threaten Indian investments.
3. **Defense and Security:**
   a. **Increased activity of global terror outfits**: Eg. ISKP.
   b. **Terrorism**: Possibility of resurgence of al Qaeda and the Islamic State (IS).
   c. **Rising radicalization** under the Taliban can have a spill-over effect on Kashmir. It is also a hub for the opium trade and organized crime.
4. **Connectivity**: Afghanistan's role as a transit route for India to Central Asia is limited by instability and Pakistan's influence.

Should India recognize the Taliban:

Benefits(Practical)	Challenges(Principle)
To safeguard $3 billion of Indian Investments in diverse projects.	**Ideological Fanaticism:** Their links with other terrorist groups like al-Qaeda, TTP, etc.
To contain China, **President Xi Jinping of China accepted the letter of credentials of the Taliban's official Ambassador to China.**	**Human Rights concern:** rising **instances of extrajudicial killing, arbitrary arrests, and detentions.**
The Taliban have held out **assurances of security if India opened its mission** and have sought closer ties with India.	**Past Experience:** In 1999, the hijacked **Indian Airlines Flight 814** landed and stayed in Kandahar, Afghanistan.
Afghanistan can act as a **counterbalance to the rising Pakistan-China axis** in Asia.	India's stand is that it should be **Afghan-led, Afghan-owned and Afghan-controlled,** and it is also wary of talks with the Taliban and the distinction of **'good Taliban-bad Taliban'.**
Faultlines in Afghan-Pakistan relations: On issues related to the Durand Line, the fencing of borders, the rise of TTP attacks inside Pakistan, and the deportation of Afghan Refugees from Pakistan, provide opportunities for India.	India is wary of the Taliban's ties with Pakistan's ISI and the potential use of the Haqqani network to threaten its interests in Afghanistan.

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Benefits(Practical)	Challenges(Principle)
Shared interest to loosen Pakistan's transit grip on Afghanistan through **Chabahar Port.**	Exposure to instability if the regime collapses or fails to maintain stability.
Enables **diplomatic presence** and influence.	Contradicts India's democratic values and support for **the Afghan-led and Afghan-owned process.**

Way Forward:

1. **Shyam Saran**: Initiate a new "Great Game" by leveraging the USA's local connections, ties with various tribes, and the goodwill gained through its developmental efforts.
2. **Harsh V Pant:** Building **Delhi-Washington-Moscow consensus** and shifting the theatre from Kashmir to Afghanistan to ensure peace and stability in Afghanistan.
3. **M.K. Bhadra Kumar**: India should continue its developmental approach and **"should not try to fish in troubled waters."** India should continue with **the no boots on the ground policy.**
4. **Vivek Katju** suggests that India should **engage discreetly** with the Taliban as it would not grant legitimacy to the Taliban nor diminish India's own legitimacy.
5. **M. K. Narayanan** suggests that India should **mediate** to develop a plan that preserves Afghan neutrality, creating a buffer against Chinese expansion into South Asia.
6. India needs to work with Central Asian republics, China, and Iran, which have similar stakes in peace and stability in the region.
7. According to **Sushant Sareen**, India needs to show **strategic patience** and wait for Afghan-Pak fault lines to widen to break the **Pak-Taliban nexus.**
8. Leverage **Heart of Asia, SCO, Moscow Format, UN, and partner nations** for **coordinated aid, reconstruction, and counterterrorism efforts.**

C. Rajamohan suggests that India should pursue a **comprehensive policy** in Afghanistan that **balances strategic rewards and risks**.

India Nepal Relations:

C Raja Mohan, "For India, Nepal is the **"Punya Bhoomi"; for** Nepal, India is the vast economic hinterland and may well be called its **"Karma Bhoomi".**

History:

Close bonds with marriage and familial ties-**Roti Beti ka Rishta.** Similar ties in terms of **Hinduism and Buddhism** with Buddha's birthplace, **Lumbini,** located in present-day Nepal.

Treaty of Peace and Friendship 1950 - allows freedom of movement across borders.

Recent news

- Nepal has objected to India and China planning to conduct the **Kailash Mansarovar Yatra** through the Lipulekh pass.
- Nepal has imposed customs duty on goods imported from India exceeding 100 Nepalese Rupees (approx. 60 Indian Rupees).

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Recent Events:

1. **RBI** permitted **Indian banks to lend in INR to Nepalese entities** to enhance **cross-border investment** and **reduce currency volatility.**
2. India and Nepal have signed MoU's to develop **the West Seti and Seti River projects** and to take forward the **Sapt Kosi high dam project.**
3. Recently, Nepal decided to have a **picture of the country's map on the new Rs 100 notes.** The map **shows the Kalapani, Lipulekh, and Limpiyadhura regions as part of the country.**

Importance of Nepal for India:

1. **Geostrategic:**
   a. Acts as a **northern 'borderland' flanking and buffer state** between India and China.
   b. To prevent terrorist groups such as **Al-Qaida, Taliban, LeT,** etc. from establishing launch pads in Nepal.
2. **Economic:**
   a. India accounts for about **two-thirds of Nepal's merchandise trade, one-third of trade in services**, and one-third of total FDI.
   b. **Safeguarding Indian Investments**. Eg. in projects like the **Motihari-Amlekhgunj** oil pipeline, **the Upper Karnali** and **the Arun III hydroelectric projects.**
   c. India is Nepal's largest trade partner, accounting for **64.1% of Nepal's total trade.**
3. **Resource management:**
   a. India imports **10,000 MW (2024 agreement)**; Projects like **Arun-III (900 MW)** boost Nepal's economy and support India's green energy goals.
   b. **The Kosi Agreement (1954) and Gandak Agreement (1959)** facilitate flood control and irrigation management for shared rivers.
4. **Multilateral Partnership** through forums such as BBIN, BIMSTEC, Non-Aligned Movement, and SAARC.
5. **Defense and Security:**
   a. **Nearly 35,000 Nepalese** citizens serve in the prestigious **Gorkha Regiment.**
   b. **Joint Exercises with Nepal.** Eg. **Surya Kiran**
6. **Cultural importance:**
   a. Signing of sister cities agreement for the twinning of **Janakpur and Ayodhya, Kathmandu and Varanasi, Lumbini and Bodhgaya.**
   b. India funded two heritage projects: **Pashupatinath riverfront development and Bhandarkhal Garden restoration.**



Challenges in relationships:

1. **Political Instability in Nepal.** Recent **Gen-Z Protests.**
2. **Border issue:** In 2019, Nepal released a new political map claiming **Kalapani, Limpiyadhura and Lipulekh of Uttarakhand** and the area of Susta **(Bihar)** as part of Nepal's territory.
3. **Issues with Friendship Treaty**: As the treaty obliges Nepal to seek

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consent while importing arms from third countries, this is resented by Nepal as an attack on sovereignty.

4. **Water Sharing Issues**: Deadlock over **Pancheshwar Project** due to disagreements on benefit-sharing.
5. **Agnipath Scheme,** which proposes a fixed four-year term for recruits, **has led Nepal to pause Gorkha recruitment.**
6. **Anti-India Sentiments** due to the perceived "big brotherly attitude" of India.
7. **Internal security issue:**
   a. Insurgent groups, like **the People's Liberation Front of India (PLFI) and the Communist Party of Nepal (CPN) Maoist,** have used Nepal as a haven.
   b. **Organized smuggling networks:** Eg. in 2023, **DRI busted a gold smuggling syndicate of Sudanese nationals** operating through the Nepal border.
8. **Nepal's growing proximity to China:**
   a. Elevated Partnership to **"Strategic Partnership of Cooperation Featuring Everlasting Friendship for Development and Prosperity".**
   b. In Nepal, China is the **largest source of FDI,** including projects like **Pokhara International Airport, Upper Trishuli hydropower project, and West Seti Dam.**
   c. **Formation of the Himalayan Quadrilateral excluding India.**
9. **Project Delays:** Eg. The Kosi Agreement (signed in 1954) and the Mahakali Treaty (in 1996) to build the **Pancheshwar Multipurpose Project** have not been implemented to date.
10. **Economic**: Nepal's trade deficit with India is close to **18 percent of the GDP.**

Way Forward:

1. **Depoliticize Boundary Issues**: Establish a **joint technocratic commission** for dispute resolution.
2. **Energy Co-ownership Model**: Promote **joint ventures in hydropower** and an integrated regional energy grid.
3. **Sub-National Diplomacy**: Enable **state-province cooperation** for local issues and economic corridors.
4. **Climate Cooperation**: Develop **climate-resilient infrastructure** and joint mechanisms for disasters (Eg. GLOF monitoring).
5. **Development of Inland waterways**, providing additional access to the sea for Nepal. (linking **Sagarmatha (Mt. Everest)** with **Sagar (Indian Ocean).**
6. **The transboundary river disputes** can be resolved under the aegis of **International law on Transboundary Water Disputes.**
7. **C Raja Mohan:** Partnership based on mutual respect and respect for sovereignty. Instead of an "India first policy", India should support a **"Nepal first"** policy.
8. **Developmental Partnership:** Innovative approaches in sectors such as health, education, food and nutrition, child development, gender and jobs. (K.V. Rajan)
9. **Amendments to the Peace and Friendship Treaty of 1950** as recommended by the **Eminent Persons' Group** set up jointly by the two countries to review their bilateral relations.

India-Bhutan Relations:

India and Bhutan established diplomatic relations in 1968 with a special office in Thimphu. Their bilateral relations are based on the Treaty of Friendship and Cooperation, originally signed in 1949 and revised in 2007.

During his state visit in 2019, Narendra Modi remarked, **"Who will not want a friend and a neighbor like Bhutan?"** highlighting the significance of Bhutan in India's 'Neighborhood First ' policy.'

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Indo-Bhutan Treaty of Peace and Friendship of 1949:

1. **Article 2:** India to guide Bhutan's foreign policy.
2. **Treaty revised in 2007:** Bhutan can import arms as long as Indian interests are not harmed and there is no re-export of the weapons.
3. **Articles 6 and 7 in the current treaty** encompass the issue of 'national treatment' and equal privileges for citizens on each other's soil.

Recent News

Narendra Modi visited Bhutan for the **70th birthday of Jigme Singye Wangchuck.**

Key Highlights of the Visit

- India backed **Bhutan's 13th Five-Year Plan**, **Economic Stimulus Programme**, and projects like **Gelephu Mindfulness City**.
- **MoUs** on **renewable energy, health, and mental health**.
- Inauguration of **1020 MW Punatsangchhu-II** and revival of **1200 MW Punatsangchhu-I**; **₹40 billion Line of Credit** extended for Bhutan's energy sector development.

Importance of Bhutan:

Geostrategic:

1. **Buffer state** between India and China.
2. **Doklam Plateau** provides a tactical military edge over China close to the Chumbi Valley. During the **Doklam standoff** between India and China, Bhutan allowed Indian troops to enter its territory to resist Chinese incursions.

Geoeconomic:

1. Safeguarding Indian Investments. Eg. projects like **Chhukha(336 MW), Tala (1,020 MW), and Mangdechhu (720 MW)** were constructed with Indian assistance.
2. India is **Bhutan's largest trade partner**: Over **80% of Bhutan's imports** and exports.
3. **Development Partnership**: India funded **₹4,500 crore (12th FYP)** across sectors like **energy, education, ICT, and health**.
4. Electricity exports to India generate about 25% of Bhutan's GDP & 40% of revenue.
5. **The Trade, Commerce and Transit Agreement, 2016,** establishes a free trade regime and provides Bhutan with duty-free transit of goods to/from third countries.

Resource management:

1. **Bhutan** has an estimated hydropower potential **of 30,000 to 36,900 MW.**
2. **Punatsangchhu-II hydropower project in 2024** is crucial for joint water management for both Bhutan and the Indian state of West Bengal.

Cultural:

1. **Preferred tourist destination: In 2023, of the 3.04 lakh tourists who visited Bhutan, 72,659 were Indians.**
2. **Cultural & Educational Ties**: **1,000+ scholarships annually**, **ITEC training**, and strong religious linkages (Bodh Gaya, Nalanda).

Challenges in relationships:

1. China is actively pushing for **diplomatic ties and border settlement**, while expanding infrastructure in Tibet (Eg. **Lhasa-Shigatse-Yatung railway**), gradually eroding India's traditional **geographic advantage**.

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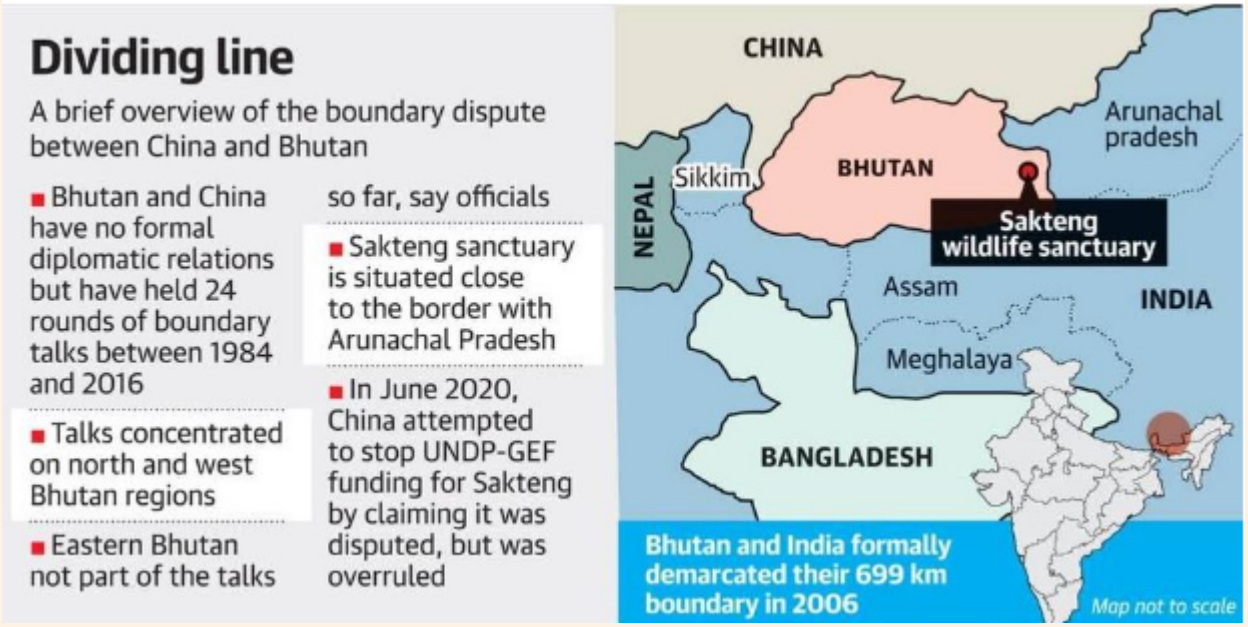
2. **Doklam Dilemma**: China's **"package deal"** to gain control over the **Doklam plateau** poses a serious **strategic threat to India's Siliguri Corridor (Chicken's Neck)**.
3. **Economic Perception Issues**: Sections in Bhutan view India's dominance as **exploitative**, arguing that aid leads to **"jobless growth"** and that benefits largely flow back to Indian firms.
4. **Hydropower Financing Concerns**: Shift from a **60:40 grant-loan model** to **loan-heavy (60-70%) financing** has raised concerns about **debt burden and financial sustainability**.
5. **Tourism Restrictions**: High **Sustainable Development Fee** reduces Indian tourist inflow.
6. **Economic Dependency**: Heavy reliance on India leads to **power asymmetry and perceptions of dominance**.
7. **Hydropower Project Delays:** Eg. **Punatsangchhu-I, initially expected to be completed by 2016, remains incomplete.**
8. **Internal security issues:**
   a. **Smuggling: Chinese-made goods, Bhutanese cannabis, liquor, and forest products are major items smuggled into India.**
   b. India's North-East Militant outfits like the **United Liberation Front of Assam (ULFA), National Democratic Front of Bodos (NDFB)**, etc., use Bhutan as a hideout.

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China Bhutan Boundary Talks

According to Suhasini Haider, the position of Bhutan is like 'an egg between two rocks.'



Bhutan shares a **477 km-long border with China**, which claims certain territories from Bhutan:

- **Western Sector- Doklam (2017 Crisis).**
- **Central (North) - Pasamlung and Jakartung.**
- **East - Saketang (It is a wildlife sanctuary in Bhutan.**

China and Bhutan have **not established diplomatic relations**.

Two agreements serve as the foundation for current negotiations. One, established in 1988, outlines **guiding principles** for resolving boundary issues, while the other, reached in 1998, focuses on upholding **peace and stability** along the Bhutan-China border.

China proposed a "swap arrangement", where China conceded its northern claims for Bhutan accepting western claims, including Doklam, which would be of concern to India.

The joint technical team (JTT) on the delimitation and demarcation of the Bhutan-China boundary signed a cooperation agreement at the **25th round of boundary negotiations**.

3-step roadmap for border resolution:

- Delimitation of the border on maps through talks between the two sides
- Joint surveys
- Actual demarcation of the 477 km border

Way Forward:

1. **Initiating Trilogue with China:** Opening such communication channels can minimize uncertainties with regard to border disputes.
2. **Economic Diversification**: Promote **MSMEs, IT, pharma, eco-tourism,** and expand into **solar & wind energy**.
3. **Technological Integration**: Expand **space, telemedicine, digital infrastructure, STEM training**.
4. **Cultural Diplomacy**: Develop a **Himalayan Cultural Corridor** and **youth exchange programmes**.

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5. **Integrated Water Management**: Move towards **river basin management**, focusing on **flood control and climate resilience**.

In the words of **C. Raja Mohan,** "Despite diversifying international bilateral ties, Bhutan will politically continue to consider India as its only major strategic ally, but New Delhi should also recognise Thimphu's concerns by not taking it for granted."

India-Bangladesh Relations:

"India and Bangladesh share not only a border but also emotions, experiences, and a vision for peace and progress." – Atal Bihari Vajpayee, Former Prime Minister of India.

- **"Shared Vision for Connectivity, Commerce & Collaboration" (2024):** Focus on multimodal connectivity, rail, road, inland waterways, digital + transit access for Bangladesh to Nepal & Bhutan via India.
- **Sabroom Integrated Check Post (Tripura):**
  - It connects to Bangladesh's Ramgarh, improving access to Chattogram Port.
  - Aims to boost Northeast India trade and reduce logistics costs.
- **High-level engagement resumed (2026):**
  - Bangladesh FM's visit to India focuses on energy, travel, and security cooperation.
  - Signals gradual normalization.

History:

1. India played a great role in the emergence of independent Bangladesh during its **Liberation War in 1971 and was the first country to recognize Bangladesh** as a separate state.
2. The Prime Minister of India recently referred to the current state of the **bilateral relationship as 'Sonali Adhyay' (golden phase).**

Recent Events:

PM Sheikh Hasina's resignation and flight to India amid protests mark a pivotal shift in South Asian geopolitics, raising concerns about Bangladesh's stability and its relationship with India.

The anti-India elements are gaining ground, as witnessed in attacks on Hindu temples in Bangladesh.

Recently, India has backed out of a trans-shipment facility that permitted exports from Bangladesh to enter other countries through Indian borders.

Importance of Bangladesh:

Geopolitical

1. **Neighborhood First Pillar:** Ensures regional stability and a friendly eastern neighbor.
2. Bangladesh provides a strategic **counterweight to the "String of Pearls"**. Eg. use of Chittagong and Mongla ports to protect the Siliguri Corridor.
3. **Act East Gateway:** Serves as the primary land and riverine bridge for India to engage with the ASEAN region.

Geoeconomic

1. **Largest Trade Partner:** Bangladesh is India's biggest trading partner in South Asia. Eg. India is a vital supplier of cotton yarn and fabric for Bangladesh's global RMG sector.

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2. **Development Partnership:** Bangladesh is the largest recipient of Indian Lines of Credit (LoC), totaling over **$8 billion**.
3. **Energy cooperation:** India exports ~1160 MW of power to Bangladesh. Eg. **the Maitree Super Thermal Power Project** is a joint venture ensuring grid stability for both.

Defence and Security

1. **Counter-Insurgency Cooperation:** Dhaka has historically assisted in dismantling safe havens for anti-India insurgent groups like ULFA.
2. **Peaceful and cooperative border management: Land Boundary Agreement (2015) and Delimitation of Maritime Boundary.**
3. **Maritime Security:** Cooperation in the Bay of Bengal for anti-piracy and Disaster Risk Reduction (DRR).

Connectivity

1. **Multimodal Transport:** Eg. **The Akhaura-Agartala** rail link provides crucial transit for landlocked Tripura.
2. **Sub-Regional Transit:** Implementation of the **BBIN Motor Vehicle Agreement** to facilitate seamless cargo movement across borders.

Multilateralism

1. **BIMSTEC Synergy** as an alternative to the paralyzed SAARC. Eg. Joint leadership in the BIMSTEC Master Plan for Transport Connectivity (2025).
2. **Blue Economy:** Eg. Collaboration at the **Indian Ocean Rim Association (IORA)** on marine pollution and fisheries.

Cultural

1. **Shared Heritage:** Common language (Bengali), literature (Tagore/Nazrul), and history of the 1971 Liberation War.
2. **People-to-People Ties:** Over 1.5 million Bangladeshis visit India annually for medical, business, and educational purposes.

Challenges in relationships:

1. **Sheikh Hasina's Shelter:** Formal extradition requests have become a litmus test for bilateral relations in 2026.
2. Reports of targeted **violence against Hindu minorities in Bangladesh** cause political ripples in India.
3. **Anti-India Rhetoric:** The "India Out" campaign in Bangladeshi social media and universities.
4. **Non-Tariff Barriers (NTBs):** Eg. retaliatory land-port restrictions on ready-made garments (RMG)
5. **Infrastructure and Connectivity Risks:** India has provided **USD 8 billion in credit since 2016**, including the **Akhaura-Agartala** and **Khulna-Mongla Port** rail line.
6. **Sharing of transboundary rivers:**
    a. Both share **54 common rivers,** but only two treaties have been signed so far. The **Ganga Waters Treaty and the Kushiyara River Treaty.**
    b. **Teesta River water dispute:** While two countries reached a draft agreement in **2011 for a 50:50 water-sharing** arrangement, it has not been implemented.
    c. **1996 Ganga treaty** expires in Dec 2026, negotiations are complicated by changing river morphology and disagreements over Farakka Barrage water levels
7. **Internal security issues:**
    a. **Illegal migration:** As per various reports, there are nearly **17 million** undocumented Bangladeshis in India.
    b. **Cross-Border Terrorism: ULFA, NDFB, ULFBV,** and **KLO** operate from Bangladesh.
    c. **Smuggling:** It is estimated that about **1.5 million heads of cattle,** amounting to about **US $500 million,** are smuggled into Bangladesh each year.

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   d. **Radicalization Risks:** Concern over the rise of Islamist elements (Jamaat-e-Islami) affecting the security of border states.
8. **Chinese Influence:** China has become Bangladesh's **largest trading and defense partner**.
   a. Bilateral trade reached **USD 18.5 billion in FY 2024**, but Bangladesh faces a **trade deficit of USD 16.45 billion**. China committed **USD 2.1 billion** in new investments.
   b. Bangladesh has re-engaged China on the **Teesta River Management Project**.
   c. China pledged to support the **repatriation of 180,000 Rohingyas**, leveraging its influence in Myanmar.
   d. Upgrade of the **Lalmonirhat airfield** near the Siliguri Corridor is a major security redline.
9. **Improved Pakistan-Bangladesh relations**
   a. In 2025, the two countries began **directly trading** for the first time, with Dhaka importing 50,000 tonnes of rice from Pakistan.
   b. **Direct flights and military contacts** have been revived, visa procedures have been simplified, and there are reports of co-operation on security matters.

Way Forward:

1. **Basin-Wide River Management:** Move beyond Teesta to holistic management of all **54 shared rivers** via the Joint Rivers Commission.
2. **Zero-Fatality Border:** Strictly implement **non-lethal border management** to end civilian casualties and public resentment.
3. Early conclusion of **the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement.**
4. **Enhance Regional and Sub-Regional Cooperation** through **BIMSTEC, SAARC, and IORA** frameworks.
5. **Smart Border Management:** Deploy CIBMS (surveillance technology) to curb smuggling without hindering legitimate cross-border movement.
6. Strengthen Track-II diplomacy and cultural centers to counter "India Out" narratives among Bangladeshi youth.
7. **Climate Cooperation:** Jointly tackle the submergence of the **Sundarbans** and deltaic flooding as a shared existential threat.

India Myanmar Relations:

PM Narendra Modi - "India's relationship with Myanmar is not just that of a neighbor but of a family, and that family bonding has a long history."

S. Jaishankar - "Myanmar is key to our Act East policy and a bridge between India and Southeast Asia."

Recent News

- **Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project nearing completion (2025-26):** Sittwe Port operational; inland water + road components progressing.
- **Free Movement Regime scrapped** due to concerns over insurgency, illegal migration. India initiated a **100-km smart fencing** project to curb illegal migration.
- **Operation Brahma (March 2025):** To provide relief after an earthquake struck the Mandalay and Sagaing regions.
- **Election Stance (Dec 2025):** India, along with China and Russia, backed the junta-organized elections despite Western calls to label them "sham" polls.
- The Myanmar military recaptured the strategic town of **Falam in Chin State**, intensifying refugee flows into Mizoram and Manipur.

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- India rescued over 2,000 citizens trapped in fraudulent **"cyber slavery" networks** operating in Myanmar's lawless border zones.

Importance of Myanmar:

1. **Gateway to ASEAN:** Myanmar is the only Southeast Asian country sharing a land border with India. Strategic land-link makes Myanmar the lynchpin of India's **Act East Policy**.
2. **Countering China:** Eg. **The Sittwe Port** project directly counters Chinese influence in the Kyaukpyu Special Economic Zone.
3. **Neighborhood First:** Myanmar is a unique intersection of India's "Neighborhood First" and "Act East" foreign policy frameworks.
4. **Strategic Location: Myanmar borders China, India, ASEAN, and the Bay of Bengal.**
5. **Kaladan Multimodal Transit Project:** Reduces India's dependence on the **Siliguri Corridor** and strengthens India's trade route to **ASEAN markets.**
6. **Economic and Trade Potential:**
   a. **Safeguarding Indian Investments: ONGC Videsh Limited (OVL), along with GAIL,** has invested in the **Shwe gas fields in Rakhine State** of Myanmar.
   b. **13 Indian Public Sector Undertakings** have a presence in Myanmar in different sectors.
7. **Convergence for Sub-Regional Cooperations:** Eg. **in BIMSTEC, ASEAN Regional Forum, Mekong-Ganga Cooperation, etc.**
8. **Energy security:** Myanmar holds oil and natural gas reserves **(11 trillion and 23 trillion cubic feet,** respectively). India has suggested a **$6 billion oil refinery in Thanlyn,** close to Yangon.
9. **Security and Defense:**
   a. Joint exercises like '**IMCOR**', '**IN-MN BILAT**' and the India-Myanmar Joint Army Exercise **(IMBAX).**
   b. **Operation Sunrise** along the Myanmar border targeting camps of insurgent groups operating in the North East.
   c. **Narcotics Control:** Cooperation with Myanmar is crucial due to its proximity to the Golden **Triangle.**

Challenges in relationships:

1. **Political Instability (Civil War):** Armed resistance groups (PDF/EAOs) now control nearly 50% of Myanmar's territory, complicating Indian engagement.
2. **Refugee Crisis:** Eg. over **60,000 refugees** entered Mizoram following the 2024-25 resistance battles (UNHCR).
3. **Border Insurgent Camps:** Anti-India groups (ULFA-I, Meitei groups) utilize the porous, forested terrain of Myanmar as safe havens.
4. **Organized Crime: Golden Triangle** makes the India-Myanmar border vulnerable to trafficking of **heroin and amphetamine-type stimulants** (ATS).
5. **Chinese Influence:**
   a. The bilateral trade is roughly **1/3rd of the total trade of Myanmar.**
   b. Beijing's **CMEC (China-Myanmar Economic Corridor)** gives it direct access to the Indian Ocean via Kyaukpyu.
   c. China is Myanmar's **largest investor,** often overshadowing Indian development projects in scale.



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6. **Suspending the 16-km Free Movement Regime has angered border tribes with shared ethnic ties.**
7. **Cyber-Slavery Hubs:** Ungoverned border regions (Myawaddy) host scam centers that kidnap and exploit Indian IT professionals.
8. **Project Delays:** Security threats and internal conflict have stalled the Kaladan and Trilateral Highway projects for years.

Way Forward:

1. Regulate movement through **upgraded border infrastructure** and **formalised trade points**, while preserving **traditional cross-border ties**.
2. **Multi-Stakeholder Engagement**: Maintain relations with the **military regime** while engaging **pro-democracy groups and civil society** to ensure long-term stability.
3. **Engagements with neighbors such as Thailand, Bangladesh, Laos, and eventually even China** are important to ensure some kind of stability.
4. India needs to enact **domestic refugee policy legislation** to bring clarity on India's stance, as **the Foreigners Act, 1946, fails to address the specific problems faced by refugees.**
5. **Strengthen Security Cooperation**: Enhance **counterinsurgency coordination, intelligence sharing, and joint operations** along border regions.
6. Early completion of projects like **the Kaladan multi-modal transport corridor, India-Myanmar-Thailand trilateral** highway, etc is needed.
7. Working with like-minded countries like **Japan,** which has a growing economic presence and similar interests in Myanmar.

India Sri Lanka Relations:

"Geography has made us neighbors, but history and culture have made us brothers." - **Former President Ranil Wickremesinghe**

"Sri Lanka is a central pillar of our 'Neighborhood First' policy and our 'SAGAR' vision." - **PM Narendra Modi**

Recent News

- **Debt restructuring support (2025):** India converted loans into grants and reduced the interest burden, critical for Sri Lanka's economic recovery.
- **Operation Sagar Bandhu (2026):** India acted as the first responder, rushing emergency relief supplies during **Cyclone Ditwah** in early 2026.
- **IMF Debt Restructuring (2025):** India played a pivotal role in securing Sri Lanka's final debt sustainability certification from the IMF.

PM Narendra Modi visited Sri Lanka in April 2026

- **Highest Civilian Honour**: PM Modi awarded **Sri Lanka Mitra Vibhushana**.
- **Defence Cooperation**: Signed a **5-year Defence MoU** for **joint exercises, maritime security, and defence collaboration**. Assurance that Sri Lankan territory won't be used against India.
- **Energy & Infrastructure**:
  - **Grid interconnection** for electricity trade.
  - Tripartite MoU between India-UAE-Sri Lanka to develop **Trincomalee energy hub.**
- **Development & Finance Support**:

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- **USD 100 million loans converted to grants.**
- Key projects launched: **Maho-Omanthai railway**, **Sampur Solar Project**, **solar rooftop for 5,000 religious sites (25 MW).**

- **Cultural Diplomacy**: Transfer of **Lord Buddha relics** for **Vesak celebrations (2025).**

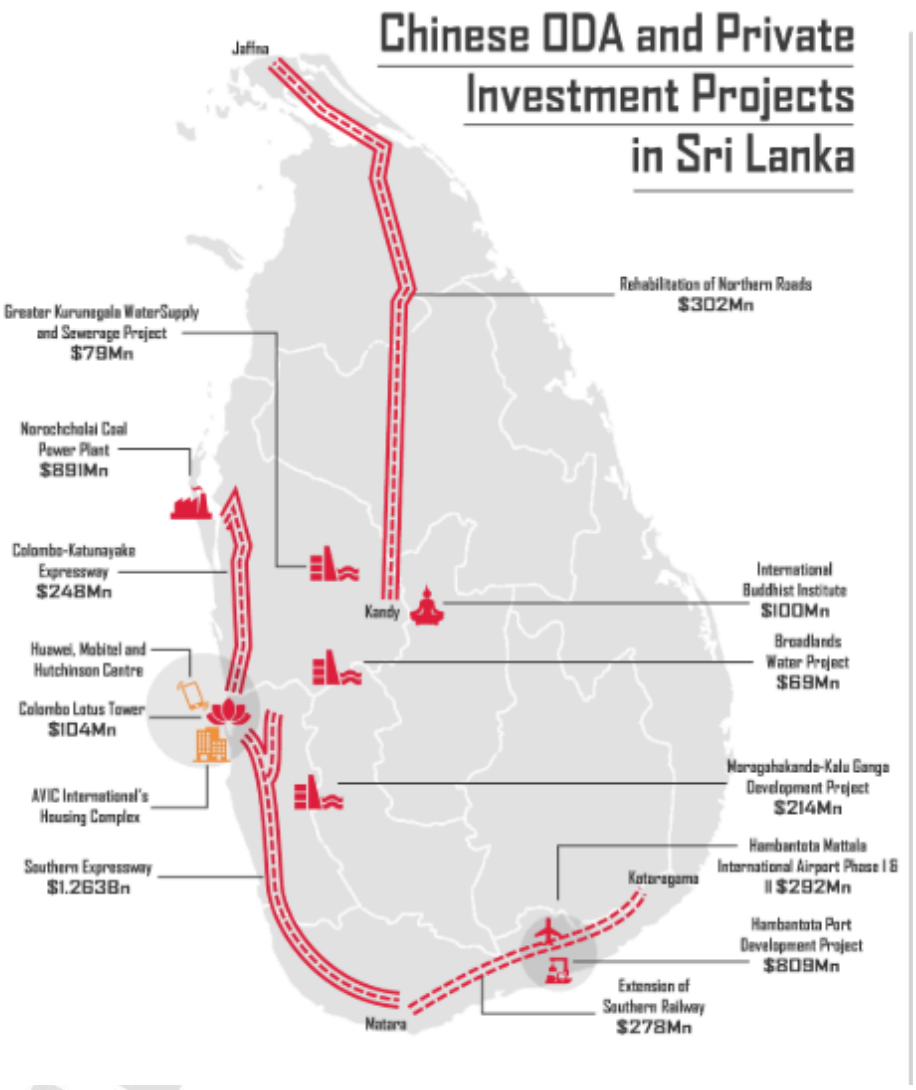
Importance of Sri Lanka:

1. **Strategic and Security Importance**
   a. **Geostrategic Location**: Lies just **30 km** off the Indian coast near Tamil Nadu, controlling vital sea lanes in the **Indian Ocean Region (IOR)**.
   b. **Maritime Security**: Crucial for India's role in ensuring safety in the **Sea Lines of Communication (SLOCs)**, especially through the **Palk Strait and Gulf of Mannar**.
   c. **Countering Chinese Influence:** Eg. Indian development of the **East Container Terminal** counters Chinese dominance in Colombo Port.
   d. **Neighborhood First:** Eg. India's $450 million rebuilding package in 2026 showcases commitment to regional stability.
2. **Economic and Trade Relations**
   a. **Major Trade Partner**: India remains Sri Lanka's top trading partner, with bilateral trade reaching **$5.5 billion** in 2025-26. **The Free Trade Agreement** (ISFTA) was signed in 2000.
   b. **Emergency Support**: India provided **$4 billion in aid (2022)** during Sri Lanka's economic crisis-fuel, food, and forex assistance.
3. **Political and Diplomatic Ties**
   a. **Shared Democratic Values**: Both are members of **SAARC**, **BIMSTEC**, and the **Indian Ocean Rim Association (IORA)**.
   b. **Stability in the Neighbourhood**: Political stability in Sri Lanka is essential for India's **Neighbourhood First Policy** and **SAGAR** vision.
4. **Military and defense significance:** Both conduct joint Military **(Mitra Shakti) and Naval exercises (SLINEX).**
5. **Cultural and Historical Links**
   a. **Civilizational Ties**: Deep-rooted **Buddhist linkages**; Emperor Ashoka's daughter, **Sanghamitra,** carried Buddhism to Sri Lanka.
   b. **Ethnic Connections**: Large population of **Indian-origin Tamils**; ties with Tamil Nadu politics and diaspora interests.
6. **Energy and Infrastructure Cooperation**
   a. **Trincomalee Oil Farm**: Joint development between Indian Oil Corporation and Ceylon Petroleum Corporation.
   b. **Renewable Energy**: MoUs signed for **solar and wind energy** projects in Mannar and Pooneryn with Indian support.

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Challenges in relationships:

1. **China's Expanding Influence**
   a. **Strategic encirclement** via China's investment in **Hambantota Port (99-year lease)** and **Colombo Port City** under the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI).
   b. **Military docking of Chinese vessels** near Indian waters. Eg. Chinese **"research vessels" (spy ships)** like Yuan Wang-5.
2. **Katchatheevu issue:** Political rhetoric in India regarding the 1974-76 treaties and demands for the **"retrieval"** of the island.
3. **Allegations of "lack of transparency"** in Indian renewable energy and port projects spark local protests. Eg. Protests in **Mannar and Pooneryn** targeted Adani's wind power projects.
4. **Tamil Ethnic Issue**
   a. Alleged **war crimes against Tamil civilians** during Sri Lanka's civil war still resonate in **Tamil Nadu politics**.
   b. Colombo's **delay in devolving power to provincial councils** (Tamil areas) despite repeated Indian pressure.
   c. Perceived **lack of progress in reconciliation** affects public and political trust in India-Sri Lanka ties.
5. **Debt Diplomacy and Economic Crisis**
   a. Sri Lanka's **external debt (~$50 billion)** includes large Chinese loans.
   b. Despite India's **$4 billion aid package (2022)**, pro-China lobbies in Colombo remain strong.
6. **Fishermen Disputes: In 2024 alone, 324 Tamil fishermen and 44 boats were apprehended by the Sri Lankan Navy.**
7. **Trade and Connectivity Imbalance**
   a. Projects like the **Trincomalee Oil Tank Farm** and **East Container Terminal** have seen **delays or reversals** under Sri Lankan political pressure.
   b. **Renewable energy friction:** Indian private investment (wind projects) faced tariff disputes and withdrawal (2025).
8. **Internal Political Instability in Sri Lanka:** Frequent regime changes and **populist domestic politics** often stall agreements with India.
9. **Public Perception and Nationalism**
   a. Sections of Sri Lankan media and polity view India's involvement as **interference** or "big brother" behavior.
   b. Cultural sensitivities and **historical baggage (IPKF intervention in 1987-90)** linger.



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Way Forward:

1. **Support Tamil Reconciliation:** Encourage full implementation of the **13th Amendment** for devolution of powers to Tamil-majority regions.
2. **Strengthen Economic Integration**
   a. Expedite the **Economic and Technology Cooperation Agreement (ETCA)**.
   b. Focus on enhancing trade, services, and joint ventures in MSMEs and renewable energy.
3. **Resolve Fishermen Conflict:** Implement **joint patrolling, hotlines**, and promote **deep-sea fishing** alternatives.
4. **Boost Cultural and Religious Diplomacy**
   a. Promote **Ramayana and Buddhist tourism circuits**.
   b. Encourage student exchanges and scholarships to build soft power ties.
5. **Enhance Maritime Cooperation:** Expand **SLINEX naval exercises** and intelligence-sharing mechanisms.
6. **Accelerate Connectivity and Infrastructure Projects**
   a. Fast-track India-backed projects like **Trincomalee Oil Farms** and **Palaly Airport**.
   b. Explore potential for a **land bridge or undersea connectivity**.
7. **Promote Development Diplomacy:** Scale up **High Impact Community Development Projects (HICDPs)** in housing, education, and healthcare.
8. **Institutionalize Crisis Response:** Create a **joint response framework** for economic shocks, pandemics, and natural disasters.

"Neighbours first, partners forever" - India and Sri Lanka must nurture civilizational ties through people-centric diplomacy under the Neighbourhood First policy.

India Maldives Relations:

S. Jaishankar - "The India-Maldives relationship is built on trust, transparency, and mutual respect. We envision a future where our partnership is stronger and more resilient than ever."

History:

1. **In 1965, the Maldives gained Independence from the British.** India was one of the first countries to establish diplomatic relations with the Maldives. **Indian Mission was set up in Male in 1972.**
2. **In 1988, India sent its troops** and ships to **help Gayoom overthrow a coup attempt** by a Maldivian businessman and Sri Lankan Tamil fighters.

Recent news

- **"Vision for Comprehensive Economic & Maritime Security Partnership" adopted (2025-26):** Framework for long-term cooperation in economy, security, and connectivity.
- India has extended support to the Maldives in the form of a **$400 million financial package** along with a **currency swap agreement worth ₹30 billion.**
- **India-Maldives FTA negotiations initiated (2025):** Terms of Reference agreed.
- **Infrastructure push via LoC projects:** Housing (Hulhumalé), roads, ports, and urban infrastructure.
- **Fisheries cooperation agreement (2025):** Focus on sustainable marine economy and livelihoods.

Importance of the Maldives:

1. **Geo-Economic Significance: 50% of India's external trade and 80% of** energy imports transit through Sea lanes of communication (SLOCs) lying near the Maldives.

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2. **Security Significance:** Act as a **'toll gate'** between the choke points **(Gulf of Aden and the Strait of Hormuz)** and the eastern Indian Ocean **(Strait of Malacca).**
3. **Indian Diaspora: Over 27000 Indians in the Maldives.**
4. **Gaining goodwill via humanitarian Assistance:**
   a. India signed an MoU with the Maldives for **High Impact Community Development Projects (HICDPs) in 2019.**
   b. Through **Operation Sanjeevani,** India supplied 6.2 tonnes of essential medicines to the Maldives in the fight against COVID 19.
   c. India also helped address the shortage of drinking water in the Maldives in 2014 through **Operation Neer.**
5. **Ensuring security via defense Cooperation:**
   a. India and the Maldives conduct many security Joint Exercises like **"Ekuverin", "Dosti", "Ekatha" and "Operation Shield".**
   b. India has donated **Landing Assault Craft and 24 Utility Vehicles to the Maldives** to bolster maritime security.

Challenges in relationships:

1. Perceptions of Indian "Big Brother" interference often lead to domestic political backlash in the Maldives. Eg. the **"India Out" campaign** (2023-24).
2. **China's Deepening Footprint:** Eg. China's control over key infrastructure projects like **housing and energy grids** in northern atolls.
3. **Fiscal Fragility & Debt:** Maldives faces a "debt-trap" scenario, with external debt exceeding 115% of its GDP, largely to China.
4. **Radicalization & Terrorism:** Maldives has one of the highest per-capita contributors of foreign fighters to global jihadist groups.
5. **Political Inconsistency:** Frequent "U-turns" in foreign policy. Eg. shift from Solih's **"India First"** to Muizzu's anti-India stance.
6. Cancellation of **Hydrography Agreement(2019)** with India and allowing a Chinese survey ship to make a **Port Call.**

Way Forward:

1. Conclude the proposed **Free Trade Agreement** to stabilize trade and provide market access to Maldivian fish.
2. **Debt Restructuring Leadership:** India should lead a **"Creditor's Club"** for the Maldives to offer a sustainable alternative to opaque Chinese debt.
3. Activate the **Joint Working Group on Counter-Terrorism** to tackle radicalization via community-level "Soft Power" programs.
4. Increase funding for the **India-Maldives Friendship Association** to engage youth and counter anti-India narratives.

"Good fences make good neighbours," but shared waters make better partners-India-Maldives must reinforce ties through people-centric, transparent cooperation.

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Chapter 4

India and Regional Relations

PYQs

[2024] Critically analyse India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics (CARs) highlighting their increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics. (10)
[2023] 'Virus of Conflict is affecting the functioning of the SCO'. In the light of the above statement, point out the role of India in mitigating problems. (10)
[2022] Do you think that BIMSTEC is a parallel organisation like the SAARC? What are the similarities and dissimilarities between the two? How are Indian foreign policy objectives realized by forming this new organisation? (10)
[2022] How will I2U2 (India, Israel, UAE and USA) grouping transform India's position in global politics ? (15)
[2021] "If the last few decades were Asia's growth story, the next few are expected to be Africa's." In the light of this statement, examine India's influence in Africa in recent years. (10)
[2021] Critically examine the aims and objectives of SCO. What importance does it hold for India? (15)
[2021] The newly tri-nation partnership AUKUS is aimed at countering China's ambitions in the Indo-Pacific region. Is it going to supersede the existing partnerships in the region? Discuss the strength and impact of AUKUS in the present scenario. (15)
[2017] The question of India's Energy Security constitutes the most important part of India's economic progress. Analyze India's energy policy cooperation with West Asian Countries. (15)

India And West Asia:

PM Modi, "India shares deep civilizational ties with West Asia and the Arab world. **Our relationship is driven by mutual respect, shared values, and a commitment to peace and development."**

Prof Girijesh Pant, "West Asia is not a place of display of India's power. It is a place of Augmentation of India's Power".

Current Affairs

- Long-term **~$3 billion LNG agreement** signed with UAE (ADNOC Gas → HPCL). (Jan 2026)
- **Operation Sankalp 2.0:** Institutionalized as a permanent naval escort architecture in the North Arabian Sea to protect merchant vessels from regional proxy attacks.
- **Rupee-Dirham Trade Scaling:** The Local Currency Settlement System (LCSS) with the UAE surpassed **$5 billion** in transactions, bypassing the SWIFT network.
- **India-GCC FTA Milestone:** Final technical rounds for the Free Trade Agreement concluded, targeting zero duty on Indian electronics and textiles.
- **I2U2 "Food Park":** Inauguration of the first integrated food park in Gujarat funded by the UAE to enhance regional food security.
- **Farzad-B Gas Field Breakthrough:** New technical agreements signed between ONGC Videsh and Iranian authorities for field development despite global sanctions.

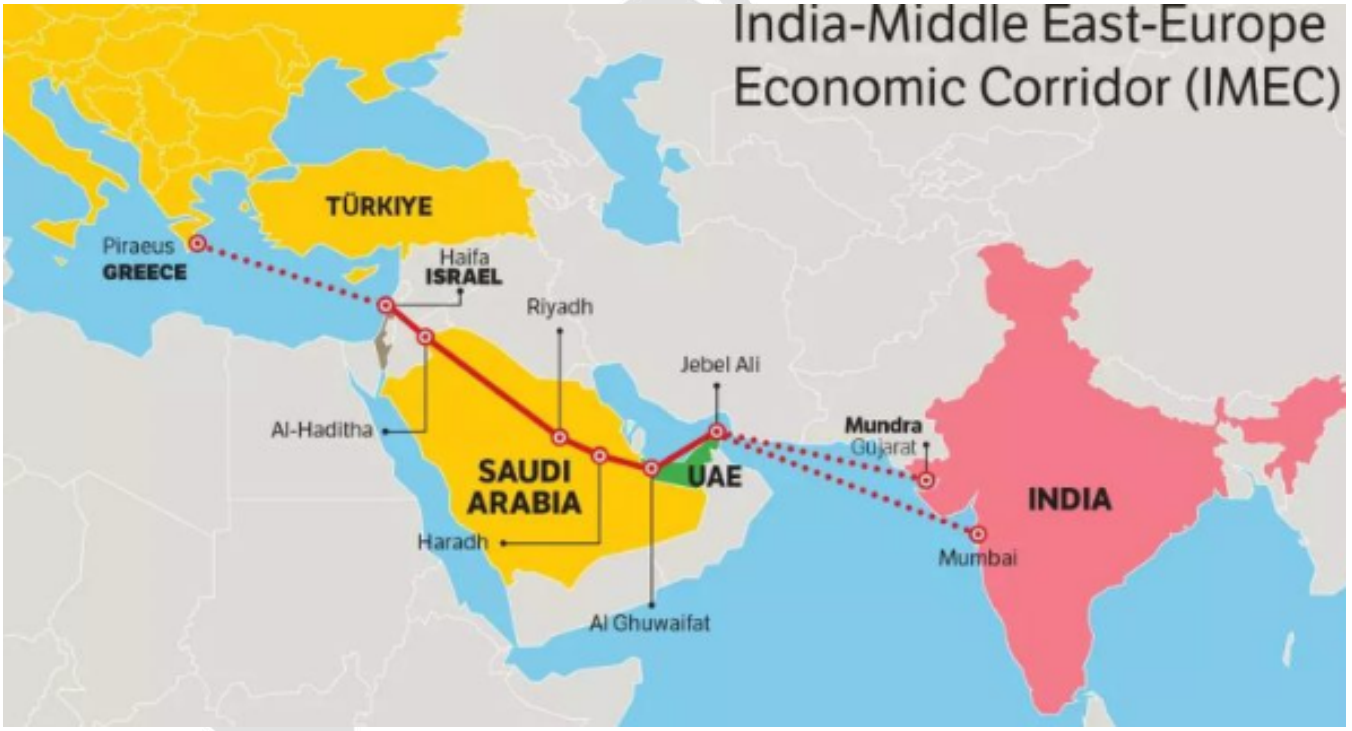
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History of India's West Asia Policy

1. **Post-Independence:** India's policy was guided by the **Non-Aligned Movement (NAM)** and a strong pro-Arab stance, largely due to oil dependence and the Palestinian cause.
2. **Post-Cold War:** In 1992, India established full diplomatic ties with **Israel**, initiating a "balancing act" between Arab nations, Iran, and Israel.
3. **"Look West" Launch (2005)** to mirror the success of the "Look East" policy, focusing on the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC).
4. **"Think West" (2014-Present):** Elevated by the Modi government to prioritize high-level political engagement, moving beyond "oil and diaspora" to include maritime security, counter-terrorism, and investment.
5. **Strategic Convergence (2020-2026):** Marked by the **Abraham Accords** and the formation of the **I2U2** group, India now engages in minilateralism to address regional challenges.

Significance of West Asia - India relations:

1. India's "De-hyphenation" policy allows it to be a bridge between Israel and Iran. Eg. India remains the only power with a Special Strategic Partnership with both Tel Aviv and Riyadh.
2. Energy Bedrock: The region provides nearly 60% of India's crude and 70% of its LPG/LNG needs.
3. **Saudi Arabia's Vision 2030 and the UAE's energy transition** goals align with India's green energy ambitions.



4. **During FY 2024-25,** India-GCC bilateral trade stood at $**178 billion,** making the GCC India's largest trading partner bloc
5. **The UAE and India launched the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA)** to enhance bilateral trade and economic ties further.
6. The region contributes **~38% of India's global remittances,** vital for foreign exchange stability
7. **Control over Strategic Maritime Chokepoint:** India's maritime strategy relies on Hormuz's "exit-guarantee" for its energy-agriculture food security nexus.

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8. **Agricultural Export Hub:** West Asia is the primary destination for India's high-value agricultural staples like rice and buffalo meat.
9. **Fertilizer Security:** Long-term potash and phosphate supplies from Jordan and Oman are vital for India's food security.
10. **Sovereign Wealth Funds** (PIF, ADIA) are major investors in India's National Infrastructure Pipeline. Eg. The UAE is now India's **7th largest investor,** with cumulative FDI reaching $25 billion.
11. **Counter-Terrorism Ally:** Institutionalized sharing of intelligence on radicalization and terror-financing with the UAE and Saudi Arabia.
12. **India has secured access to Port Duqm of Oman for military use and logistic support.**
13. **Connectivity Hub (IMEC):** The region is the gateway for India's land-sea bridge to Europe, bypassing the Suez.
14. **Diaspora Protection:** The scale of the diaspora (10 million) makes West Asia a domestic political priority for India.

West Asia crisis

On **February 28, 2026**, the US and Israel launched a surprise joint offensive against Iran, dubbed **Operation Epic Fury,** targeting its nuclear programme, military leadership, and key infrastructure.

Major Events During the War

1. **The "Epic Fury" Strike (Feb 28):** Coordinated US-Israeli strikes targeted nuclear sites, missile bases, and the supreme leadership in Tehran, resulting in the **death of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei**.
2. **Closure of the Strait of Hormuz:** Iran retaliated by effectively shutting down the world's most vital oil artery, causing global oil prices to skyrocket.
3. **The "Ring of Fire" Response:** Iran-backed proxies, including Hezbollah and the Houthis, launched thousands of drones and missiles at Israel and US bases in Bahrain, Qatar, and the UAE.



4. **Nuclear Facility Damage:** Successive strikes on Kharg Island and Natanz reportedly significantly degraded Iran's enrichment capabilities but failed to fully eliminate the program.

Impact of Crisis

On West Asia (Middle East)

1. **State Fragility:** The war has pushed Lebanon and Syria toward total state collapse and humanitarian catastrophe. Eg. millions of new refugees are fleeing toward Jordan and Turkey, destabilizing regional borders.
2. **Nuclear Proliferation:** Neighbouring states are now reconsidering their own "nuclear options" for future self-defense.
3. **Shift in Alliances:**
   a. The crisis has forced Arab nations into a difficult choice between US security and Iranian proximity.
   b. The "Abraham Accords" are under extreme pressure due to rising pro-Palestine and pro-Iran public sentiment.
4. **Infrastructure Devastation:** Eg. significant damage to desalination plants and power grids in the UAE and Qatar.

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5. **Proxy Evolution:** Militias have become more autonomous, operating without direct central command from a weakened Tehran. Eg. Houthis have expanded their reach into the Indian Ocean.
6. **Humanitarian crisis:** 5000+ killed in Iran; thousands more across Israel, Lebanon, and Gulf states.

On Global Geopolitics

1. The **US-Europe alliance strained**. Eg. France and Germany publicly condemned the strikes.
2. **Russia-China Consolidation:** The war has solidified a "resistance bloc" against perceived Western unilateralism.
3. **UN Credibility Crisis:** The inability of the UN Security Council to prevent the conflict has marginalized the organization.
4. **Weaponry Innovation:** The war served as a testing ground for AI-driven drone swarms and hypersonic missiles. Eg. Global defense budgets are shifting toward low-cost "attrition warfare" technology over traditional tanks.
5. **Rise of Neutral Middle Powers:** Eg. The "Islamabad Accords" highlight the shift of diplomatic gravity toward non-Western regional powers.

On India

1. West Asia's geopolitical volatility, with conflicts like **Israel-Hamas and the US-Iran, complicates India's traditional non-alignment & multi vector policy.**
2. **Strategic Autonomy Issues:** Eg. The sinking of the Iranian warship IRIS Dena in the Indian Ocean by a U.S. submarine has challenged India's role as Net Security Provider in the IOR.
3. **Energy:** India imports ~85% of its crude needs. Qatar supplies ~40% of India's LNG imports. Strait of Hormuz closure disrupts over 85% of India's LPG supply daily.
4. **Trade Routes:** India's exports to Europe, Africa, and the Americas via Suez face delays and 20-30% higher freight costs.
5. **Chokepoint Vulnerability:** Blockades in the Strait of Hormuz or Red Sea effectively paralyze India's trade and energy arteries.
6. **Seafarer Exposure:** Eg. Nearly 700 Indian sailors were stuck on commercial ships near Hormuz during the 2026 crisis.
7. **Connectivity Uncertainty:** The IMEC depends on regional peace; ongoing wars render the **project strategically non-viable. Similarly, Chabahar port faces military risk and sanctions.**
8. **Radicalization risk:** Instability in Yemen, Syria, and Iraq creates vacuums that transnational terror groups can exploit.
9. **Fertilisers:** Gulf-sourced urea and phosphate imports are disrupted, threatening the Rabi agricultural input supply chain.
10. **Diaspora Safety:** The conflict endangered nearly 10 million Indian expatriates working across the West Asian region.
11. **Remittance Decline:** Eg. states like Kerala have reported a 20% decline in monthly inflows from the Gulf.

On Energy Markets

1. **Price Volatility:** Brent crude prices crossed **$120 per barrel** during the Hormuz blockade.
2. **Maritime Premium Surge:** Marine "war-risk" insurance premiums skyrocketed by over **1,000%** for vessels entering the Gulf.
3. **LNG Supply Crunch:** Qatar's Ras Laffan LNG facility shut down, removing 19% of global LNG trade.
4. **Strategic Reserve Depletion:** Major economies have exhausted their emergency oil stocks to stabilize domestic markets.
5. **New Supply Routes:** The war has prioritized the development of pipelines that bypass the Persian Gulf entirely. Eg. renewed interest in the East-West pipeline through Saudi Arabia to the Red Sea.

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India's stance on the war

India has moved from its traditional "passive neutrality" to a more active, principled positioning based on 3 distinct layers:

- **Condemnation of Attacks on Sovereignty (Pro-GCC):**
  - In a departure from past hesitance, India **co-sponsored a Bahrain-led UNSC Resolution** in March 2026.
  - The PM personally called the leaders of Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Bahrain to condemn the violation of their territorial integrity.
- **Rejection of Regime Change:** Despite condemning the strikes, India has **not condemned the Iranian government itself** nor the assassination of its leadership.
- **Crisis Management:** With 90% of LPG imports passing through Hormuz, India negotiated a **"Humanitarian Window"** with Tehran to allow specific Indian-flagged tankers to pass.

Way Forward

1. **Energy Supply Diversification:** Eg. Utilizing the **East-West Pipeline** (Saudi Arabia) and **Habshan-Fujairah** (UAE) to bypass the strait.
2. **Maritime Security Leadership:** Deploying Indian Navy assets in the Arabian Sea to act as a "net security provider" for merchant vessels.
3. Leveraging India's unique position as a **"civilizational anchor"** to facilitate back-channel talks between the US, Israel, and Iran.
4. **Fiscal Buffering for Exporters:** Providing relief packages to Indian exporters struggling with a **1,000% spike** in war-risk insurance premiums.
5. Utilizing the **BRICS framework** to build a Global South consensus on de-escalation and energy security.
6. Accelerating the **shift to biomass and renewable** fuels to reduce long-term dependence on West Asian crude.

India-Iran relations

India and Iran share a deep-seated civilizational bond that has transitioned into a complex, strategic partnership in the modern era.

History of India-Iran Relations

1. **Ancient Affinities:** Deep cultural and linguistic linkages dating back to the Indo-Aryan period; Persian was the official court language in India for centuries.
2. **1950 Friendship Treaty:** India was among the first countries to establish diplomatic ties with the newly formed Republic of Iran post-WWII.
3. **Cold War Divergence:** Relations were lukewarm as Iran joined the US-led **CENTO**, while India pursued the **Non-Aligned Movement** and stayed close to the USSR.
4. **1979 Revolution Shift:** Following the Islamic Revolution, India was quick to recognize the new government, moving toward a "Strategic Partnership."
5. **Tehran Declaration (2001):** PM Vajpayee's visit institutionalized cooperation in energy, trade, and regional security.
6. **New Delhi Declaration (2003):** Signed during President Khatami's visit as Republic Day Chief Guest, it set the blueprint for a long-term strategic partnership.

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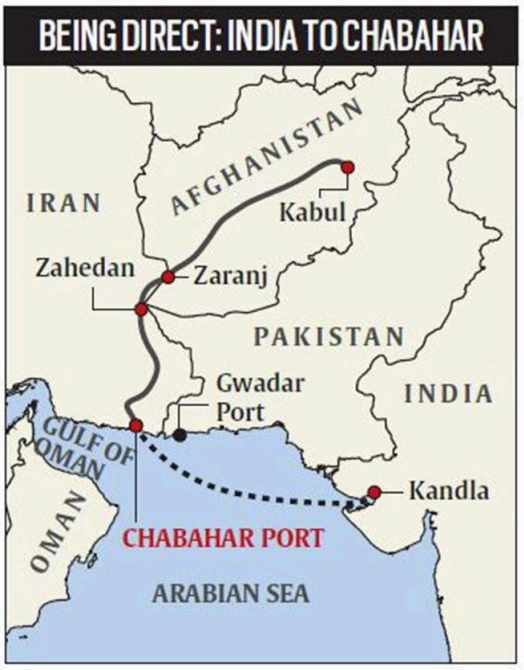
7. **Nuclear Vote Friction (2005-2009):** Ties were strained when India voted against Iran at the **IAEA** regarding its nuclear program to secure the US-India Civil Nuclear Deal.
8. **The Chabahar Era (2016-Present):** PM Modi's 2016 visit marked the transition to a connectivity-focused relationship, centering on the Chabahar Port.

Recent News

1. **10-Year Chabahar Pact (2024)** to operate the **Shahid Beheshti terminal**.
2. Iran's formal entry into the **Shanghai Cooperation Organization** in 2025.
3. **Red Sea Crisis Diplomacy (2025):** India and Iran held high-level talks to ensure the safety of commercial shipping lanes in the Arabian Sea.
4. **Pezeshkian-Modi call (March 2026):** Leaders met to discuss the "Gaza-Middle East Corridor" and finalized a "Joint Roadmap for Energy Security."
5. **INSTC Trial Runs (2025-26):** Successful maiden transport of Indian goods to Russia via Iran's **Anzali Port.**

Significance of Iran for India

1. **Gateway to Central Asia: Chabahar Port** provides the only viable land-sea route for India to reach Afghanistan & resource-rich Central Asian republics.
2. **Energy Security Diversification:** Iran possesses the world's second-largest gas and fourth-largest oil reserves, crucial for India's growing industrial energy needs.
3. Iran is the geographic heart of the **International North-South Transport Corridor**, linking Mumbai to Moscow and Europe.
4. **Countering Chinese Influence:** Strategic presence in Iran's Chabahar acts as a counter-balance to the Chinese-operated **Gwadar Port** in Pakistan.
5. **Afghanistan Stability:** Eg. jointly facilitating **humanitarian aid (wheat and vaccines)** to Kabul via the Iranian land route.
6. **Regional Security:** Shared interest in neutralizing Sunni-extremist groups like ISIS-K and Al-Qaeda that threaten regional stability.
7. **Diaspora Safety:** Over **9 million Indians** live and work in West Asia.
8. **Critical Mineral Access:** Iran has untapped reserves of lithium and copper. Eg. joint exploration ventures in the **Sistan-Baluchestan province** for battery-grade minerals.



Major Issues in India-Iran Relations

1. **US Sanctions:** Eg. major Indian banks refusing to process payments for **Chabahar-related equipment** due to CAATSA fears.
2. **The "China Factor":** The **$400 billion China-Iran 25-year pact** threatens to push India out of Iran's strategic orbit.
3. **Project Delivery Deficit:** Eg. the temporary removal of India from the **Chabahar-Zahedan railway project** in 2020 due to funding lags.
4. **Oil Import Halt:** India stopped importing Iranian oil in 2019 to satisfy US waivers, hurting bilateral trust.
5. **Divergent Israel Ties:** India's growing defense partnership with Israel clashes with Iran's staunch ideological opposition to the Zionist state.

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6. Occasional friction regarding Iran's comments on **Kashmir** or Indian domestic issues impacts diplomatic synergy.

Way Forward

1. India must exercise **"strategic autonomy"** by creating a non-dollar clearing house for Iran trade.
2. **Balanced West Asian Policy:** India should act as a bridge between Iran and the Arab world to ensure regional de-escalation.
3. **Energy Resumption:** Explore "Sanction-proof" oil-for-goods swaps.
4. **Focus on Afghanistan:** Use the Chabahar-Kabul link to provide a non-Pakistani alternative for the Afghan economy.
5. **Maritime Security Pact:** Formalize a joint patrolling mechanism in the Gulf of Oman to counter piracy and "dark vessel" activity.

India-Israel Relations

As Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu stated, **"The sky is the limit for India-Israel cooperation"** - symbolizing deep mutual trust and strategic alignment.

As former diplomat T.P. Sreenivasan observed, **"India-Israel relations represent the maturing of India's foreign policy realism."**

Current Affairs

- During PM Modi's visit, India and Israel upgraded ties to **"special strategic partnership".**
- **Labour Mobility Agreement:** Protocols signed to facilitate the employment of **50,000 Indian workers** in Israel's construction and caregiving sectors over the next five years.

Significance of India-Israel relations

1. **Defence Technology Pillar:** Israel is the 4th largest supplier of advanced weaponry, providing critical technologies like UAVs and missile systems. Eg. **Barak-8 LRSAM** project.
2. **Agricultural Cooperation:** Israeli drip irrigation and **"fertigation"** technologies are vital for water-stressed farming regions. Over 35 Centres of Excellence are operational across India.
3. **Intelligence and Counter-Terrorism:** Both nations share a **"zero tolerance"** policy and maintain deep institutionalized sharing of real-time intelligence
4. **Water Security Leadership:** Israel's expertise in desalination and wastewater recycling supports India's Jal Jeevan Mission and Namami Gange.
5. **Critical & Emerging Technology (iCET):** A joint initiative led by NSAs to synergize strengths in AI, semiconductors, and space exploration.
6. **Maritime Connectivity (IMEC):** Israel serves as the Mediterranean gateway for the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor.
7. **Adani Group's acquisition of Haifa Port (2023)** anchors India's long-term logistical presence in the Levant.
8. **Economic Diversification:** Trade is expanding into chemicals, medical devices, and high-end electronics. Bilateral merchandise trade reached **$11 billion (excl. defence) in FY 2024-25.**

Major Areas-of Friction

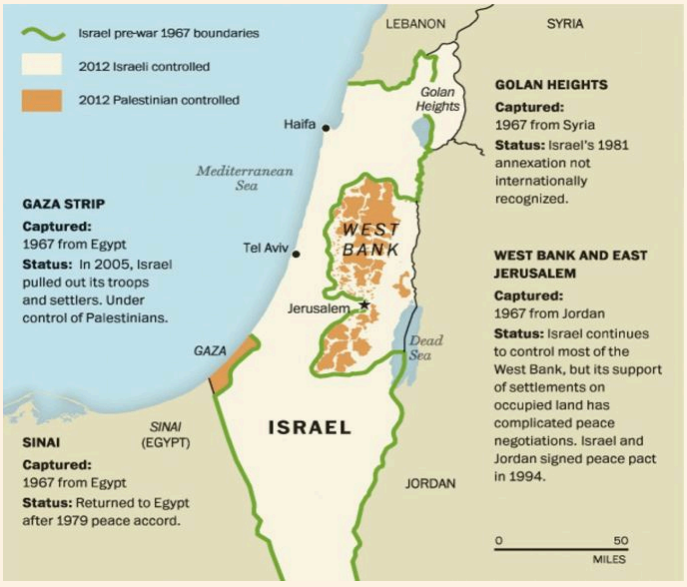
1. **Palestine Policy Divergence:** India maintains principled support for Palestine and the two-state solution, conflicting with Israel's expectations of full diplomatic alignment.

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2. **Regional Instability:** Escalating conflicts in West Asia **(Israel-Hezbollah/Iran)** threaten the stability of the IMEC corridor.
3. **The "Iran Factor":** India's strategic interest in Chabahar Port and energy ties with Iran often clash with Israel's security priorities.
4. **Geopolitical Balancing:** Harsh V. Pant (ORF) notes, **"India walks a tightrope between its strategic embrace of Israel and economic entrenchment in the Gulf."**
5. **Slow Progress on Economic and Trade Diversification:** non-defense trade remains modest and over-reliant on diamonds and agriculture.
6. **Technology transfer issue**: Israel's reluctance **to share core source codes or sensitive high-end algorithms** leads to procurement delays.
7. **FTA Stalemate:** Despite multiple rounds since 2010, a comprehensive Free Trade Agreement remains elusive due to IPR and services disputes.
8. **Cyber-Espionage Allegations:** Reports of Israeli-origin spyware (Pegasus) have caused domestic political controversies and trust issues within India.
9. **China's Influence:** Eg. Chinese involvement in **Haifa's New Bay Terminal** competing with India-led infrastructure initiatives.
10. **Domestic Political & Ideological Sensitivities:** Sections of the Indian polity, especially from left and minority groups, criticize deepening ties with Israel, especially during conflicts.

India's Stance on Israel-Palestine

- **Traditional Support for Palestine (1947-1991)**
  - India was the **first non-Arab country to recognize Palestine in 1988**.
  - Voted consistently **against Israel at the UN** and supported the **two-state solution**.
  - Hosted **PLO Chairman Yasser Arafat** multiple times; India regarded the PLO as the **sole legitimate representative of the Palestinians**.
- **Normalization and Strategic Engagement with Israel (Post-1992)**
  - India **established full diplomatic relations with Israel in 1992**, while continuing to support Palestine.
  - Adopted a **de-hyphenation policy**: maintaining **independent bilateral ties** with both.
- **Recent Position and Continuity (2017-2023)**
  - PM Modi visited **Israel in 2017**, the **first Indian PM to do so**, but **did not visit Palestine** on the same trip - seen as symbolic.
  - In **2018**, Modi visited Ramallah and reiterated support for **"a sovereign, independent, viable and united Palestine living peacefully with Israel."**
  - India began abstaining from some **anti-Israel resolutions** at the UNHRC, reflecting calibrated neutrality.



- **India's Present Stance (2024)**
- **Two-State Solution:** Reaffirmed as the only viable solution. India supports "a sovereign, independent Palestine coexisting with Israel." (MEA, Oct 2023)

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- **On Civilian Deaths in Gaza:** Called for **restraint, humanitarian aid, and ceasefire**; Abstained on **UNGA Gaza ceasefire resolution (Oct 2023)**.
- **UN Voting Pattern (2023-24):** Mixed approach - abstained on ceasefire, supported humanitarian resolutions. **Maintains balance** in multilateral forums.
- **Development Support:** Continues to fund development projects (schools, IT centers) in the West Bank under the **India-Palestine Development Partnership.**

Way Forward

1. **Broaden Beyond Defence to Innovation Diplomacy**
   a. Expand cooperation in **health tech, agri-tech, water management, and AI** under the **India-Israel Industrial R&D Fund (I4F)**.
   b. Eg. Israel's water recycling model in the Negev can be adapted in Indian dry zones like Bundelkhand.
2. **Conclude the Long-Pending Free Trade Agreement (FTA):** Accelerate negotiation through a sectoral approach - pharma, electronics, IT, and medical devices.
3. **Promote People-to-People and Academic Ties:** Establish India-Israel Chairs in major universities; increase scholarships and exchange programs in STEM fields.
4. Establish a dedicated **Joint Counter-Terrorism Task Force** and share best practices on **urban policing, cyber defense, and drone warfare**.
5. Balance West Asia Outreach with Strategic Clarity: Adopt a principled realpolitik guided by issue-based alignments rather than ideological camps.
6. **Joint Collaboration in Global South Development**: Eg. launch **triangular development projects in Africa and South Asia** under platforms like **I2U2**.

In a multipolar world, India-Israel relations serve as a model for principled, pragmatic, and mutually beneficial diplomacy beyond ideology and blocs.

Key Highlights of the USA's Gaza Peace Plan

- **Disarmament of Hamas:** Aims to **disarm Hamas** and make **Gaza a terror-free zone.** Hamas members may receive **amnesty or safe passage** to countries like **Jordan, Egypt, Qatar, or Iran**, with **no forced eviction** of Gaza residents.
- **International Security Force (ISF):** A **temporary multinational force** will secure Gaza and **train Palestinian police.** The **IDF will withdraw gradually**, retaining a **security perimeter** until stability is achieved.
- **New Governance Framework:** Gaza to be led by a **technocratic, apolitical Palestinian committee** under an international **"Board of Peace"** chaired by **Donald Trump.**
- **Humanitarian Aid & Hostage Exchange:** Immediate **humanitarian assistance** for reconstruction and a **hostage-prisoner swap**-all hostages released within **72 hours** of Israel's acceptance.
- **Regional Support:** Backed by **Qatar, Jordan, UAE, Saudi Arabia, and Pakistan**, providing **regional guarantees** for implementation and compliance.

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India And Africa:

Narendra Modi - "Our partnership is not just about sharing resources but about sharing dreams and a vision for a brighter future."

As per **Suhasini Haider, for African countries, India doesn't represent just a 'white knight' or trading partner;** It represents a country with similar problems that it has solved through low-cost innovations.

Recent News

- India hosted the **4th India-Africa Forum Summit** in New Delhi (after a gap of 10 years) under the theme **"IA SPIRIT"** (Innovation, Resilience, and Inclusive Transformation).
- **BRICS Presidency 2026:** India's presidency prioritized the integration of new African members (**Egypt and Ethiopia**) into the group's financial and security architecture.
- India finalized **"Mine-to-Market" agreement**s with **Zambia and Namibia** for the joint extraction of copper and lithium.
- **$100 Billion Trade Milestone:** Bilateral trade officially crossed the **$103 billion** mark in FY 2025-26, making India Africa's third-largest trading partner.
- Following Mauritius, **Namibia and Ghana** officially integrated **India's UPI stack** into their national payment gateways in early 2026.
- During the PM visit, **India and Ethiopia** elevated their bilateral ties to a **Strategic Partnership.**

Africa's Resource Potential:

- Africa is home to some **30% of the world's mineral reserves, 8 % of the world's natural gas, and 12 %** of the world's oil reserves.
- The continent has **40 % of the world's gold and up to 90 % of** its chromium and platinum.
- **It holds 65 % of the** world's arable land and 10 % of the planet's internal renewable fresh water source.
- Africa accounts for **48% of cobalt and 47% of manganese reserves.**

Significance of Africa for India:

1. **Global South Leadership:** Eg. India's pivotal role in securing the African Union's permanent membership in the G20.
2. **Critical Mineral Security:** Eg. sourcing Cobalt and Manganese from the Democratic Republic of Congo for India's PLI battery schemes.
3. **Safeguarding Indian investments.** Eg. **22.5% India's FDI outwards flow is towards Africa, and** current investment is around **$32 bn**.
4. **Energy Diversification:** Eg. increased crude imports from Nigeria and Angola during the 2026 West Asian security crisis.
5. **Maritime Security (SAGAR):** Cooperation in the Western Indian Ocean is essential for combatting piracy and ensuring safe trade routes.
6. **Demographic Market Potential:** Africa's 1.4 billion people offer a massive, youthful consumer market for Indian MSMEs and services.
7. **Food Security Nexus:** Africa's uncultivated arable land can serve as a "global granary" through Indian agricultural expertise. Eg. cooperation with Ethiopia and Sudan for pulses.

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8. **UNSC Reform:** Support from 54 African nations is indispensable for India's permanent seat at the UN. Alignment of the Ezulwini Consensus with the G4 position on UNSC expansion.
9. **Countering Competition:** Strategic engagement prevents a unipolar regional order dominated by Chinese infrastructure-based "debt-trap" diplomacy.
10. **Diaspora Soft Power:** The 3-million-strong Indian diaspora acts as a bridge for investment and cultural influence across the continent.
11. **Cooperation at the WTO**: Eg. **at the Bali Ministerial in 2013,** both advocated an interim mechanism for **safeguarding MSP to farmers against WTO caps.**
12. Nearly half of all **member countries in the International Solar Alliance,** initiated by India, are from Africa.

Points of Friction:

1. **Strategic Inertia & Diplomatic Underrepresentation:** India has only ~50 missions in Africa vs. China's 60+, limiting **India's diplomatic footprint**.
2. **Lack of Coherent Africa Policy**: India's approach is often **bilateral and fragmented**, lacking a **pan-African strategy** despite platforms like the **India-Africa Forum Summit (IAFS)**.
3. **Chinese Dominance:** China's BRI presence dwarfs India's development budget. China's trade with Africa remains **triple the volume** of India-Africa trade as of 2026.
4. **Trade remains heavily skewed toward raw commodities** rather than diversified value-added manufacturing. Eg. crude and gold form **70% of India's imports** from Africa.
5. **Implementation Gaps:** Indian-funded projects under Lines of Credit (LoC) often face significant procedural and bureaucratic delays.
6. **Political Instability:** Frequent coups in the Sahel region and civil unrest disrupt long-term Indian investments and personnel. Eg. suspension of **mining operations in Mali** in 2024-25.
7. **Perception of Racism:** Isolated incidents of discrimination against African students in India create negative soft-power narratives abroad. **Eg.** attack on Nigerian students in Delhi.
8. India's engagement with Africa has been criticized for being **too focused on East and Southern Africa**, neglecting other regions.
9. **Debt Sustainability Concerns:** Rising African debt to India (over $12 billion in LoCs) has raised **concerns over repayment capacity**, especially in low-income nations.
10. **Perception Issues of Indian Products:** Eg. **Tainted syrup medicine** imported from India led to the death of **more than 60 children in the West African nation of Gambia in 2022.**
11. **Maritime Piracy:** Resurgence of piracy in the Gulf of Guinea and Red Sea increases insurance premiums for Indian shipping.

Way Forward:

1. Develop an integrated **"India-Africa Strategy 2030"**, focusing on region-specific needs (Eg. Sahel, Horn of Africa, Southern Africa).
2. **Expand Diplomatic Footprint:** Open embassies in all 54 African countries and increase the frequency of **high-level summits and ministerial dialogues** to ensure sustained engagement.
3. **Fast-track Development Projects & LoCs:** Create a **project monitoring unit** under the Ministry of External Affairs to ensure timely execution and transparency.
4. **Diversify Trade & Investment**
    a. Move beyond extractives; Focus on **solar energy (ISA), digital tech, pharma, textiles, and agro-processing**.
    b. Strengthen ties with **AfCFTA (African Continental Free Trade Area)** to access unified African markets.

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5. **Strengthen Capacity Building & Human Capital Linkages:** Expand **ITEC, e-Vidya Bharati and e-Arogya Bharati (e-VBAB)** tele-education and telemedicine schemes.
6. **Build Maritime and Blue Economy Partnerships**
   a. Enhance cooperation under **SAGAR (Security and Growth for All in the Region)** in Indian Ocean states like Seychelles, Mozambique, and Madagascar.
   b. Joint anti-piracy operations, port development, and logistics collaboration can deepen strategic ties.
7. **Counterbalance China through Quality Engagement**
   a. Emphasize India's **demand-driven, debt-sustainable, and training-focused development model** as distinct from China's.
   b. Promote **South-South Cooperation** via multilateral forums (IBSA, BRICS, AU-G20).

India's Major Developmental Initiatives in Africa

- **Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI):** Six African nations officially adopted the **"India Stack"** framework to digitize their national identity and payment systems.
- The India-led **International Solar Alliance** operationalized a **$35 million guarantee fund** in late 2025 to de-risk private investments in off-grid solar projects across African LDCs.
- **Healthcare "Health Sovereignty":** India is assisting the **African Medicines Agency (AMA)** in establishing **local pharmaceutical manufacturing hubs** in Kenya and Egypt.
- The **e-VidyaBharati and e-AarogyaBharati** platforms **(Pan African e-Network (PAeN))** provide access to Indian premier universities and multi-specialty medical consultations.
- India is deploying its **"Digital Agriculture"** expertise to help African farmers in the Sahel region improve yields and long-term food security.
- The **Indian Development and Economic Assistance Scheme (IDEAS)** provides concessional **Lines of Credit** for high-impact infrastructure like drinking water and power transmission.
- **AAGC (Asia-Africa Growth Corridor):** Joint initiative with **Japan** focuses on "Quality Infrastructure" and maritime connectivity.
- **Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC) and Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR) scholarships.**

India-Africa relations can shape a **multipolar, inclusive, and rules-based global order**, rooted in equity and sustainable growth.

India and Central Asia:

The region of Central Asia is **denoted as the Heartland by Helford Mackinder,** indicating its strategic importance.

With its proximity to Afghanistan and the presence of enormous resources, Central Asia is seen as a region where a 'New Great Game' is unfolding in the domain of energy and security.

Recent News

- The **4th India-Central Asia Dialogue** (Foreign Ministers) was held in June 2025 in New Delhi, focusing on connectivity, counter-terrorism, trade, and regional security cooperation.
- **India and Uzbekistan** conducted the joint military exercise "Dustlik" in 2025, focusing on counter-terrorism operations and joint tactical training.

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- **India and Kyrgyzstan** held the joint special forces exercise "Khanjar" in 2025, aimed at high-altitude warfare and counter-insurgency cooperation.
- The **US sanctions waiver for Chabahar Port** expired in April, creating a major logistical hurdle for India's primary gateway to Central Asia.
- India successfully renewed its long-term uranium procurement agreement with **Kazakhstan.**
- An Indian consortium signed a landmark deal for the exploration of the **Zarafshan valley** in Tajikistan, targeting critical minerals.

Significance of Central Asia for India:

1. **Strategic Backyard:** Central Asia forms India's **"extended neighborhood,"** vital for regional stability and balancing Eurasian powers.
2. **Energy Security (Uranium).**
3. Kazakhstan provides nearly **80% of India's uranium imports.**
4. **TAPI Pipeline** to transport Turkmen gas to India.
5. **Strategic Autonomy:** Eg. using the **SCO and India-Central Asia Summit** to voice independent positions on Eurasian security amidst Russia-West-China rivalries.
6. **Counter-Terrorism Alignment:** Shared concern over radicalization and instability in Afghanistan makes the region a vital security partner.
7. **Stabilizing Afghanistan:** Collective interest in ensuring a peaceful, stable, and inclusive government in Kabul to prevent narcotics spillover.
8. **INSTC Corridor Node:** The region is the central transit hub for the **7,200 km multimodal transport network** connecting India to Russia.
9. **Critical Minerals Hub:** Access to massive undeveloped reserves of lithium, cobalt, and rare earths essential for India's EV mission.
10. **UNSC Reform Support:** Consistent diplomatic backing from all five Central Asian republics for India's permanent UNSC seat.
11. **Cultural Soft Power:** Deep-rooted historical links via the Silk Road, Buddhism, and the popularity of Bollywood and Yoga.

Resource Potential of Central Asia

- **Uranium:** Kazakhstan is the world's largest producer (**40% of global uranium production** & **14% of the world's total uranium reserves**).
- Turkmenistan holds the **4th largest natural gas reserves** (~265 trillion cubic feet).
- **Kazakhstan** ranks among the top 15 globally for proven oil reserves (**30 billion barrels**).
- A massive rare-earth element (REE) deposit was discovered in the **Karaganda region (Kazakhstan)** in April 2025, estimated at **20 million metric tons**.
- **38.6% of manganese**, **30% of chromium**, **12.6% of zinc**, **8.7% of titanium,** and **20% of lead** reserves. Uzbekistan also ranks **11th globally in copper reserves** (approx. 44 million tons).
- **Uzbekistan and Kyrgyzstan** remain top-tier **gold producers** (Uzbekistan produces over **100 tons annually**).

Steps taken by India

- **India has the India-Central Asia Development Group and India-Central Asia Business Council.**

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- **India also launched a US$1 billion** line of credit for development projects in infrastructure, **IT, energy, and agriculture in 2020.**
- **Connect Central Asia Policy(2012): Based on 4 Cs-Commerce, Connectivity, Consular, and Community.**
- **India- Central Asia Dialogue since 2019** has been the main instrument fostering and strengthening the future course of cooperation between the countries.
- **Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation:** To assist the CARs countries in the areas of IT, Management, journalism, diplomacy, entrepreneurship, and banking.
- **Joint Exercises like Dustlink, Khanjar, Kazind, etc.**
- **Strategic Partnership Agreements** with three of the five CARs**: Kazakhstan, Tajikistan, and Uzbekistan.**
- **India joined the Ashgabat Agreement in 2018** to diversify its connectivity options with Central Asia.
- **The India-Tajikistan Friendship Hospital** was inaugurated in October 2014.
- **India-Central Asia Rare Earth Forum**: Joint exploration and cooperation in critical minerals.

Points of Friction:

1. **The "New Great Game"**
   a. **China pledged $4 billion in financial aid to the region in 2023.**
   b. In 2023, the **U.S. hosted the "US-Central Asia" summit.**
   c. **Russia** remains the primary security guarantor for CARs.
2. **Connectivity issue:** Expiry of the US waiver in April 2026 makes the primary transit route strategically vulnerable.
3. **China's "C+C5" Dominance:** China's massive financial muscle and BRI investments dwarf India's investments. Eg. China's trade is **30 times larger** than India's $1.2 billion trade.
4. **TAPI Security Risks:** It remains stalled due to instability in Kabul and India-Pakistan tensions.
5. **Low trade volume:** Eg. accounts for less than **1% of India's total global trade** volume in 2025.
6. Lack of seamless **inter-bank relations and credit guarantees** makes private sector investment highly risky.
7. **Narcotics Trafficking:** The **"Golden Crescent"** remains a major source of opium smuggling through Central Asian routes into India.

Way Forward:

1. Early conclusion of the **Free Trade Agreement (FTA) between India and the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU).**
2. **Strengthen multilateral engagement** through **the SCO, Eurasian Economic Community (EEC), etc.**
3. **Establishing air corridors** to address the connectivity gap.
4. Exploring the **Iran-India-China trilateral agreement for the transportation of oil and gas from Iran** and CAR.
5. **B2B over G2G:** Move beyond government-level MoUs by strengthening the "India-Central Asia Business Council" for private sector ventures.

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India And Latin America:

As per Jaishankar, Latin America forms part of India's larger goal of **"becoming a leading global power."**

Recent news

- Prime Minister Modi concluded the **first standalone visit by an Indian PM to Argentina** in 57 years, focusing on lithium and defense.
- India officially inaugurated its **new embassy in Ecuador (Nov 2025).**
- **Bilateral Trade Crossing $50 Billion (FY 2025-26),** for the first time.
- **India-Chile CEPA 3.0 (Oct 2025):** The 3rd round of negotiations for an expanded Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement was held in Santiago.
- KABIL (Khanij Bidesh India Ltd) began exploratory drilling of **Lithium** in **Argentina's Catamarca province** under the 2024-25 strategic pact.

Significance of Latin America for India:

1. **Critical Mineral Security:** The "Lithium Triangle" (Chile, Argentina, Bolivia) is essential for India's 2030 EV targets. (60% of the world's lithium reserves).
2. **Energy Diversification Pillar:** LAC provides nearly **15-20% of India's crude**, acting as a buffer against West Asian volatility.
3. **Edible Oil Lifeline:** South America has replaced Ukraine as a primary source for sunflower and soy oil. India imported **$5.6 billion worth of oilseeds** from Argentina and Brazil.
4. **Pharmaceutical Export Hub:** India exports more pharmaceuticals to the LAC region than **China**, reaching over **$1.5 billion** annually.
5. **IT & Service Integration:** Over **40,000 locals** are employed by Indian IT giants like TCS and Infosys in Latin American delivery centers.
6. **Global South Advocacy:** Partnership through G4, BRICS, and IBSA to push for **reformed multilateralism** at the UN.
7. **Agricultural Land Potential:** LAC's vast arable land offers "outward food security" through joint agricultural ventures.
8. **Defense Market Expansion:** Eg. negotiations for the sale of **LCA Tejas and BrahMos missiles** to Argentina.

Steps Taken by India to Strengthen Relations

1. Opening of new embassies in **Ecuador, Paraguay, and the Dominican Republic** in 2022.
2. **KABIL Strategic Investments:** Direct government-to-government funding for mineral exploration in the **Lithium Triangle** to bypass market volatility.
3. Upgrading the limited Preferential Trade Agreements (PTA) with **Chile and MERCOSUR** into comprehensive partnership agreements in 2025-26.
4. Launching the **India-LAC Business Council** to provide a structured platform for MSMEs to navigate regional markets.
5. **Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) Outreach** to nations like Bolivia to assist in financial inclusion and digital governance.
6. Consistent use of **HADR (Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief)**, as seen in the 2025 aid to Cuba and Ecuador.

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7. Appointing dedicated **Defense Attachés in Brazil and Chile** (2025) to facilitate military-industrial cooperation and exports.

Points of Friction:

1. **Geographic Distance:** High freight costs and lack of direct shipping lines make Indian exports less price-competitive. Eg. Shipping a container to **Santiago** takes nearly 45 days.
2. **Lack of Sustained High-Level Focus:** Despite recent visits, LAC is often prioritized lower than the Indo-Pacific or West Asia in New Delhi.
3. **China's trade** with LAC (~$450 billion) dwarfs India's ($50 billion). Chinese involvement in the **Chancay Port (Peru)** creates a logistical monopoly that Indian trade must navigate.
4. **Language & Cultural Gaps:** The Spanish/Portuguese barrier remains a significant hurdle for Indian SMEs.
5. **Political Volatility:** Frequent shifts between "Left" and "Right" lead to inconsistent trade policies. Eg. changes in **Argentine trade regulations** impacted Indian pharmaceutical exports.
6. **High import duties** in MERCOSUR countries continue to hinder Indian automobile and textile exports. Eg. Indian cars face **35% import tariffs** in Brazil.
7. Negotiations to expand the **2004 India-MERCOSUR PTA** have faced delays due to internal bloc disagreements.
8. **Limited Diaspora Influence:** Unlike in the West or Africa, the small Indian diaspora in LAC limits domestic political lobbying power.
9. **Complex Regulatory Environment:** Overlapping regional trade blocs (Pacific Alliance, MERCOSUR, CARICOM) create a "noodle bowl" of regulations.
10. **Limited Institutional and Financial Engagement:** Eg. only a single non-retail branch of the State Bank of India in São Paulo.

Way Forward:

1. **Strengthening relationship based on four pillars (S. Jayshankar):**
   a. **Supply chain diversification.**
   b. **Resource partnerships.**
   c. **Sharing of development-related experiences, such as digital capabilities, health solutions, and agricultural practices.**
   d. **Addressing global challenges.**
2. **Focus on "Active Non-Alignment":** India and LAC must use their shared stance on global conflicts to lead a "Third Way" in geopolitics.
3. Prioritize a free trade deal with the **Pacific Alliance (Mexico, Chile, Peru, Colombia)** as a gateway to the region.
4. Work toward a **"Mutual Recognition Agreement"** for pharmaceutical and agricultural standards to reduce non-tariff barriers.

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India and Nordic Countries:

As knowledge economies, the **Nordic nations and India** are natural allies in addressing 21st-century challenges like climate change and digitalization.

Recent News

- The **India-EFTA Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement** officially entered into force on October 1, 2025, promising **$100 billion in investments** over 15 years.
- The India-Nordic Development Initiative for Climate Action (INDICA) was introduced in Oslo as an execution bridge for climate technology.
- PM Modi met Finnish PM Petteri Orpo to discuss "Just AI" and the co-development of **6G and Quantum Computing**.
- India and Finland announced they will co-host the **World Circular Economy Forum (WCEF) 2026** in New Delhi.
- **Sweden-India SITE Network:** The Strategic Innovation and Technology Exchange (SITE) was launched in Stockholm to accelerate deep-tech startups.
- **Denmark and India** operationalized a pilot green maritime corridor between Tuticorin and Copenhagen.

Significance of Nordic Countries for India:

1. **Innovation Powerhouse:** The Nordics are global leaders in niche technologies, offering solutions for India's industrial modernization.
2. **Arctic Strategic Interests:** Nordic nations are key to India's Arctic Policy for climate research and sustainable resource management.
3. **Circular Economy Model:** Adopting Nordic waste-to-energy and sustainable consumption models for India's urban waste challenges.
4. **Supply Chain Resilience:** Nordic countries offer alternative, high-trust supply chains for semiconductors and critical electronics.
5. **Multilateral Reform:** Shared commitment to a rules-based order and support for India's permanent UNSC seat.

Steps taken by India

- **EFTA-TEPA Conclusion:** Finalizing the historic trade deal with EFTA (including Norway and Iceland) to secure duty-free access for Indian exports.
- **Dedicated India-Nordic Summits:** Institutionalizing the **Summit-level engagement** (2018, 2022, 2026), a format India only shares with the USA.
- **Launch of INDICA:** Creating the India-Nordic Development Initiative for Climate Action to move from policy dialogue to project execution.
- **Green Strategic Partnership:** Establishing a unique **"Green Strategic Partnership" with Denmark** (2020) as a model for other Nordic ties.

Points of Friction:

1. **TEPA Implementation Hurdles:** Converting the **$100 billion investment promise** into actual ground-level projects remains a bureaucratic challenge.

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2. **Geopolitical Divergences:** Differences in approach toward the **Russia-Ukraine conflict** and the subsequent NATO expansion of Sweden and Finland.
3. **Logistical Connectivity:** Lack of direct, high-frequency shipping and air-cargo routes increases freight costs and transit times.
4. **Sanitary and Phytosanitary (SPS) Barriers:** Strict Nordic/EU environmental and health standards often hinder Indian agricultural exports.
5. **Migration and Mobility Gaps:** Challenges in securing long-term social security and visa portability for Indian tech workers.
6. **Perception Gaps: Norwegian pension funds** have been hesitant to invest in India due to perceived regulatory unpredictability.

Way Forward:

1. Encourage **Government Pension Fund Global (Norway)** to invest in Indian green bonds.
2. **Deepen Arctic Research:** Focus on "Polar-Himalayan" climate links to turn Arctic research into actionable data for Indian agriculture.
3. **Reformed Multilateralism:** Coordinate on a shared "Global South-Nordic" agenda for IMF/World Bank restructuring.
4. **Ensure a conducive environment for investments** through favorable policies, regulatory frameworks, and ease of doing business.

Shared values of democracy, innovation, and equity make the India-Nordic relationship a **strategic lighthouse in the Global North-South matrix**.

India Pacific Island Nations Relation:

Recent News

- **FIPIC Foreign Ministers' Meeting (Sept 2025)** on the sidelines of the **80th UN General Assembly** to discuss maritime security and digital connectivity.
- The **Indo-Pacific Regional Dialogue** in New Delhi featured a dedicated session on Pacific Island Countries, emphasizing their role in India's **Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI)**.
- The Ministry of Culture **expanded "Project Mausam"** to the South Pacific to reconnect historical maritime links between the Indian and Pacific Oceans.
- India operationalized its pledged **$12 million grant** for community development projects across the 14 PICs in early 2026.
- Under the **CDRI (Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure)**, India began funding the installation of early warning systems in **Fiji and Vanuatu**.

Significance of Pacific Island Nations for India:

1. **Strategic Location:** These nations sit at the intersection of vital trans-Pacific trade routes and maritime chokepoints.
2. **Multilateral Influence:** Eg. support from 14 Pacific nations is critical for India's bid for a **permanent seat in the UNSC**.
3. India and PICs are **"natural allies" in climate advocacy,** being most vulnerable to rising sea levels. Eg. **Infrastructure for Resilient Island States** launched at COP-26.
4. **Blue Economy potential:** Despite small landmasses, these nations control some of the world's largest and most resource-rich **Exclusive Economic Zones**.

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5. **Countering Hegemony:** India's presence offers a democratic alternative to China's expanding infrastructure-led "grey zone" activities in the region.
6. **Large Indian-origin populations** in Fiji and PNG act as cultural and economic bridges.
7. **Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI):** PICs are central to India's vision of a free, open, and inclusive Indo-Pacific.

Steps Taken by India to Strengthen Relations

1. Establishing the **Forum for India-Pacific Islands Cooperation** in 2014 to ensure regular, summit-level political engagement.
2. Providing a recurring **$200,000 annual grant** to each of the 14 PICs for small-scale community development.
3. Pledging a **12-point development agenda** including solar energy, dialysis centers, and sea-ambulance services.
4. **Visa-on-Arrival Facilities** to all FIPIC members to encourage tourism and business travel.
5. Doubling the number of **ITEC scholarships** for Pacific Island professionals in fields like IT, accounting, and governance.
6. **Opening of new embassies** (Eg. in **Paraguay** and recently proposed in smaller PICs) to reduce the "bureaucratic distance."
7. Creating specific JWGs for **Maritime Security and Sustainable Fisheries** to institutionalize technical cooperation.

Challenges in Cooperation

1. **Chinese "Wolf Warrior" Diplomacy:** China's massive financial muscle and trade volume (30x larger than India's) create a competitive disadvantage.
2. The vast **physical distance and lack of direct air/maritime connectivity** make trade logistics prohibitively expensive.
3. **Debt Sustainability Fears:** Rising sovereign debt in the region limits the capacity of PICs to take on even concessional Indian loans.
4. **Climate Crisis Intensity:** The rapid pace of sea-level rise creates a "constant emergency" mode that disrupts long-term developmental planning.
5. **Linguistic & Cultural Barrier:** Beyond Fiji, the lack of deep cultural or linguistic familiarity hinders deep-seated social integration for Indian firms.
6. **US-China Polarization:** Growing pressure on PICs to choose between Western security alliances and Chinese economic aid. Eg. friction over the **Solomon Islands-China security pact.**

Way forward

1. **Shift to "Demand-Driven" Development:** India must move from pre-packaged aid to projects identified specifically by the Island nations themselves.
2. **Air-Freight Corridors** to bypass slow maritime routes for pharma and high-tech exports.
3. **Collaborative Blue Economy:** Partner with Australia and Japan (under the Quad) to provide high-quality maritime domain awareness.
4. **Institutionalize the FIPIC Secretariat** to monitor project implementation and coordinate diplomatic responses.
5. **Reform Global Finance:** Jointly advocate for a "Vulnerability Index" to allow PICs better access to concessional climate finance from the IMF.

India's engagement with Pacific Island nations must shift from episodic diplomacy to sustained strategic partnership, grounded in climate resilience and mutual development.

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Chapter 5

India and Multilateral Institutions

PYQs

[2024] Terrorism has become a significant threat to global peace and security'. Evaluate the effectiveness of the United Nations Security Council's Counter-Terrorism Committee (CTC) and its associated bodies in addressing and mitigating this threat at the international level. (15)
[2020] Critically examine the role of WHO in providing global health security during the Covid-19 pandemic. (10)
[2019] 'Too little cash, too much politics, leaves UNESCO fighting for life.' Discuss the statement in the light of US' withdrawal and its accusation of the cultural body as being 'anti-Israel bias'. (10)
[2018] What are the key areas of reform if the WTO has to survive in the present con- text of 'Trade War', especially keeping in mind the interest of India? (15)
[2017] What are the main functions of the United Nations Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)? Explain different functional commissions attached to it. (10)

India and the United Nations:

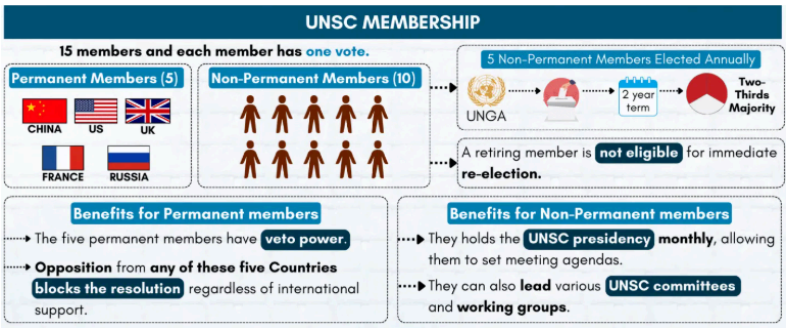
1. "The United Nations was not created to take mankind to heaven, but to save humanity from hell." - **Dag Hammarskjöld**
2. "The UN is the only place where the world comes together to solve global problems that no nation can solve alone." - **António Guterres**
3. "Success of Humanity lies in our collective strength, not in the battlefield." - **Narendra Modi**
4. "A world without the UN or with a paralyzed UN would be far more costly and dangerous to peace." - **Richard Holbrooke**

Recent News

- **UN80 Reform Roadmap:** The UN officially launched the "UN80" initiative to modernize global governance ahead of its 80th anniversary in October 2026.
- **Financial Crisis (April 2026):** The Secretariat reported record arrears of **$1.57 billion**, the highest in seven years, threatening peacekeeping missions.
- **Pact for the Future (Late 2024):** Adoption of the Global Digital Compact and Declaration on Future Generations to govern AI and emerging technologies.
- **Climate "Loss and Damage" Fund:** Successfully operationalized in January 2026, providing the first major funding cycle for climate-vulnerable nations.

Major Achievements of UN organizations:

1. **Preventing Global War** between great powers for over eight decades.
2. **Eradicating Diseases:** Successfully eradicated smallpox (1980) and reduced polio cases by **99%** through the WHO.



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3. **Decolonization:** Assisted over **80 nations** in gaining independence and transitioning to sovereign states.
4. **Feeding the Hungry:** The World Food Programme (WFP) provides life-saving food to over **100 million people** annually.
5. **Environmental Pacts:** Negotiated the landmark **Paris Agreement (2015)** and the Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework (2022).
6. **Nuclear Non-Proliferation:** The IAEA monitors and limits the spread of nuclear weapons through the NPT framework.
7. **Human Rights Standard-Setting:** Drafted the **Universal Declaration of Human Rights**, the foundation of modern international law.
8. **Refugee Protection:** UNHCR currently assists over **110 million** forcibly displaced people worldwide.
9. **Promoting Democracy:** Provided technical and electoral assistance to over **100 countries** for free and fair elections.
10. **Protecting Cultural Heritage:** UNESCO has designated and protected over **1,100 World Heritage Sites** globally.

Issues in the United Nations:

1. **Security Council Paralysis:** Deep rifts among the P5 members lead to frequent vetoes on urgent humanitarian crises. Eg. repeated vetoes regarding **Ukraine and Gaza**.
2. **Budgetary Liquidity Crisis:** Member states failing to pay assessed contributions on time, leading to severe operational shortages.
3. **Outdated Representation:** The UNSC reflects the world of 1945, excluding major 21st-century powers like India and Brazil.
4. **Ineffective Peacekeeping:** Peacekeepers are often deployed without clear political exit strategies or robust mandates to protect civilians.
5. **Rise of Minilateralism:** Nations are bypassing the UN to form smaller groupings (Quad, BRICS, G20) for security and trade.
6. **AI and Tech Gaps:** The UN struggles to keep pace with rapid AI advancements, leading to fragmented global regulations.
7. **Gender Inequality:** Despite 80 years of existence, the UN has never had a woman as Secretary-General.
8. **Bureaucratic Red Tape:** Overlapping mandates between UN agencies lead to wasted resources and slow response times.
9. **Human Rights Selectivity:** Eg. differing UN responses to **human rights situations** in non-P5 vs. P5-aligned nations.
10. **Erosion of Multilateralism:** Increasing unilateralism and Great Power deconfliction outside the UN framework weakens the organization's authority. Eg. the US attack on Venezuela.

India's Bid for UNSC Permanent Membership:

1. **Representative Legitimacy:** India is the world's most populous nation, representing nearly **18% of humanity**.
2. **Economic Prowess:** As the **world's 5th largest economy** (and the fastest-growing major economy in 2026).
3. **Peacekeeping Leadership:** India is historically one of the **largest cumulative troop contributors** to **71+** UN Peacekeeping Operations (UNPKO).
4. India was an **original signatory** of the UN Charter in 1945 & has adhered to the UN's principles even during periods of national hardship.
5. Through its leadership in the **G20 (2023)** and the **"Voice of Global South Summits"**, India has positioned itself as a bridge between the developed West and the developing world.

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6. **Responsible Nuclear Power:** Despite being a non-signatory to the NPT, India's "No First Use" policy and impeccable non-proliferation record.

Major Challenges to India's UNSC Permanent Membership

1. **The Veto Stalemate (Article 108):** Any Charter amendment requires ratification by all P5 members' domestic parliaments, which is politically difficult.
2. **China's "Hidden Veto" Strategy:** China remains the only P5 member that hasn't officially backed India's bid with a clear commitment.
3. **The "Coffee Club" (UfC Group) Opposition:** Eg. **Pakistan, Italy, and Mexico** consistently lobby for expanding only "non-permanent" seats to block regional competitors.
4. **Nuclear Non-Signatory Status:** Critics point to India's refusal to sign the **NPT and CTBT** as a disqualifier for permanent membership.
5. **Intergovernmental Negotiations (IGN) Deadlock:** The 2026 session of the IGN ended without a consensus on the framework for expansion.
6. **African Solidarity (Ezulwini Consensus):** Africa demands at least two permanent seats with veto power, complicating the G4's unified reform model.
7. **Geopolitical Divergences on Conflicts:** India's "strategic neutrality" in major 2024-2026 conflicts has occasionally caused friction with Western P5 allies.
8. **The "Veto Power" Dilemma:** New Delhi's willingness to **defer veto power for 15 years** is seen as a "dilution" by some domestic critics.

Key Reforms Needed in the UN

1. **Expansion of UNSC:** Increase both permanent and non-permanent seats to include **India, Brazil, Japan, Germany**, and African representation.
2. **Veto Restructuring:** Limit the use of the veto in cases of mass atrocities or genocide through a voluntary code of conduct.
3. **Financial Penalty Mechanism:** Implement stricter interest or voting-right penalties for states that are chronic defaulters on budget payments.
4. **Empower the General Assembly:** Strengthen the UNGA's role in security matters when the Security Council is paralyzed.
5. Shift from traditional peacekeeping to **"Peace Enforcement"** with a primary focus on civilian protection. Eg. uniting for consensus.
6. **Direct Public Funding:** Explore global taxes (Eg. on carbon or financial transactions) to reduce dependency on member state contributions.
7. **Inclusive Multilateralism:** Formally institutionalize the role of regional blocs like the **African Union** within the UN Charter.

India and G-20

G-20 is a Strategic multilateral platform connecting and bringing together the world's major developed and emerging economies.

G-20 was established in 1999 as a meeting of Finance Ministers and Central Bank Governors. It was raised to the Summit level in 2008 to address the fallouts of the **Global Financial Crisis.**

"The G20 is not just a forum to discuss the economy; it is a platform to decide the future of the planet." - **Narendra Modi**

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G20 Summit 2025 (Johannesburg Declaration)

- **Debt Sustainability:** Proposed Cost of Capital Commission to examine high borrowing costs for developing countries.
- **Disaster and tech readiness.**
- Commitment to **Universal Early Warning Systems by 2027** under UN initiative.
- Launch of **AI for Africa Initiative** to boost computing capacity and talent.
- **Energy & Climate Transition.**
- **Mission 300** (World Bank + AfDB): Electrify **300 million people in Africa by 2030**.
- Reaffirmed goal to:
  - **Triple global renewable energy capacity by 2030.**
  - **Double energy efficiency improvement rates.**
- Introduced the **G20 Critical Minerals Framework** (voluntary, non-binding) with a focus on:
  - **Sustainable supply chains.**
  - **Investment in exploration.**
  - **Responsible mining governance.**
- **Youth Development:** Adopted Nelson Mandela Bay Target. Reduce NEET (Not in Employment, Education, Training) by 5% by 2030.
- **Gender Equality:** Revised Brisbane-eThekwini Goal. Reduce the gender gap in labour force participation by 25% by 2030 (from 2012 levels).

Significance of G-20

1. **Economic Governance:** Represents **85% of global GDP** and **75% of international trade**, ensuring systemic stability.
2. **Global South Voice:** Provides a platform for emerging powers like India and Brazil to challenge G7-centric narratives.
3. **Debt Sustainability:** The "Common Framework" helps low-income countries restructure debt to avoid sovereign defaults.
4. Financial Stability & Reform Advocacy
   a. **Coordinates policies** through bodies like the **Financial Stability Board (FSB)** and supports IMF-World Bank reforms.
   b. Played a crucial role in response to the **2008 global financial crisis and the COVID-19 economic recovery**.
5. **Crisis Response and Pandemic Recovery**
   a. Initiated the **Debt Service Suspension Initiative (DSSI)** for low-income nations during COVID-19.
   b. Promoted equitable access to vaccines through **COVAX** and endorsed the **One Health** approach.
6. **Shaping Global Development Agenda:** Drives progress on **climate action, gender equality, digital economy, anti-corruption**, and **sustainable development (SDGs)**.

Major Issues in G-20

1. **Informal structure - G-20 has no permanent secretariat.**
2. **Geopolitical Polarization:** Conflict-driven rifts (Ukraine/Gaza) often paralyze the forum, making "Joint Communiqués" difficult to achieve.
3. **US did not participate in the summit and tried to stop the declaration in its absence.**
4. **Non-Binding Nature:** G-20 is facing a credibility crisis due to deglobalization and rising protectionism.
5. **"G-Zero" Risk:** A shift toward "every nation for itself" as leaders prioritize domestic protectionism over global cooperation.

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6. **Implementation Deficit:** Eg. Slow disbursement of the **$100 billion climate finance** promised to developing nations.
7. **Institutional Fatigue:** The proliferation of working groups and "Engagement Groups" has led to a diluted, unfocused agenda.
8. **Lack of Accountability:** Eg. repeated failure to eliminate **inefficient fossil fuel subsidies** despite annual pledges since 2009.

Way forward for the G-20 group:

1. **Empower the Troika:** Strengthen the "Past, Present, and Future" presidency model to ensure that projects don't die with a change in leadership. **(Sanjaya Baru)**
2. **Bridge the Digital Divide:** Use the G20 to set global standards for "Ethical AI" that prevent the Global South from becoming tech-colonized.
3. **Establish a Permanent Secretariat** for tracking implementation and ensuring data-driven policy.
4. **Strengthen Regional Partnerships:** Formalize the G20's link with the AU, ASEAN, and MERCOSUR to enhance regional implementation.
5. **Revitalize Multilateralism:** Use the G20 as a "stepping stone" to broader UN reforms to restore faith in global governance.

"One Earth, One Family, One Future," the theme of India's G20 Presidency, reflects the G20's growing role in shaping equitable global governance.

As a platform for collective leadership, the G20 must move from crisis response to long-term reforms in finance, health, and climate.

PM Modi noted, "The G20 must be the beacon of hope and healing" - a call for human-centric globalisation and solidarity.

World Trade Organisation:

The 14th Ministerial Conference (MC14) of the World Trade Organization in Yaoundé (Cameroon) ended without consensus due to disputes over the e-commerce moratorium.

Major outcomes of the meeting

1. **Fisheries Subsidies:** Members moved toward the **"Second Phase" of the agreement,** aiming to curb subsidies driving overcapacity. A roadmap was established to discipline **distant-water industrial fleets** while protecting small-scale fishers.
2. **Incorporation of the Investment Facilitation for Development (IFD) Agreement:** India and South Africa **blocked** the formal inclusion of this China-led plurilateral pact into the WTO rulebook.
3. **E-commerce Moratorium:** The 26-year **moratorium on digital customs duties lapsed** due to a lack of consensus. However, 66 countries advanced a **plurilateral pact** to keep digital trade duty-free among themselves.
4. **Agriculture:** Negotiations ended in a **deadlock** over **Public Stockholding (PSH)**. India and African nations sought a permanent PSH solution for food security, but developed countries refused without reciprocal market access concessions.
5. **Lapse of TRIPS Safeguard against "non-violation" complaints:** Without it, WTO-compliant measures like **compulsory licensing** can now be more easily challenged by other members, even if no specific rule is broken.

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6. **LDC issues:** LDCs received extended support for post-graduation transition, but the **lapse of the TRIPS safeguard exposes developing countries to legal challenges** on public health and affordable medicine policies.

E-Commerce Moratorium (WTO)

- It is a **WTO agreement (since 1998)** under which members **do not impose customs duties on electronic transmissions**. Eg. software downloads, Digital music, etc.
- It aims to **promote the growth of digital trade** and avoid taxation barriers.
- Developed Countries (US, EU): Advocate a **permanent moratorium** as it promotes **digital innovation & global trade.**
- Developing Countries (India, South Africa): Oppose continuation, claiming **revenue Loss**, limiting ability to regulate digital trade & **uneven Playing Field** (Benefits **Big Tech over domestic firms).**

World Trade Organisation

- The **World Trade Organization (WTO)** is the only global international organization dealing with the rules of trade between nations.
- It acts as a forum for negotiating trade agreements, a place to settle trade disputes, and a system of rules that ensures trade flows as smoothly as possible.
- Established in 1995, headquartered in Geneva, with 166 members accounting for ~98% of global trade.
- **History:** Before the WTO, there was the **GATT** (General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade), established in 1948.
  - **The GATT Era (1948-1994):** it was a "provisional" agreement and lacked a formal institutional structure.
  - **The Uruguay Round (1986-1994):** It led to the creation of the WTO because members realized GATT was too narrow (only covered goods).
  - **The Marrakesh Agreement:** On April 15, 1994, ministers from most GATT nations signed the deal in Marrakesh, Morocco, officially birthing the WTO in 1995.

Core Functions of the WTO

1. **Trade Negotiations**: Recent milestones include the **Trade Facilitation Agreement (2017)** and the **Fisheries Subsidies Agreement (2022)**.
2. **Implementation and Monitoring** through Specialized councils and committees. Every member undergoes periodic **Trade Policy Reviews** to ensure compliance.
3. **Dispute Settlement Body**: An independent legal mechanism to enforce rules and prevent unilateral trade wars.
4. **Building Trade Capacity**: Provides **"Special and Differential Treatment"** for developing nations. **Aid for Trade** initiative for poorer nations to build the skills and infrastructure.

Organisational Structure of the WTO

1. **Ministerial Conference:** **Apex decision-making body** comprising trade ministers of all members. Meeting **biennially**, it sets WTO's strategic direction and takes key policy decisions.
2. **General Council:** Based in Geneva and **manages day-to-day functioning between ministerial meetings**. It also **acts** as the **Dispute Settlement** Body and **Trade Policy Review Body.**
3. **Functional Councils:** Three councils-**Goods, Services, and TRIPS**-operate under the General Council, overseeing implementation of agreements in their respective areas.

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4. **Committees and Working Bodies:** Handle specialized areas such as environment, development, regional trade agreements, and membership.

Dispute Resolution in the WTO

- **Dispute Settlement Body (DSB):** Oversees dispute resolution. It establishes **panels, adopts reports, and monitors implementation.**
- **Panels examine disputes** and **issue rulings**. The DSB ensures compliance, and if members fail to implement decisions, it permits suspension of concessions to enforce rulings.
- Created in 1995, the Appellate Body **reviews panel decisions on legal grounds** and can uphold, modify, or reverse them.
- The Appellate Body is **currently non-functional** due to vacancies since November 2020, weakening the system.

Achievements of the WTO

- **Facilitation of International Trade:** Eg. The real volume of world trade has expanded by **2.7 times since the inception of the WTO.**
- **Reduction in Tariffs:** After the creation of the WTO, average tariffs have almost halved, **from 10.5% to 6.4%.**
- **Rise of global value chains:** The predictable market conditions fostered by the WTO have enabled the rise of global value chains (**accounts for 70% of total merchandise trade).**

Major Agreements under the WTO

Agreement & Full Name	Primary Objective	Key Features & Provisions
AoA: Agreement on Agriculture	Reform agricultural trade to create a fair, market-oriented system.	• **Market Access:** Converts non-tariff barriers to tariffs and requires progressive duty cuts. • **Export Competition:** Bans new export subsidies and mandates reductions in existing ones to prevent price undercutting. • **Domestic Support (Boxes):** Green Box (non-distorting, Eg. research); Amber Box (trade-distorting, Eg. price supports with 5-10% limits); Blue Box (Amber box with production limits). • **The Peace Clause (Bali 2013):** Allows developing nations to exceed the 10% de minimis subsidy limit for food security programs without being legally challenged by other members.
TRIPS: Trade-Related Intellectual Property Rights	Establish minimum global standards for protecting creations of the mind.	• **Broad Coverage:** Sets rules for Patents (20 years), Copyright (60 years in India), Trademarks, and GIs. • **Enforcement:** Mandates that member nations provide legal procedures to enforce IP rights effectively. • **Flexibilities:** Allow compulsory licensing for national emergencies and Parallel Importing to ensure access to affordable medicines.

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Agreement & Full Name	Primary Objective	Key Features & Provisions
SPS: Sanitary & Phyto-Sanitary Measures	Ensure food safety and animal/plant health in cross-border trade.	• **All health regulations must be based on scientific risk assessments**, not used as "hidden" protectionism. • **Standardization:** Encourages members to follow international standards (Eg. Codex Alimentarius).
GATS: General Agreement on Trade in Services	Create a reliable system of international rules for the service sector.	• **General Obligations:** Include **MFN** (treating all members equally) and **Transparency** (publishing all relevant laws). • **4 Modes of Supply:** Covers everything from **digital BPO** (Mode 1) and **tourism** (Mode 2) to **foreign bank branches** (Mode 3) and onsite **IT consultants** (Mode 4). • **Specific Commitments:** Market access is negotiated sector-by-sector (Eg. banking, telecom). • The decades-old moratorium on customs duties for e-commerce **expired on March 26, 2026**. For the first time since 1998, members are technically no longer legally barred from taxing digital transmissions.
TRIMS: Trade-Related Investment Measures	Prevent investment rules from distorting or restricting international trade.	• **Trade Neutrality:** Ensures that foreign investment is not restricted by rules that favor domestic goods. • **Prohibited Measures:** Explicitly bans Local Content Requirements and Trade Balancing Requirements (limiting imports based on export volume). • **GATT Consistency:** Mandates that investment measures comply with national treatment principles.

Major issues faced by the WTO

1. **Appellate Body Paralysis** due to U.S. blocking judge appointments.
2. **Negotiation Deadlock:** The **Doha Development Round remains stalled** due to disagreements over agriculture, subsidies, and market access.
3. **MFN Principle Erosion** due to Proliferating regional FTAs that bypass non-discriminatory rules. Eg. RCEP.
4. **Protectionism & Security:** Nations abuse GATT "security exceptions" to justify unilateral tariffs, undermining predictable trade and fueling ongoing global trade wars.
5. **Outdated Rulebook:** Existing 1995 rules fail to address 21st-century realities like AI, cloud computing, and complex cross-border data flow regulations.
6. **Power Asymmetry:** Deep North-South divides persist over intellectual property and food security, hindering equitable treatment for developing versus developed economies.
7. **Geopolitical Rivalries:** U.S.-China tensions and strategic bloc formations (IPEF, BRICS+) reduce cooperation, causing members to favor alternative frameworks over the WTO.
8. **Developing Status Dispute:** Eg. the USA's objection over China and India claiming "Special treatment".
9. **E-commerce Tariff Cliff:** The long-standing moratorium on digital duties lapsed in March 2026, risking new taxes on software, music, and downloads.

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10. **Green Protectionism:** Tensions rise over carbon border taxes (like the EU's CBAM), which developing nations view as unfair barriers to their industrial growth.

India's stance in the WTO on different issues

1. **Agreement on Agriculture:** India demands a Permanent Solution for **Public Stockholding (PSH)**, allowing it to procure grains at fixed prices without violating subsidy caps.
2. **Agreement on Fisheries Subsidies:** India seeks a balanced deal that punishes large-scale industrial fleets while exempting its **9 million artisanal fishermen** from subsidy cuts.
3. **TRIPS Agreement:** India champions **IP flexibilities**, opposing "evergreening" of patents and supporting waivers for essential medicines.
4. **General Agreement on Trade in Services (GATS):** India pushes for **"Mode 4" liberalization**, seeking easier **global movement for its high-skilled professionals** and service providers.
5. **TBT and SPS Agreements:** India resists weaponization of technical standards, arguing that complex requirements should not be used as disguised protectionist trade barriers.
6. **Agreement on Investment Facilitation:** India blocked the incorporation of this plurilateral agreement, arguing that **investment is not a trade issue** under the WTO mandate.
7. India defends **Special & Differential Treatment** as an **unconditional, treaty-based right**, rejecting attempts by developed nations to dilute benefits for emerging economies.
8. **E-Commerce Moratorium:** India opposes making a ban on **digital customs duties** permanent, seeking "policy space" to generate revenue and protect its domestic digital industry.
9. **Non-Trade Issues:** India firmly resists linking trade to **labor, gender, or environmental standards**, viewing them as potential tools for "green" or social protectionism.

Way Forward

1. **Broaden mandate:** Shift from pure liberalization to **equitable globalization**, with rules on digital trade, data flows, and green subsidies (Global Trade and Development Report).
2. **Restore dispute system:** Revive the WTO Appellate Body by addressing concerns on judicial overreach, timelines, and policy space.
3. **Reform S&DT:** Replace self-declaration of developing status with objective data like GDP per capita and the UN's Multidimensional Vulnerability Index.
4. **Institutional reform:** Create a permanent WTO Reform Council for periodic updates.
5. **Build coalitions:** Middle powers (India, European Union, Brazil, etc.) should drive consensus.

A **reformed, inclusive, and forward-looking WTO** is essential to sustain a credible, rules-based multilateral trading system in a changing global economy.

International Criminal Court:

It is the **first international permanent court** to investigate and prosecute individuals accused of serious international crimes.

Recent News

- The ICC issued arrest warrants for Prime Minister **Benjamin Netanyahu** and former Defense Minister **Yoav Gallant** for alleged war crimes in Gaza.
- **US Sanctions on ICC (Feb 2025):** The Trump administration imposed sanctions on ICC officials in response to warrants against Israeli leaders

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The **Rome Statute (adopted in 1998, entered into force in 2002)** grants the ICC jurisdiction over 4 main crimes.

Category	Key Features
Genocide	Specific intent to **destroy a national, ethnic, racial, or religious group**, including killing members or causing destruction by other means.
Crimes Against Humanity	**Serious violations** committed through **large-scale attacks against the civilian population**. Includes offences like **murder, rape, imprisonment, enforced disappearances, enslavement, torture, and apartheid** (as per the Rome Statute).
War Crimes	**Grave breaches of the Geneva Conventions** during armed conflict. Includes **use of child soldiers, killing/torture of civilians or prisoners of war, attacks on hospitals and monuments**.
Crime of Aggression	**Use of armed force by a State** against the **sovereignty, territorial integrity or political independence** of another State.

Comparison between ICC and ICJ:

Parameters	ICC	ICJ
Genesis	**Rome Statute**	Established in **1945 by UN Charter**
HQ	**Hague (Netherlands)**	**Peace Palace** in The Hague (Netherlands)
Composition	**18 judges,** with 9-year, non-renewable term, **in 3 divisions**: Pre-Trial, Trial, and Appeals elected by Assembly of States Parties	**15 judges** elected to 9-year terms by UN General Assembly and the Security Council.
Cases	Holds only **individuals criminally responsible for offences.**	Hears **2 types of cases**: •**Legal disputes** between States submitted to it by them (contentious cases) •**Requests for advisory opinions** on legal questions referred to it by UN organs/ specialized agencies

Significance of the International Criminal Court:

1. **Ending Impunity:** Provides a global mechanism to hold high-ranking officials personally liable for atrocities beyond national borders.
2. **Court of Last Resort:** Operates on the **principle of complementarity**, intervening only when national courts are "unwilling or unable" to prosecute.
3. **Global Jurisdiction Focus:** Unlike ad hoc tribunals (like Nuremberg), it is a permanent body with the power to investigate any member territory.
4. **Victim Reparations:** Established the **Trust Fund for Victims** to provide physical, psychological, and material support to those affected by war.
5. **Defining International Crimes:** Standardizes the legal definitions of **Genocide, War Crimes, and Crimes Against Humanity** for the global community.
6. **Prevention of Aggression:** Since 2018, the court can prosecute the "Crime of Aggression," targeting leaders who launch illegal wars.

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7. **Neutral Arbitration:** Offers a perceived neutral ground for justice, separate from the political pressures of domestic courtrooms.

Why did India not join the Rome Statute?

1. India views the ICC as an **infringement on its sovereign right** to exercise criminal jurisdiction within its borders.
2. India objected to the **broad and "vague" definitions** of **Crimes Against Humanity** and the inclusion of **internal armed conflicts**.
3. India opposes the power of the UN Security Council to refer cases to the ICC, seeing it as a tool for the P5 to target non-aligned nations.
4. India expressed concern that the court's statutes could potentially be used to criminalize the **possession or use of nuclear weapons**.
5. India argued the Rome Statute focuses too much on state agents while failing to adequately address **cross-border terrorism**.
6. New Delhi fears the "unwilling/unable" clause could be used by the ICC to override India's own highly developed and independent judiciary.
7. Given the volatile security situation in **Kashmir and the Northeast**, India believes international interference could complicate **national reconciliation** and counter-insurgency.

Challenges with the Functioning of ICC:

1. ICC has **no police force**; It depends entirely on member states to execute its arrest warrants.
2. **Perceived Eurocentric Bias:** Historically, **9 out of the first 10** formal investigations were conducted in African nations
3. **Absence of Major Powers:** Non-membership of the **USA, Russia, China, and India** significantly limits the court's global reach and legitimacy.
4. **Political Instrumentalization:** Eg. accusations of **"double standards"** regarding the speed of the Ukraine investigation vs. the Afghanistan investigation.
5. **Witness Intimidation:** The court struggles to protect witnesses in active conflict zones, leading to the collapse of high-profile cases.
6. **Security Council Overreach:** The UNSC can refer or **defer (freeze)** cases, giving political bodies power over judicial processes.
7. **Limited Jurisdiction:** The ICC cannot investigate crimes on the territory of non-member states unless referred by the UNSC.
8. **Allegations of misconduct against top officials** erode public trust. Eg. **sexual misconduct allegations** against Prosecutor Karim Khan.

Way Forward:

1. **Shift to "Positive Complementarity":** The ICC should focus on building the capacity of national judiciaries rather than trying to replace them.
2. **Universalize the Rome Statute** by addressing specific sovereign concerns of non-members.
3. **Implement Veto Restraints:** The P5 should voluntarily forgo the veto in cases of mass atrocities to allow for more consistent UNSC referrals.
4. **Financial Autonomy:** Create an endowment or independent funding stream to insulate the court from the "donor politics" of specific nations.
5. Formalizing links with **regional human rights courts** (like the African Court) to "de-center" justice from The Hague.

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International Court of Justice

The International Court of Justice (ICJ), often called the **"World Court,"** is the principal judicial organ of the United Nations.

Established in June 1945 by the UN Charter and began work in April 1946, succeeding the Permanent Court of International Justice (PCIJ).

Consists of 15 judges elected to 9-year terms by the UN General Assembly and Security Council.

1. Judges are elected from different nationalities to ensure geographical representation (3 from Africa, 3 from Asia, 2 from Latin America, 5 from Western Europe, and 2 from Eastern Europe).
2. Indian Representation: Justice Dalveer Bhandari (serving his second term since 2018).

Recent News

- The ICJ delivered an opinion clarifying that **states have legal obligations to protect the climate system** and can be held liable for "significant harm" caused to vulnerable nations.
- **South Africa vs. Israel:** The ICJ issued multiple provisional measures regarding the situation in Gaza, ordering the prevention of genocidal acts and ensuring humanitarian aid.

Mandate

1. **Contentious Jurisdiction:** Settles legal disputes submitted by States (only states can be parties). Decisions are binding, final, and without appeal for the parties involved.
2. **Advisory Jurisdiction:** Provides non-binding legal opinions on questions referred by authorized UN organs and specialized agencies.
3. Under Article 38 of its Statute, the court applies international treaties, international custom, general principles of law, and judicial decisions/teachings of highly qualified publicists.

Major Achievements and Significance

1. **Peaceful Settlement of Disputes:** Offers a robust alternative to armed conflict for resolving complex sovereignty and border issues.
2. **Clarifying International Law:** Acts as the "Supreme Interpreter" of the UN Charter and various global treaties.
3. **Interprets human rights** obligations within the context of state responsibility. Eg. Provisional measures in the **Gambia vs. Myanmar** case to protect the Rohingya from genocide.
4. **Maritime Boundary Delimitation:** Resolves overlapping maritime claims, crucial for economic zones. Eg. **Somalia vs. Kenya** maritime boundary dispute (2021).
5. **Consular Access Rights:** Upholds the Vienna Convention on Consular Relations, protecting foreign nationals in legal distress. Eg. **Kulbhushan Jadhav (India vs. Pakistan)** case.
6. **Decolonization Catalyst:** Eg. Advisory opinion on the **Chagos Archipelago (2019)** calling for the end of UK administration.
7. **Environmental Jurisprudence:** Eg. **The Pulp Mills (Argentina vs. Uruguay)** case set high standards for environmental impact assessments.
8. **Institutional Neutrality:** Eg. The balanced composition ensures that **no single power bloc** dominates its rulings.
9. **Preventing Escalation:** Eg. **ordering** Russia to **suspend military operations** in Ukraine (2022) to prevent irreparable harm.

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Major Issues in the ICJ

1. **Lack of Compulsory Jurisdiction:** The court can only hear cases if both states have consented to its jurisdiction.
2. **Enforcement Gap:** The ICJ has no "police force"; enforcement relies on the **UN Security Council**, which is subject to veto.
3. **Lengthy Litigation Cycles:** Eg. the **Genocide Convention** cases typically span over a decade before reaching the merits stage.
4. **Limited Access:** Only **States** can bring cases; individuals, NGOs, and corporations are completely excluded from contentious proceedings.
5. **Politicized Nominations:** Judge elections involve intense lobbying in the UNGA and UNSC, leading to concerns about "judicial diplomacy".
6. **Resource Inadequacy:** Limited budget of **$30 million.**
7. **Advisory Opinions** are non-binding. Eg. Israel continues to maintain the **West Bank wall** despite a 2004 advisory opinion declaring it illegal.
8. Overlapping jurisdiction with the specialized courts like the International **Tribunal for the Law of the Sea**, ICC, and WTO leads to conflicting interpretations of international law.

Way Forward

1. Encourage more states to **file "Optional Clause" declarations** under **Article 36(2)** to accept the court's authority unconditionally.
2. **Veto Reform for Article 94:** The P5 should voluntarily agree not to use the veto against the enforcement of ICJ judgments.
3. **Fast-Track Procedures:** Introduce specialized **"Summary Proceedings" for urgent cases.**
4. **Broader Standing (Locus Standi):** Explore allowing certain UN bodies (like the Human Rights Council) to initiate contentious proceedings.
5. **Post-Judgment Monitoring:** Establish a dedicated UNGA committee to monitor and report on the implementation of ICJ judgments annually.

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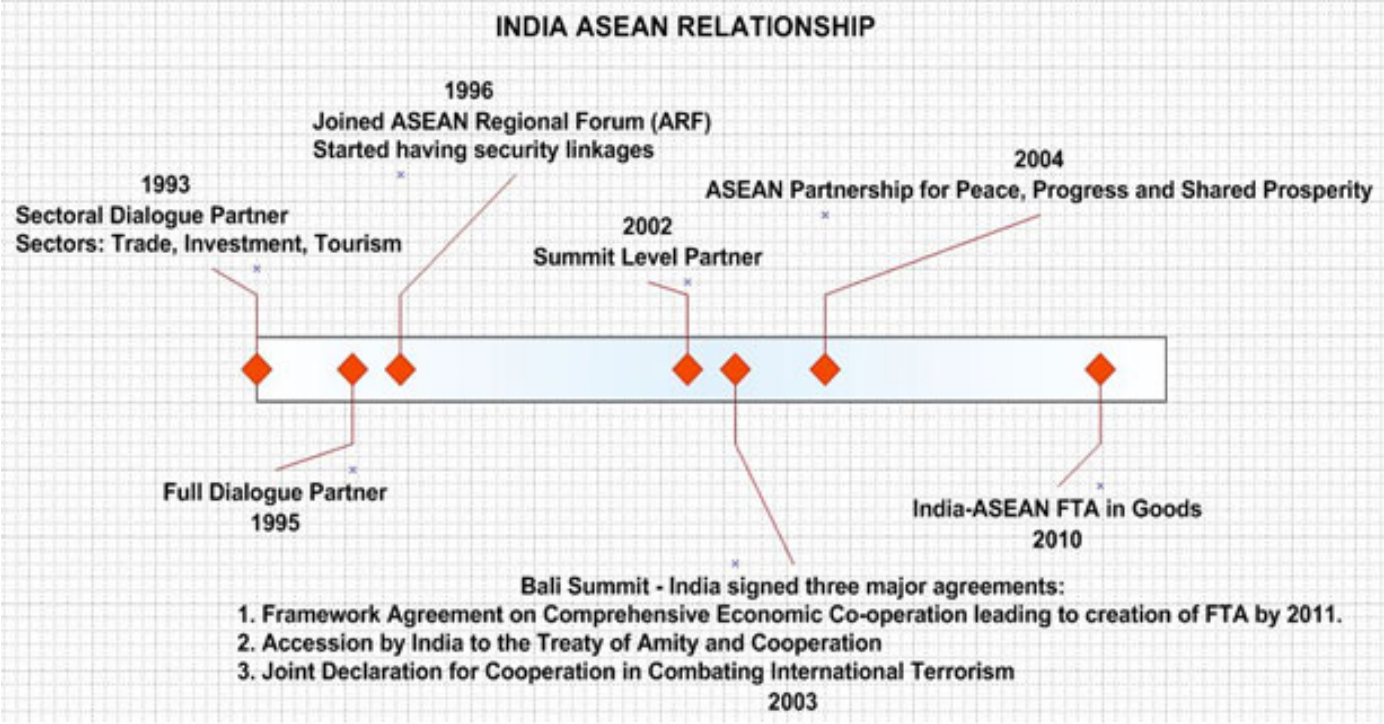
Chapter 6

Regional Organizations

Association of South East Asian Nations:

Established on 8 August 1967 under the Bangkok Declaration, ASEAN carries the motto of **"One Vision, One Identity, One Community".**

In his virtual speech at the ASEAN-India summit, PM Modi called the 21st century **"the century of India and ASEAN"**, and committed to India's support to **"ASEAN Unity, ASEAN Centrality, and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific".**



Recent News:

Key outcome of 22nd ASEAN-India Summit:

- India reaffirmed its **commitment to ASEAN Centrality, Unity**, and the **ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific (AOIP)**.
- **ASEAN-India Plan of Action (2026-2030) to implement ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership** announced in 2022.
- **2026** was designated as the **"ASEAN-India Year of Maritime Cooperation"** to enhance collaboration in the **Blue Economy**.
- Review of **ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement (AITIGA)** to enhance **trade facilitation.**
- Simplify **customs procedures.**
- Address **non-tariff barriers.**
- Create opportunities in **services and investment sectors.**
- **Connectivity: Physical and Digital Infrastructure.**

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- Focus on accelerating key projects:
  - **India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway.**
  - **Kaladan Multimodal Transport Project.**
- Aim: Transform **Northeast India into regional trade hubs** and border areas into economic corridors.
- Plans to extend the Trilateral Highway into Southeast Asia aligned with **ASEAN's Master Plan on ASEAN Connectivity (MPAC) 2025** under the strategy of **"Connecting the Connectivities".**
- Digital connectivity focus includes **Broadband networks, Submarine cable systems & Satellite communication.**
- The summit welcomed the **1st ASEAN-India Track 1 Cyber Policy Dialogue**, creating channels to address **cybersecurity threats to infrastructure**.

Significance of ASEAN - India Relations

1. **Regional Stability:** India's **'Act East Policy'** and **ASEAN's 'Outlook on the Indo-Pacific'** share complementary visions for regional stability.
2. **ASEAN Regional Forum** and the **Expanded ASEAN Maritime Forum** align with **India's SAGAR** doctrine.
3. **Economic Interdependence:** ASEAN is India's **4th largest trading partner**, with bilateral trade exceeding **$122 billion** in 2023-24.
4. **Maritime Security:** Proximity to the **Strait of Malacca** through which 60% of India's trade passes, **makes ASEAN** vital for Freedom of Navigation and securing Sea Lines of Communication.
5. **Counterbalance to China:** A strong partnership provides a strategic alternative for Southeast Asian nations facing Chinese assertiveness. Eg. **BrahMos missile exports** to the Philippines.
6. **Connectivity Hub:** Serves as a gateway for India's landlocked **Northeast region** to the global economy.
7. **Food Security:** ASEAN is a key supplier of edible oils (palm oil) and a market for Indian grains.
8. **Cultural Soft Power:** Ancient civilizational links (Buddhism, Ramayana) foster trust and long-term diplomatic goodwill.
9. **Defense Cooperation:** Eg. India conducting the **ASEAN-India Maritime Exercise (AIME)** in the South China Sea.
10. **Global Governance:** ASEAN support for India's **permanent seat** in an expanded UN Security Council.
11. **Supply Chain Diversification:** "China Plus One" strategy makes ASEAN-India a formidable manufacturing and assembly corridor.
12. **Counter-Terrorism:** Cooperation through the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF) to combat radicalization and cybercrime.

Points of Friction:

1. **Trade Deficit:** Eg. increasing imports of **palm oil and electronics** creating a persistent $40 billion deficit.
2. **RCEP Withdrawal:** India's exit from the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership created a "perception gap" regarding its economic commitment.
3. **Connectivity Delays:** Major projects like the IMT Trilateral Highway have missed multiple deadlines due to terrain and bureaucracy.
4. **Myanmar Crisis:** Differing approaches - India's "pragmatic engagement" with the Junta vs. some ASEAN nations' "isolation" policy.
5. ASEAN is **wary of India being too closely aligned with the "Quad," fearing regional militarization.**
6. **AITGA Limitations:** The current trade agreement is seen as outdated and biased toward manufacturing-heavy ASEAN economies. Indian service sectors face **non-tariff barriers.**

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7. **China's Economic Dominance** makes ASEAN hesitant to take strong "anti-China" stances. (China is the **top trading partner** for all 11 members)
8. **Internal ASEAN Fractures:** Eg. Pro-China members like **Cambodia** often block strong statements on South China Sea disputes.
9. **Trade and Investment Barriers: Non-tariff barriers, such as complex customs procedures and inconsistent regulations**, hinder smoother trade and investment flows.

Major Initiatives in Recent Years

- **ASEAN-India Plan of Action (2026-2030)** for deep-tech and maritime cooperation.
- **ASEAN-India Fund (AIF):** India doubled its contribution to $10 million for digital and green energy projects.
- **Science & Technology Fund** for collaboration in **Semiconductors and Space Tech**.
- **Centre for Southeast Asian Studies:** Established at **Nalanda University** (2025) to promote regional academic research.
- **Unified Payments Interface (UPI) Expansion:** Bilateral links with **PayNow (Singapore)** and **PromptPay (Thailand)**.
- **Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI):** Specifically the "Maritime Resources" pillar led by ASEAN-India cooperation.
- **Green Hydrogen Partnership (2025):** A framework for developing a regional supply chain for clean fuel.

Way Forward

1. **Upgrade the Act East Policy to Act Comprehensive:** Move beyond symbolism to a results-oriented strategy covering **security, trade, digital connectivity, and cultural diplomacy.**
2. **Accelerate Physical and Digital Connectivity**
   a. Fast-track the completion of the **India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway** and extend it to Laos, Cambodia, and Vietnam.
   b. Promote cross-border **digital public infrastructure** aligned with India Stack for fintech and governance solutions.
3. **Review and modernize** the **ASEAN-India Free Trade Agreement (AIFTA)** to address India's concerns about trade imbalance.
4. **Champion Multilateralism and Rule-Based Order:** Jointly uphold **freedom of navigation and international law (UNCLOS)** in the Indo-Pacific.
5. **Sustainable Development and Climate Partnership**: Partner with ASEAN on **disaster risk reduction, blue economy, circular economy**, and **climate-resilient infrastructure.**
6. **Active Neutrality in Myanmar:** India must leverage its unique ties with the Junta and the opposition to mediate a return to democracy. **(Shyam Saran)**
7. **Strengthen the "Maritime Pillar":** Use the 2026 Year of Maritime Cooperation to move from joint exercises to "joint manufacturing" of naval assets. **(Harsh V. Pant)**
8. **Bridge the RCEP Gap:** Explore "RCEP-minus" or deep bilateral FTAs with individual ASEAN members to compensate for staying out of the bloc.
9. **Institutionalize the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership:** Move from annual summits to quarterly working-group meetings on critical minerals and rare earths.

India-ASEAN cooperation embodies **South-South solidarity,** essential for achieving **SDGs, regional stability,** and **inclusive global governance.**

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QUAD

Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (QSD) or Quad is an informal strategic forum among like-minded democracies of the **USA, India, Japan and Australia**, aimed at ensuring and supporting a **"free, open and prosperous" Indo-Pacific region.**

History:

2004 Tsunami - Humanitarian assistance and Disaster Relief - The 4 countries came together.

2007 - Japanese PM put forth the idea of the **Arc of Prosperity and Freedom.**

2017 - Establishment of QUAD.

2019 - Grouping was extended to the ministerial level.

2020 - Malabar Exercise was extended to all the members.

QUAD Represents

- 24% of the global population.
- 35% of global GDP.
- 18% of global trade.

Wilmington Declaration (2024):

- Adopted at the **QUAD Leaders' Summit (September 2024, Wilmington - USA)**.
- Reaffirms QUAD's vision of a **Free, Open, Inclusive, and Rules-Based Indo-Pacific**.
- Positions QUAD as a **"force for good"** with expanded cooperation across sectors.

Key Highlights:

- **Indo-Pacific & Maritime Security.**
- Commitment to **freedom of navigation and maritime security**.
- Launch of:
  - **QUAD At Sea Ship Observer Mission - enhancing coast guard cooperation.**
  - **MAITRI Initiative** for interoperability & maritime domain awareness.
- **Infrastructure & Connectivity.**
- Initiatives launched:
  - **Quad Logistics Network**
  - **Ports of the Future Partnership**
- Expansion of **Quad Fellowships (2200+ experts).**
- **Technology & Cybersecurity.**
- Focus on **semiconductors, resilient supply chains, cybersecurity**.
- Creation of **Quadrilateral Information-Sharing Network (QUIN)**.
- **Climate, Space & People-to-People.**
- Launch of **Q-CHAMP (Climate Adaptation & Mitigation Package)**.
- Use of **Earth Observation systems** for disaster response.
- Expansion of **Quad Fellowship** in science, technology & policy.

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Significance of QUAD:

1. **Strategic Counterbalance to China:** Eg. Support for **ASEAN centrality, UNCLOS,** and peaceful resolution of disputes like the **South China Sea Dispute.**
2. **Maritime Rules-Based Order:** Ensures adherence to international laws like UNCLOS against unilateral attempts to change the status quo.
3. **Defence & Security:** Regular joint naval exercises like **Malabar** boost interoperability.
4. **Global Force for Good:** Eg. **the Quad Vaccine Partnership** delivering millions of doses to Southeast Asian and Pacific nations.
5. **Supply Chain Resilience:** Eg. Launch of the **Supply Chain Resilience Initiative (SCRI)** focusing on semiconductors and rare earths.
6. **Technological Standard Setting:** Eg. The Quad Principles on **Critical and Emerging Technology** (CET) for ethical AI development.
7. **Climate Action:** Eg. The **Quad Climate Working Group** focusing on green hydrogen and disaster-resilient infrastructure.
8. **Infrastructure Financing:** High-standard, transparent **alternatives to China's "debt-trap" BRI.** Eg. **Blue Dot Network** and $50 billion commitment for Indo-Pacific infrastructure.
9. **Counter-Terrorism:** Eg. **Quad Counter-Terrorism Working Group** to synchronize regional watchlists.
10. **Disaster response: HADR** initiatives under **Indo-Pacific Logistics Network.**
11. **Expansion Potential: "Quad Plus" engagements** involving South Korea, New Zealand, and Vietnam reflect the grouping's potential for future expansion.

Other Initiatives

- **IPMDA (Indo-Pacific Partnership for Maritime Domain Awareness):** Using commercial satellite data to track "dark shipping" and IUU fishing.
- **Quad Cancer Moonshot:** A health initiative launched in 2024 to reduce cervical cancer deaths in the Indo-Pacific.
- **Quad Fellowship:** Sponsoring 100 STEM students annually from member countries to study in the US.
- **Cable Connectivity and Resilience Centre:** Based in Australia to secure the subsea fiber-optic cables that power regional internet.
- **Quad Debt Management Resource Portal:** Helping Indo-Pacific countries manage sovereign debt and avoid "debt-trap" diplomacy.
- **Quad Senior Cyber Group:** Creating a "Cyber Security Framework" for critical regional infrastructure and 5G networks.
- **Open RAN (Radio Access Network):** Joint investment in open-architecture telecommunications to avoid reliance on Huawei/ZTE.

Major challenges

1. **Lack of Institutionalization:** The absence of a formal secretariat or treaty-based structure limits its long-term operational consistency.
2. **Concerns over continuity**: Eg. failure **to convene a leader-level summit** in 2025.
3. **ASEAN concerns** related to militarization of the region, regional polarization (pro and anti-China divide) and undermining of ASEAN Centrality.
4. **Divergent National Interests:** India focuses on land borders, while others focus on maritime zones. Similarly, India's **security relationship with Russia** creates friction with the US.

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5. **Different Indo-Pacific Visions:** India focuses on the Indian Ocean, while others focus on the Pacific.
6. **Economic Dependency on China:** Australia, Japan, and even India remain heavily reliant on trade with China, complicating decoupling.
7. **"Asian NATO" Perception:** Beijing's narrative that the Quad is a military alliance creates hesitation among neutral Southeast Asian nations
8. **US Strategic Distraction:** Ongoing conflicts in Ukraine and the Middle East divert US resources away from the Indo-Pacific.
9. **India's Strategic Autonomy:** India is reluctant to turn the Quad into a formal military alliance to avoid provoking China.
10. **Resource Constraints:** Delivering on massive infrastructure promises (like the $50 billion fund) requires consistent multi-year budgetary approvals.
11. **Exclusion of Regional Players:** Eg. the slow progress of **"Quad Plus"** formats.
12. **Vulnerability to China's Aggression:** India, being the only member with a land border with China, faces direct retaliatory risks. Eg. increased **LAC tensions (2020-present).**

Way Forward

1. **Define a Clear Indo-Pacific strategy** to position it as **"force for good"** & reassure regional players like ASEAN.
2. **Move Beyond "Anti-China" Rhetoric:** The Quad must continue defining itself by "what it stands for" (positive agenda) rather than just "what it is against." **(Harsh V. Pant)**
3. **Formalize Maritime Coordination:** Transition the Malabar Exercises into a permanent, coordinated patrol mechanism for the Indian Ocean.
4. **Institutionalize Through a Secretariat:** To ensure continuity, a small, permanent coordinating body should be established to oversee working group progress.
5. **Strengthen "Quad Plus" Engagements:** Institutionalizing regular meetings with South Korea, Vietnam, and New Zealand will broaden the grouping's regional legitimacy.
6. **Enhanced resource commitment** and **timely completion of project**s to ensure long-term impact.

BIMSTEC

The **BIMSTEC** has emerged as a critical vehicle for regional integration, as SAARC remains dormant. It also serves as the primary link between India's **"Neighborhood First" and "Act East" policies.**

Origin and Evolution

1. **Bangkok Declaration (1997):** Formed on June 6, 1997, as **BIST-EC** (Bangladesh, India, Sri Lanka, Thailand).
2. **Expansion (1997-2004):** Myanmar joined in late 1997 (**BIMST-EC**); Nepal and Bhutan joined in 2004.
3. **Institutionalization:** The Permanent Secretariat was established in **Dhaka (2014)**. The formal **BIMSTEC Charter** was adopted at the 5th Summit (2022), granting it legal status.

Composition and Key Data

1. **Members:** 7 (Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Myanmar, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Thailand).
2. **Population:** Over **1.73 billion** people (~22% of global population).
3. **Combined GDP:** Approximately **$5.2 trillion** (growing at an average of 6-7%).
4. **4% of the world's GDP and 4.5 % of the world's trade.**

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Recent News

- **6th BIMSTEC Summit (April 2025):** Held in Bangkok; Adopted the **"Bangkok Vision 2030"** for a prosperous and resilient region.
- **Maritime Transport Agreement (2025):** Member states signed a landmark pact to streamline coastal shipping and port access.
- **Operation Brahma (2025):** India led a coordinated BIMSTEC relief effort following a major earthquake in Myanmar.
- **BIMSTEC Youth Heritage Programme (2026):** India hosted the first-ever immersion program to promote regional cultural identity.

Significance of BIMSTEC

1. **Strategic Alternative:** Provides a functional regional platform for South Asia while SAARC remains paralyzed by bilateral tensions. **(SAARC- Pakistan)**
2. **Act East Linkage:** Acts as a physical and diplomatic bridge between South Asia and Southeast Asian markets.
3. **Economic Integration:** Unlocks the potential of the "Bay of Bengal" littoral states.
4. **Security Cooperation:** Eg. regular meetings of **BIMSTEC National Security Chiefs** to synchronize anti-radicalization strategies.
5. **Maritime Domain Awareness:** Ensures safety of the "Global Commons" in the Bay of Bengal. Eg. joint naval tracking of illegal fishing and piracy via the **Information Fusion Centre** in India.
6. **Blue Economy Potential:** Promotes sustainable use of ocean resources, including fisheries and deep-sea minerals. Eg. **BIMSTEC Blue Economy Policy**.
7. **Connects India's landlocked Northeast to the sea** through neighboring Bangladesh and Myanmar ports. Eg. **Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project**.
8. **Disaster Resilience:** Eg. The **BIMSTEC Centre for Weather and Climate** (India) provides early warnings to member states.
9. **Cultural Connectivity:** Revives historical "Silk Road" links and spiritual ties to foster people-to-people harmony. Eg. Development of the **BIMSTEC Buddhist Circuit.**
10. **Technology Sharing:** Bridges the digital divide through collaborative research in AI, agriculture, and space technology.
11. **Public Health Cooperation:** Eg. Establishment of a **BIMSTEC Traditional Medicine Network** for affordable and indigenous healthcare.

Major Issues and Limitations

1. **Bilateral Tensions:** Eg. **The Rohingya refugee crisis** significantly strained diplomatic relations between Bangladesh and Myanmar.
2. **Lack of economic integration:** India's trade with BIMSTEC countries accounted for only **4%** of its total foreign trade.
3. **Lack of institutionalization**: Only 6 summits have been held in the last 27 years. The secretariat became operational after 14 years of establishing BIMSTEC
4. **Implementation Delays** due to "red tape" and slow execution. Eg. **The IMT Trilateral Highway** remains incomplete despite being under discussion for over a decade.
5. **Lack of Financial Resources:** The Secretariat remains underfunded compared to other regional blocs like ASEAN or the EU.

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6. **Domestic Political Instability:** Frequent changes in government within member states often lead to shifts in regional priority. Eg. Political transitions in **Bangladesh (2024)** and **Sri Lanka**.
7. **China's Overwhelming Influence:** Eg. Myanmar and Sri Lanka's heavy **infrastructure debt to China** complicates their strategic alignment with BIMSTEC.
8. **Stalled FTA Negotiations** due to disagreements over **Rules of Origin** and "negative lists".
9. **Limited Secretariat Power:** The Secretariat has little executive authority, serving primarily as a coordinating and administrative body.
10. **Asymmetry in Size:** India's massive size and economy create fears of "Big Brother" dominance among smaller neighbors.
11. **Geographical Disconnect:** Lack of direct land connectivity between some members (Eg. Sri Lanka and Bhutan) complicates integration.

Major Initiatives

1. **Bangkok Vision 2030:** A roadmap for a "Prosperous, Resilient, and Open" BIMSTEC region.
2. **BIMSTEC Master Plan for Transport Connectivity:** Identifying 264 projects to enhance regional logistics by 2030.
3. **Coastal Shipping Agreement:** Streamlining cargo movement between ports to reduce transit time and costs.
4. **BIMSTEC Energy Centre (India):** A facility to coordinate the regional power pool and promote renewable energy.
5. **Mutual Assistance in Customs Matters:** An agreement to simplify trade documentation and prevent regional smuggling.
6. **BIMSTEC Startup Conclave:** An initiative to foster innovation and entrepreneurship among regional youth.
7. **BIMSTEC Centre for Weather and Climate:** Providing real-time early warning services for natural disasters.

Way Forward

1. **Institutionalize the Charter:** Ensure the 2022 Charter is fully operationalized to give the group legal teeth in global forums. (**C. Raja Mohan**)
2. **Focus on "Low-Hanging Fruits":** Prioritize finishing existing projects like the IMT Highway before launching new grand initiatives. (**Shyam Saran**)
3. **Enable Digital Integration:** Scale India's Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) across the region to facilitate seamless trade and services.
4. **Finalize the FTA:** Conclude the Trade in Goods agreement to boost intra-regional trade beyond the current 7%.
5. **Strengthen the Secretariat:** Increase the budgetary and human resource capacity of the Dhaka-based Secretariat.
6. **Bridge the Trust Deficit:** Use "Track 1.5" and "Track 2" diplomacy to resolve bilateral issues like the Rohingya crisis.
7. **Energy Connectivity:** Accelerate the cross-border power grid to ensure regional energy independence and green transition.
8. **Engage Civil Society:** Move beyond "Summit-level" diplomacy to include academia, media, and youth in regional building.

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SAARC

The **South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC)** is the primary intergovernmental organization for regional integration in South Asia.

Recent Major News (2024-2026)

- After the funeral of former Bangladesh PM Khaleda Zia, **Chief Adviser Muhammad Yunus** called for a **"reformatted SAARC"** during his meeting with several regional leaders in Dhaka.
- India approved a **₹3,000 crore** withdrawal for the Maldives under the **SAARC Currency Swap** Framework to stabilize its economy.
- In 2025, the **SAARC Food Bank** was utilized **to assist Sri Lanka** during a minor grain shortage.

Origin and Evolution

1. The idea was first formally proposed by President **Ziaur Rahman** of Bangladesh in 1980.
2. Officially founded on **December 8, 1985**, with the signing of the SAARC Charter in Dhaka.
3. **Secretariat:** Established in **Kathmandu, Nepal**, on January 17, 1987.
4. **Evolution:** Originally 7 members; **Afghanistan** joined as the 8th member in 2007.

Composition and Key Data

1. **Members (8):** Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan, Sri Lanka.
2. **Observers (9):** Australia, China, EU, Iran, Japan, Mauritius, Myanmar, South Korea, USA.
3. **Population:** ~21% of the world's population (~1.73 billion people).
4. **Global GDP:** Contributes roughly **4.2%** of the world's GDP.
5. **Intra-regional Trade:** Remains low at **~5%**, contrasted with ASEAN's 25%.

Major Objectives of SAARC

1. To **promote the welfare** of the peoples of South Asia and improve their quality of life.
2. To accelerate **economic growth, social progress, and cultural development** in the region.
3. To promote and strengthen **collective self-reliance** among the countries of South Asia.
4. To contribute to **mutual trust, understanding, and appreciation** of one another's problems.
5. To **strengthen cooperation with other developing countries** and international organizations with similar aims.
6. Cooperation based on the principles of **sovereign equality and territorial integrity.**

Significance and Achievements of SAARC

1. **Only forum** where **heads of all eight South Asian nations** legally engage on regional issues.
2. **SAPTA & SAFTA:** Established the South Asian Free Trade Area to reduce customs duties on traded goods.
3. **Shared Civilizational Identity:** Represents a common geography, history, and culture that transcends modern political borders.
4. Serves as the **primary institutional vehicle** for India's "Neighborhood First" Policy.
5. **Strategic Counterweight:** Helps India maintain its leadership role and balance external influences, particularly China's, in the region.
6. **Regional Stability:** Essential for managing cross-border issues like migration, radicalization, and internal security threats.

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7. **Soft Power Projection:** Eg. leveraging the **South Asian University** to train the region's future leaders in Delhi.

Major Issues and Limitations

1. **Indo-Pak Rivalry** over Kashmir and terrorism prevents any meaningful consensus on regional progress. Eg. **indefinite postponement** of the 19th Summit since 2016.
2. The SAARC Charter requires **unanimous approval** for all decisions, allowing one state to veto. Eg. Pakistan blocking the **SAARC Motor Vehicle Agreement.**
3. **Low Intra-regional Trade (<5%): T**rade is hindered by non-tariff barriers and poor cross-border infrastructure.
4. **"Big Brother" Syndrome:** Smaller neighbors often perceive India's economic and geographical size as a threat to sovereignty.
5. **External Influence (China):** Eg. demand for inclusion of **China by some** countries.
6. **Exclusion of Bilateral Issues:** The Charter prohibits discussing bilateral disputes, leaving the core causes of friction unaddressed. Eg. Failure to mediate in **the Rohingya crisis**.
7. **Weak Implementation:** Eg. **The Social Charter** remains a largely symbolic document with limited ground-level impact.

Major Initiatives and achievements

1. **SAFTA (2006)**: Intra-SAARC trade increased from **$1 billion (1995) to ~$23 billion (2020)**.
2. **SAARC Development Fund** (**$300 million)**: Supports **social, economic, and infrastructure projects.**
3. **SAARC Tuberculosis & HIV/AIDS Centre (Bangladesh)**: Health cooperation.
4. **SAARC Agriculture Centre (Bhutan)**: Agricultural development.
5. **COVID-19 Emergency Fund:** India-led initiative with a $21 million pool for medical supplies.
6. **South Asia Satellite:** Communication satellite for regional connectivity and data sharing.
7. **BBIN Motor Vehicle Agreement:** A sub-regional "workaround" to SAARC for seamless transport between 4 members.
8. **SAARC Disaster Management Centre (India)** for **disaster preparedness & response**.
9. **SAARC Food Bank:** A strategic reserve of over 500,000 tonnes of grain for food security.
10. **SAARC Currency Swap:** Provides up to $2 billion in liquidity to member central banks.
11. **South Asian University:** A flagship academic project fostering regional youth integration.

Way Forward

1. **Adopting "Member-Minus-One":** Move away from the unanimity rule to allow willing members to proceed with projects.
2. **Functionalism over Politics:** Focus on "low-politics" areas like climate and disaster management that are non-contentious.
3. **Institutionalize the Secretariat:** Grant the Secretary-General more executive power to enforce project deadlines.
4. **Leverage Digital Connectivity:** Use "India Stack" to create a South Asian Digital Common Market for services.
5. **Sub-Regionalism:** Strengthen clusters like BBIN as "proof of concept" for broader SAARC integration later.
6. **Bridge the Trust Deficit:** Use "Track 2" diplomacy and cultural exchange to reduce the "Big Brother" perception of India.

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7. **Re-evaluate Observer Roles:** Engage observers like Japan and the EU more deeply in infrastructure funding.
8. **Reforming SAFTA:** Expand the free trade agreement to include services and remove the "sensitive lists."

BRICS

The **BRICS** grouping has evolved from an investment term into a powerful geopolitical bloc.

Origin and Evolution

1. The acronym **"BRIC"** was coined in 2001 by **Goldman Sachs economist Jim O'Neill** to identify high-growth emerging economies.
2. The first meeting of Foreign Ministers took place on the UNGA margins in 2006; The first formal Leaders' Summit was held in **Yekaterinburg, Russia (2009)**.
3. South Africa joined in 2011 (**BRICS**). Expansion occurred at the 2023 Johannesburg Summit, with new members joining in **2024 (Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, UAE)** and **2025 (Indonesia)**.
4. In 2024, the group introduced a **"Partner Country"** category to engage nations like Malaysia, Thailand, and Nigeria without granting full membership.

Composition and Key Data

1. **Full Members (11):** Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, Egypt, Ethiopia, Indonesia, Iran, Saudi Arabia, and UAE. (Note: Saudi Arabia participates but has maintained a nuanced formal status.)
2. **Global Population:** Represents over **45%** of the world's population (~3.6 billion people).
3. **Global GDP (PPP):** Accounts for approximately **37%** of global GDP, surpassing the G7's share.
4. **Global Oil Production:** Controls roughly **42%** of global oil production and exports.

Recent News

- **India Hosts 18th Summit (2026)** with the theme **"Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation, and Sustainability".**
- **Rio Summit (July 2025):** Brazil hosted the 17th Summit focusing on **AI Governance** and the "Rio Declaration" on inclusive global governance.
- **Local Currency Settlement:** India and the UAE successfully executed the first-ever crude oil payment in **Rupees/Dirhams** under the BRICS framework.

Objectives of BRICS

1. **Global Governance Reform:** To reform the UNSC, IMF, and WB for equitable representation.
2. **Multipolar World Order:** To challenge Western-centric dominance and promote a more balanced, non-hegemonic global system.
3. **Financial Autonomy:** To reduce reliance on the US Dollar and SWIFT by promoting local currency trade.
4. **Sustainable Development:** To collaborate on green technology, food security, and SDGs.
5. **Security Cooperation:** To synchronize stances on counter-terrorism, cybersecurity, and regional conflicts (Eg. Gaza, Ukraine).

Significance of BRICS

1. **Voice of Global South:** Provides a powerful platform for developing nations to influence global rules and standards. Eg. advocating for CBDR in international climate negotiations.

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2. **Representative of new world order**: It serves as a **counter to groupings like G-7** which are dominated by the West.
3. **Alternative to Bretton Woods Institutions:** The **New Development Bank (NDB), Contingency Reserve Agreement, and BRICS pay**
4. **De-dollarization Hub:** Leads the global shift toward trade in local currencies to mitigate exchange rate volatility. Eg. R**upee-Rouble** and **Rupee-Dirham**.
5. **Energy Security Bloc:** The inclusion of Iran and UAE makes BRICS a dominant force in global energy policy.
6. **Strategic Autonomy:** Allows countries like India to balance relations between the West and the "Rest" effectively. Eg. India participates in both the **Quad** and **BRICS**.
7. **Reform Pressure Group:** Exerts collective pressure on the IMF/World Bank to increase voting shares for emerging markets.
8. **Technological Sovereignty:** Promotes cooperation in AI, 5G, and space to avoid reliance on Western tech monopolies. Eg. **BRICS Statement on Global AI Governance** (2025).
9. **Alternative Financial Safety Net:** Eg. **The Contingent Reserve Arrangement (CRA)** provides a $100 billion backup fund for members.

Major Issues/Limitations of BRICS

1. China is pushing for inclusion of countries like **Belarus, which are under heavy debt trap influence from China,** as an attempt to make BRICS a China-centric platform.
2. **Internal Rivalries:** Deep-seated friction between India and China (Eg. border disputes) prevents total strategic cohesion.
3. **Diverse Political Systems:** Vibrant democracies (India, Brazil) Vs autocracies (Russia, China, Iran). Difficulty in consensus on **human rights or democratic norms** in joint declarations.
4. **Expansion Complexity:** A larger "BRICS+" risks becoming a "talk shop" like the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM).
5. **Dominance of China:** Fears that the group is becoming a vehicle for Chinese geopolitical and economic interests.
6. **Slow De-dollarization:** Despite rhetoric, the US Dollar remains the dominant currency for over 80% of global trade.
7. **Informal Structure:** Lack of a permanent secretariat or charter makes it less effective than formal blocs like the EU.
8. **Sanctions on Russia:** Western sanctions on Russia limit the group's ability to use the NDB for certain projects.
9. **Low Intra-BRICS Trade:** Eg. most members still rely on **G7 markets** for high-tech imports and services exports.

Major Initiatives

1. **New Development Bank (NDB):** Headquartered in Shanghai; has approved over $35 billion in infrastructure loans.
2. **Contingent Reserve Arrangement:** A $100 billion fund to provide short-term liquidity support to members.
3. **BRICS Pay:** Cross-border payment system currently in pilot mode to bypass SWIFT
4. **BRICS Vaccine R&D Centre:** Launched during the pandemic to facilitate technology transfer and vaccine equity.
5. **Remote Sensing Satellite Constellation:** Six satellites from member states sharing data for disaster management.

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6. **BRICS PartNIR:** Partnership on New Industrial Revolution to cooperate on AI, digitalization, and green tech.
7. **BRICS Space Council (2025):** A new body to coordinate deep-space exploration and lunar research.

Way Forward

1. **A Balanced Global Voice:** BRICS must ensure it does not become an "anti-West" bloc but a "pro-Global South" advocate.
2. **Define Expansion Criteria:** The group must formalize criteria for "Partner Countries" to ensure economic synergy and strategic focus.
3. **Institutionalize the NDB:** Strengthen the bank's capital base and include more Global South nations to broaden its legitimacy.
4. **Focus on Climate Resilience:** Use the 2026 Summit to align BRICS influence with the green energy needs of the Global South.
5. **Strengthen Digital Infrastructure:** Promote "India Stack" (UPI/DPI) as a model for financial inclusion across BRICS nations.
6. **Focus on "Low-Hanging Fruit" (Functionalist approach):** Prioritize cooperation in health, space, and education, which are less politically sensitive.
7. India should guide BRICS toward being a "constructive" rather than "disruptive" force in global governance.

Shanghai Cooperation Organisation:

The **SCO** is a permanent intergovernmental international organization that has evolved into the world's largest regional body by both geography and population.

Origin and Evolution

1. **Shanghai Five (1996):** Formed by China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Tajikistan to manage border disputes and demilitarization.
2. With the induction of Uzbekistan, the group was renamed the SCO in 2001, in Shanghai.
3. The **SCO Charter** was signed in 2002 and entered into force in 2003, formalizing its legal and institutional framework.
4. **India and Pakistan** joined as full members during the **Astana Summit (2017).**
5. **Recent Enlargement: Iran** (2023) and **Belarus** (2024) were inducted.

Key Data

1. Covers **~40%** of the world's population (approx. 3.4 billion people).
2. Covers **~80%** of the Eurasian landmass, spanning from Eastern Europe to the Pacific.
3. Contributes over **25%** of the global GDP (Nominal).
4. **Institutional Bodies:** Permanent Secretariat in **Beijing** and the Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS) in **Tashkent**.

Recent News

- **25th SCO summit in 2025**: **India's Defence Minister refused to sign the joint statement** at the Defence Ministers' meeting as it **omitted the mention of the Pahalgam terror attack** while mentioning the Jaffar Express hijacking in Pakistan in March.

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Key Outcomes of the 2025 SCO Summit

- The **Tianjin Declaration** condemned terrorism, including the **Pahalgam attack**, urged an end to **cross-border terrorism**, and opposed the use of **extremist groups as mercenaries.**
- **Membership & Partnerships: Laos** joined as a partner, expanding SCO's strength to **27 nations** (10 members, 17 partners).
- Launched the **Global Governance Initiative (GGI)** to uphold **sovereign equality, multilateralism**, and a **just global order.**
- Supported the **UNGA resolution against Nazism and xenophobia**, and reaffirmed **mutual respect, cultural exchange, and people-to-people ties.**
- **Regional Peace:** Condemned **military actions in Gaza and Iran**, and called for **inclusive governance in Afghanistan** to ensure stability.
- **Economic & Development Cooperation:** Agreed to establish an **SCO Development Bank** to boost regional growth.

Major Objectives of SCO

1. **Security & Counter-Terrorism:** Fighting the "Three Evils"-terrorism, separatism, and extremism - through regional intelligence sharing.
2. **Multipolarity:** Promoting a fair and rational international political and economic order to counter Western-led dominance.
3. **Economic Cooperation:** Enhancing trade, transport, and energy partnerships across the Eurasian landmass.
4. **Cultural Exchange:** Building mutual trust and "neighborliness" through education, tourism, and humanitarian initiatives.
5. **Regional Stability:** Ensuring peace in Afghanistan and Central Asian border regions through collective security dialogues.

Significance of SCO:

1. **Gateway to Central Asia:** Provides a strategic platform to engage with landlocked Central Asian republics rich in minerals.
2. **Counter-Terrorism Platform:** Access to the **RATS database** helps India track regional terror movements and radicalization trends.
3. **Energy Security Hub:** Connects India to Russia and Central Asian gas/oil reserves essential for energy independence.
4. **Strategic Autonomy:** Allows India to maintain a presence in a "non-Western" bloc while participating in Western-led groups like QUAD.
5. **Afghan Stability:** Essential for India to have a seat at the table regarding the security vacuum in Afghanistan.
6. **Civilizational Soft Power:** Revives historical "Silk Road" and "Buddhist Circuit" links. Eg. designation of **Varanasi** as the first SCO Cultural and Tourism Capital (2022-23).
7. **Market Access:** Provides an alternative trade route to the massive Eurasian market amidst global supply chain shifts.

SCO's challenges:

1. **Expansion Dilemma:** SCO's enlargement, including Belarus, raises its global profile but **dilutes regional focus.**
2. **Chinese Hegemony:** Beijing's **Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)** dominates the group's economic agenda.

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3. **Consensus Constraint:** Every decision requires a unanimous vote, allowing a single member to veto any initiative.
4. **Diverse Interests:** Member states have diverse interests, making consensus-building challenging. Eg. **India declared, 'Pakistan as an epicenter of terrorism'.**
5. SCO is increasingly seen as an **"anti-West" forum, and the entry of Iran into the SCO** has made the situation difficult for India.
6. **Sino-Russian Axis:** The growing dependence of Russia on China limits India's ability to use Moscow as a balancer. Eg. Russia's support for **CPEC.**
7. **Connectivity Barriers:** Lack of direct land access through Pakistan limits India's physical trade with other members. Eg. trade with Central Asia remains under **$2 billion.**
8. **Institutional Weakness:** The Secretariat has limited executive power and relies heavily on member-state funding. Eg. delays in implementing the **Regional Transport Master Plan.**
9. **Sanction Complications:** Western sanctions on members like Russia, Iran, and Belarus complicate financial and banking cooperation.

Major Initiatives

1. **SCO-RATS:** A permanent body to coordinate regional efforts against terrorism, separatism, and extremism.
2. **SCO Startup Forum:** An India-led initiative to build a regional entrepreneurial ecosystem.
3. **SCO Young Scientists Conclave:** A platform for researchers to collaborate on common societal challenges like water and food security.
4. **Shared Buddhist Heritage:** A cultural initiative led by India to map and preserve Buddhist historical sites.
5. **SCO Energy Club:** A mechanism to synchronize energy policies between producers (Russia/Iran) and consumers (India/China).

Way Forward:

1. India must treat the SCO as a "tactical platform" rather than a "romanticized" instrument for a multipolar world. (**Shyam Saran)**
2. **Focus on Functionalism:** Prioritize non-contentious areas like science, tech, and healthcare where consensus is easier.
3. **Leverage "India Stack":** Use Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) to position India as the regional hub for a modern, knowledge-based economy.
4. **Bridge the Connectivity Gap:** Rapidly operationalize the INSTC and Chabahar Port to offer a viable alternative to the BRI.
5. **Navigate the Sino-Russian Axis:** India must skillfully manage its relationship with a "China-dependent" Russia to protect its Eurasian interests. (**Vijay Gokhale)**
6. **Civilizational Dialogue:** Use the "One Earth, One Family, One Future" message to shape a more inclusive SCO discourse.
7. **Reform SCO Norms:** Push for institutional mechanisms to verify and investigate cross-border terror claims within the RATS framework.

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Arctic Council:

The **Arctic Council** is the leading intergovernmental forum promoting cooperation among the Arctic States, with a focus on sustainable development and environmental protection.

Origin and Evolution

1. **Genesis (1991):** Roots lie in the **Arctic Environmental Protection Strategy (AEPS)**, a non-binding agreement focused on pollution monitoring.
2. **Establishment (1996):** Formally established via the **Ottawa Declaration** to expand cooperation beyond just the environment to sustainable development.
3. Following the **conflict in Ukraine,** the "Arctic 7" (Western members) paused cooperation with Russia.

Composition of Arctic Council

1. **Arctic States (8):** Canada, Kingdom of Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Norway, Russia, Sweden, and the USA.
2. **Permanent Participants (6):** Indigenous peoples' organizations (Eg. Saami Council, Inuit Circumpolar Council) with full consultation rights.
3. **Observer States (13):** Non-Arctic nations including **India**, China, Japan, France, and Germany.



4. **Observer Organizations:** Includes Intergovernmental (Eg. UNDP, UNEP) and Non-governmental organizations (Eg. WWF).
5. **Working Groups (6):** Specialized bodies like **AMAP** (Monitoring) and **PAME** (Marine Environment) that conduct the bulk of the scientific work.
6. India has held **Observer Status** since 2013, which was renewed in 2019 and 2023.
7. India operates **'Himadri'** (Svalbard), a permanent research station, and the **'IndARC'** multi-sensor moored observatory.

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Significance of Arctic Council for India

1. **Monsoon Correlation:** Scientific links suggest that Arctic sea ice melting directly impacts the predictability of Indian monsoons.
2. **Energy Security:** The Arctic holds 13% of undiscovered oil and 30% of gas. Indian PSU **ONGC Videsh** explores long-term stakes in Russian Arctic LNG projects to diversify energy baskets.
3. **Scientific Diplomacy:** Participation allows India to contribute to global climate discourse without being a regional littoral state.
4. **Mineral Wealth:** Critical minerals like copper, phosphorus, and rare earth elements.
5. **Alternative Trade Routes:** The opening of the Northern Sea Route (NSR) could reduce shipping distances between Europe and Asia.
6. Scientific expertise gained in the Arctic is directly applicable to the **Himalayan "Third Pole".**
7. **Strategic Positioning:** Eg. Counterbalancing **China's "Near-Arctic State"** claim by asserting India's century-old link via the Svalbard Treaty.
8. **Standard Setting:** Involvement in the Council ensures India has a voice in polar shipping codes and environmental regulations. Eg. **IMO's Polar Code**.

Different Challenges facing the Arctic Region:

1. **Geopolitical Fracture:** The 2022 invasion of Ukraine led to a "pause" in cooperation between Russia and the "Arctic 7".
2. **Military Security Exclusion:** The Ottawa Declaration (1996) explicitly excludes military security, leaving no forum for regional arms control.
3. The Council is **"informal" not a formal treaty organization**; Its recommendations are not legally enforceable.
4. **Restricted Observer Role:** Non-Arctic states like India have no voting rights and limited participation in core decision-making.
5. **The Arctic does not conceptually qualify as a global commons** (much of the region's ocean falls within the recognized national jurisdictions of the Arctic states).
6. **China,** which calls itself a **near-Arctic State**, has announced ambitious plans for a **'Polar Silk Route'** to connect to Europe as well as building massive icebreakers.

Major Initiatives by India

1. **India's Arctic Policy (2022):** Unveiled a clear 6-pillar framework (Science, Climate, Economic, Connectivity, Governance, Capacity Building).
2. **First Winter Expedition (2024):** Launched by the Ministry of Earth Sciences to study the Arctic during the polar night (Nov-Mar).
3. **NSR Feasibility Studies (2023):** India and Russia launched joint studies to operationalize the **Northern Sea Route** for cargo.
4. **Green Strategic Partnership:** Collaboration with **Denmark** and **Norway** focusing on sustainable maritime technology and wind energy.
5. **Polar Research Coordination:** Establishment of the **National Centre for Polar and Ocean Research (NCPOR)** as the nodal agency for Arctic-Antarctic synergy.
6. **Svalbard Treaty Legacy:** Reasserting India's 1920 signatory status to claim a historical and legal right to presence in the region.

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Way Forward:

1. **Diversify Partnerships:** Deepen ties with Nordic states for "Green Arctic" technology.
2. **Active Observer Role:** Move beyond being a "passive observer" to a "shaper" of Arctic norms through **science-based diplomacy**.
3. Strategically integrate the Northern Sea Route into the **International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC)**.
4. **Climate-First Approach:** Ensure Arctic engagement remains "climate-sensitive" to maintain India's image as a responsible global power.
5. Push for the **"Internationalization of Arctic Science"** to prevent the region from becoming a site of "Cold War 2.0".
6. Advocate for the Arctic to remain a **"Zone of Peace"** governed by the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea. (**UNCLOS**)

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Chapter 7

International Policies & Diplomacy

India's Neighbourhood First Policy:

India's **Neighbourhood First Policy (NFP)** is a cornerstone of its foreign policy, emphasizing stable, prosperous, and connected relations with its immediate neighbors.

Core Pillars (The 5S Approach)

1. **Samman:** Respecting the sovereignty and specific developmental needs of each neighbor.
2. **Samvad:** Continuous high-level political engagement to prevent communication gaps.
3. **Shanti:** Ensuring regional stability by countering cross-border terrorism and extremism.
4. **Samriddhi:** Sharing India's economic growth through trade, aid, and connectivity.
5. **Sanskriti:** Leveraging shared civilizational links and people-to-people ties.

Current Affairs

- **Maldives Debt Stabilization (2025):** India extended a **₹4,850 crore Line of Credit** and deferred debt repayments to stabilize the Maldivian economy amidst its fiscal crisis.
- **Operation Brahma (2025):** The Indian Army provided massive medical and humanitarian assistance following a major earthquake in **Myanmar**.
- **Regional Power Grid (2025):** India signed landmark agreements with Nepal to build high-capacity **cross-border transmission lines** (Inaruwa-New Purnea).
- India launched **Operation Sagar Bandhu** to provide humanitarian assistance and disaster relief following Cyclone Ditwah, which devastated parts of Sri Lanka.

Relevance of India's Neighbourhood First policy:

1. Building trust and addressing "Big Brother Syndrome" through frequent high-level visits and non-reciprocal developmental partnerships
2. **Strategic Security Buffer:** Stable neighbors prevent external hostile powers from using their territories for anti-India activities. Eg. Stability in Myanmar is crucial for India's North-East.
3. **Internal Security Stability:** Effective border management with neighbors reduces illegal migration, human trafficking, and drug smuggling.
4. **Countering Chinese Influence:** Offers a sustainable alternative to China's "debt-trap" infrastructure projects under the BRI. Eg. India's $4 billion assistance to Sri Lanka in 2022.
5. **Promoting regional economic integration:** Immediate neighbors provide a natural market for Indian manufactured goods, services, and digital products.
6. Strengthening India's role as Net Security provider & ensuring secure Sea Lines of Communication (SLOCs). Eg. joint radar networks with Maldives and Mauritius.
7. Strengthening India's Disaster Diplomacy: Eg. Operation Sagar Bandhu (2025) assisted Sri Lanka after the devastating Cyclone Ditwah.
1. A successful neighborhood policy solidifies India's Global South leadership. It also helps in mobilizing neighborhood support for India's permanent membership bid.
    a. Strengthening energy security: Eg. Hydro-power imports from Bhutan.

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Challenges in Neighbourhood First Policy:

1. **The "Big Brother" Syndrome:** Smaller neighbors often perceive India's proactive engagement as intrusive or "hegemonic" in nature.
2. **China's Chequebook Diplomacy:** India's financial resources cannot match China's massive, unconditional infrastructure funding in the short term.
3. **Project Delivery Deficit:** India faces criticism for "announcing much but delivering slowly" compared to China. Eg. delays in the Kaladan Multi-Modal Project.
4. **Pakistan Deadlock:** The "terror and talks cannot go together" stance has paralyzed SAARC and regional trade.
5. **Domestic Political Spillover:** Internal Indian state politics (Eg. West Bengal or Tamil Nadu) often stall bilateral agreements. Eg. Teesta Water Sharing Agreement.
6. **Cartographic Aggression**: Eg. Nepal's inclusion of the Kalapani-Lipulekh triangle in its official political map in 2020.
7. **Political Instability:** Eg. Myanmar coup in 2021, ouster of Sheikh Hasina in 2024.
8. **Refugee Crisis & Migration:** Eg. over 40,000 refugees from Myanmar entered Mizoram, leading to the suspension of the Free Movement Regime (FMR).
9. **Low Intra-Regional Trade**: Trade within South Asia is under 5% of its total trade, the lowest for any global region.
10. **Radicalization & Extremism:** Rising fundamentalism in the neighborhood poses a direct threat to India's secular and social fabric.

Major Initiatives

- **BIMSTEC Revitalization:** Shifting focus from SAARC to BIMSTEC as the primary vehicle for regional integration.
- The **India-Bangladesh Friendship Pipeline** for high-speed diesel transport.
- **Inland Waterways:** Utilizing the **Chittagong and Mongla ports** for connecting India's North-East.
- **Lines of Credit (LOC):** Expanding soft loans from $3.3 billion (2014) to over **$15 billion (2026)** for regional infra.
- **Operation Brahma:** The 2025 humanitarian mission to Myanmar earthquake victims.
- **UPI-RuPay Expansion:** Financial integration projects in Mauritius, Sri Lanka, and Nepal.

Way Forward

1. **Shift to "System-based Integration":** Move from project-based diplomacy to creating regional electricity and digital grids.
2. **Depoliticize Regional Trade:** Ensure that trade corridors remain open even when political relations are strained.
3. **Active "Listening" Diplomacy:** Host annual "Neighbours Retreats" to project India as a partner that listens rather than lectures.
4. **Manage Domestic Spillover:** Create a "Bilateral Consultative Committee" involving Indian state governments and neighboring nations.
5. **Bridge the Delivery Deficit:** Empower the Ministry of External Affairs with more personnel and dedicated funding for timely project completion.
6. **Non-reciprocity 2.0:** India must be willing to bear the "asymmetric costs" of regional integration to reap long-term security. **(Shyam Saran)**

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7. **Countering Anti-India Narratives:** Invest in local-language media and cultural centers to battle "misinformation" in neighboring capitals.
8. **Strategic Patience:** Recognize that neighborhood ties are a "long game" requiring resilience against periodic regime changes. **(S.D. Muni)**

Success of NFP depends on India's ability to bridge perceptions of India **as an "elder brother" rather than a "big brother".**

Act East Policy:

India's **Act East Policy (AEP)**, launched in 2014, marks a strategic shift from the purely economic "Look East Policy" to a more proactive, multi-dimensional engagement with the Indo-Pacific.

Origin and Evolution

1. **Look East Policy (1991):** Formulated by PM Narasimha Rao to revive India's economy post-Cold War by engaging ASEAN. Focus was primarily on trade and investment.
2. **Expansion (2004-2014):** Coverage expanded to include East Asian nations (Japan, South Korea) and Australia.
3. **Act East Policy (2014):** Formally launched at the **12th ASEAN-India Summit**. It added a **security dimension** and placed the **North-Eastern Region (NER)** at the heart of the policy.
4. **Indo-Pacific Vision (2018):** PM Modi's Shangri-La Dialogue speech expanded the AEP's scope to the entire Indo-Pacific region under the **SAGAR** vision.
5. Elevation of India-ASEAN ties to a **Comprehensive Strategic Partnership** (2022) and the conclusion of **major defence deals** like the BrahMos export to the Philippines.

Core Pillars (The 4 C's)

1. **Commerce:** Enhancing trade through FTAs and integrating India into global value chains.
2. **Culture:** Leveraging civilizational links through Buddhism, yoga, and Bollywood.
3. **Connectivity:** Physical (roads/ports), digital (fiber optics), and people-to-people links.
4. **Capacity Building:** Training, education, and development assistance to partner nations.

Significance of India's Act East Policy

1. **Strategic Counter-Balance to China:** Preventing the Indo-Pacific from becoming a "unipolar" region. Eg. Upgrading ties with **Vietnam** to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership.
2. **Gateway to North-East Development:** Transforms landlocked North-Eastern states into an international hub for trade and manufacturing.
3. **Maritime Domain Awareness:** Ensures the safety of Sea Lines of Communication (SLOCs) against piracy and illegal maritime claims. Eg. Regular **"Malabar" naval exercises.**
4. **Supply Chain Resilience:** Reduces economic over-reliance on a single source by diversifying imports of critical tech and minerals.
5. **Defence Export Hub:** Eg. Selling **LCA Tejas and BrahMos missiles** to Southeast Asian nations.
6. **Cultural Soft Power:** Revives the ancient "Spice Route" and "Buddhist Circuit" to foster civilizational solidarity.
7. **Energy Security:** Accessing vast offshore gas reserves and collaborating on green hydrogen technology. Eg. ONGC Videsh's investment in **gas blocks off the coast of Vietnam**.
8. **Institutional Leadership:** Solidifies India's role as a key decision-maker in forums like the East Asia Summit (EAS).

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9. **Diaspora Engagement:** Leverages the successful 3-million-strong Indian diaspora in ASEAN for investments and lobbying.

Major Initiatives

1. **India-Japan Act East Forum (2017):** A unique platform for Japan to fund infra in India's NER (approx. ₹13,000 crore).
2. **BIMSTEC Master Plan:** A transport connectivity project linking the Bay of Bengal to the Mekong region.
3. **Mission SAGAR:** Humanitarian missions providing food and medical aid to Indian Ocean and Pacific Island nations.
4. **FIPIC (Forum for India-Pacific Islands Cooperation):** A structured outreach to 14 Pacific Island nations.
5. **Quick Impact Projects (QIP):** Small-scale development projects (schools, clinics) in Cambodia, Laos, and Vietnam.
6. **1000 PhD Fellowships:** Specifically for ASEAN students to study at India's IITs.
7. **Agartala-Akhaura Rail Link:** The critical "bottleneck breaker" for connecting Kolkata to North-East via Bangladesh.

Major Issues/Limitations

1. **Project Delivery Gap:** India is criticized for being "slow to implement" compared to China's fast-tracked projects. Eg. **The Kaladan Multi-Modal Project** has faced over a decade of delays.
2. **Myanmar Instability:** Civil unrest in Myanmar blocks the primary land route connecting India to Southeast Asia.
3. **Economic Disenchantment:** India's exit from the RCEP has led to concerns that it might be economically isolated from the bloc.
4. **Chinese "String of Pearls":** Proactive Chinese naval presence and port investments in the region encircle Indian maritime interests. Eg. Expansion of **Ream Naval Base** in Cambodia.
5. **Sensitive Agri-Trade:** Eg. periodic **tariff hikes on refined palm oil** causing diplomatic friction with Malaysia and Indonesia.
6. **Internal Security:** Ethnic tensions and insurgency within India's North-East deter foreign investors and slow down infrastructure. Eg. **Manipur crisis**.
7. **Resource Constraints:** India's financial "chequebook" is limited compared to China's multi-billion dollar Belt and Road Initiative.
8. **Regulatory Incoherence:** Frequent changes in Indian tax laws and e-commerce rules create uncertainty for East Asian investors.
9. **Asymmetric Trade Deficit:** Eg. **$40 billion trade deficit** with ASEAN, largely driven by electronics and chemical imports.
10. **Divisions within ASEAN:** Eg. divergent views on **South China Sea disputes** among ASEAN members hinder a unified maritime response.

Way Forward

1. **Accelerate the "Act" in Act East:** India must prioritize completing the Trilateral Highway and Kaladan project to match Chinese delivery speed. (**Harsh V. Pant)**
2. **Focus on "Security First":** Build deep-sea naval assets and maritime sensors to be the region's "Net Security Provider".
3. **Bridge the RCEP Gap:** Explore bilateral Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreements (CEPAs) with individual ASEAN nations to regain lost trade momentum.
4. **Leverage Japan:** Institutionalize the Japan-India partnership to counter China's BRI with high-quality infrastructure.

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5. **Maritime Law Leadership:** Lead the drafting of a "Global Code of Conduct" for the Indo-Pacific based on UNCLOS.
6. **Inclusive Global South:** Use the AEP to channel the voice of Pacific Island nations in global climate and debt dialogues.

Indo-Pacific Policy:

India's **Indo-Pacific Policy** represents a strategic reconceptualization of the maritime space from the shores of Africa to the Americas.

Origin and Evolution

1. **Confluence of Two Seas (2007):** Roots lie in Japanese PM Shinzo Abe's speech to the Indian Parliament, envisioning the integration of the Indian and Pacific Oceans.
2. **Shangri-La Dialogue (2018):** PM Modi's keynote speech formally articulated India's vision for a **"Free, Open, and Inclusive Indo-Pacific" (FOIIP)**, emphasizing ASEAN centrality.
3. Launch of the **Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative in 2019** to provide a cooperative mechanism based on specific pillars.
4. Post-Galwan shift toward closer security alignment with the **Quad** (India, US, Japan, Australia) and active participation in the **IPEF** (Indo-Pacific Economic Framework).

Core Pillars

1. **ASEAN Centrality:** Recognizing ASEAN as the geographic and institutional heart of the region.
2. **Inclusiveness:** Opposing "club-based" exclusions; advocating a region open to all who follow international law.
3. **Rules-Based Order:** Upholding **UNCLOS** (Law of the Sea) to ensure freedom of navigation and overflight.
4. **Sustainable Connectivity:** Promoting infrastructure that respects sovereignty and avoids "debt-trap" diplomacy.
5. **Strategic Autonomy:** Engaging in minilateralism (Quad, I2U2) while maintaining independent decision-making.

Recent News

1. **BBNJ Treaty Entry (Jan 2026):** India leads regional implementation of the "High Seas Treaty" to create Marine Protected Areas in the Indo-Pacific.
2. Full operationalization of **Quad IPMDA** (Indo-Pacific Partnership for Maritime Domain Awareness), providing real-time data to Pacific and Indian Ocean nations.
3. **India-Vietnam Strategic Upgrade (May 2026):** Joint statement emphasizing the Indo-Pacific Vision and granting mutual market access for agri-products like grapes and durians.
4. **IPEF Supply Chain Agreement (2024-25):** India ratified the first-of-its-kind multilateral agreement to coordinate responses to supply chain disruptions.
5. **First Indian Port in Vietnam (2025):** Discussions finalized for an Indian consortium to develop a deep-sea terminal to counter regional port encirclement.
6. **South China Sea Stance (2024):** India's strongest-ever diplomatic note supporting the 2016 Arbitral Award in favor of the Philippines.

Significance of Indo-Pacific for India

1. **Trade Arteries Security:** Over 90% of India's trade by volume and 50% of its value passes through these waters.

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2. To ensure the **Strait of Malacca** remains open to prevent a "choke-point" crisis for Indian energy imports.
3. **Rules-Based Maritime Order:** Preventing "might makes right" by enforcing universal compliance with international maritime laws like **UNCLOS.**
4. Strengthening India's role as **"Net Security Provider"** in the Indian Ocean.
5. **Strategic Counter-Balancing:** Acts as a geographical shield to prevent a unipolar, hegemon-dominated regional order.
6. **Economic Supply Chains:** Central to the "China Plus One" strategy, attracting manufacturing shifts from East Asia to India.
7. **Blue Economy Growth:** Holds vast untapped potential for deep-sea mining, offshore wind energy, and sustainable fisheries.
8. **Diplomatic Leadership:** Provides a platform for India to lead the "Global South" on maritime security and climate justice through **IORA.**
9. **Technological Cooperation:** Accessing critical and emerging technologies through partnerships like the Quad and iCET.
10. **Energy Diversification:** Eg. **ONGC Videsh's** strategic gas blocks in the South China Sea.

Major Issues/Limitations

1. **Project Delivery Deficit:** Eg. Chronic delays in the **Kaladan Multi-Modal Project** undermining India's reliability as a connectivity partner.
2. **Resource Constraints:** Eg. Difficulty in maintaining a **sustained dual-carrier presence** across both the Indian and Pacific Oceans.
3. India's **withdrawal from RCEP and staying out of the IPEF trade pillar** limits economic integration.
4. **Geopolitical Balancing Act:** Difficulty in balancing the "Quad" security alignment with its "BRICS" and "SCO" commitments.
5. **ASEAN Internal Fracture:** Lack of unity within ASEAN on the "China challenge" complicates India's "ASEAN Centrality" pillar. Eg. **pro-China** stance by **Cambodia and Laos**.
6. **Underdeveloped Island Infrastructure:** India's own island territories (Andaman) lack the deep-sea port facilities needed for major power projection.
7. **Fragmented Policy Doctrine:** Lack of a single, codified "National Indo-Pacific Strategy" document leads to fragmented regional messaging.

Major Initiatives

1. **Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (2019):** India-led initiative with 7 pillars (Australia, France, Japan have joined as lead partners for specific pillars).
2. **Quad IPMDA:** Providing satellite-based radio frequency data to track "Dark Vessels" (illegal fishing/smuggling).
3. **Indo-Pacific Economic Framework (IPEF):** Engaging 14 nations on supply chains, clean energy, and fair economy.
4. **Supply Chain Resilience Initiative (SCRI):** Launched by India, Japan, and Australia to reduce dependence on China.
5. **FIPIC:** The Forum for India-Pacific Islands Cooperation to engage 14 Pacific Island nations.
6. **Act East Forum:** Specifically for Japanese investment in India's North-East to link it to Southeast Asia.
7. **Maritime Domain Awareness (MDA):** Setting up Information Fusion Centres (IFC-IOR) at Gurugram to coordinate with regional navies.

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Way Forward

1. India must integrate **SAGAR and Act East into a single "Unified Indo-Pacific Doctrine"** for clarity. **(Harsh V. Pant)**
2. **Accelerate "Act" in Act East:** Focus on completing "bottleneck" projects like the Trilateral Highway to build credibility.
3. **Hedge with Minilaterals:** Use trilateral groups (India-France-Australia) to bypass the sluggishness of larger regional bodies.
4. **Security-Development Nexus:** Ensure maritime security is backed by "Green Infrastructure" to win over Global South nations.
5. **Bridge the RCEP Gap:** Pursue aggressive bilateral FTAs with individual ASEAN members and the UK/EU to offset RCEP exclusion.

Indo-Pacific Economic Framework for Prosperity (IPEF)

- Unveiled by the US in **2022** alongside leaders from 13 partner nations.
- Designed to re-engage the U.S. economically in the Indo-Pacific following its 2017 withdrawal from the TPP.
- **Composition:** 14 members representing **40% of global GDP.**
- **The "Four Pillar" Approach:**
  1. **Trade**
  2. **Supply Chain Resilience**
  3. **Clean Economy**
  4. **Fair Economy**
- Members can choose which "pillars" to join. India has joined three out of four, opting out of the **Trade Pillar** due to concerns over labor and environmental standards.
- The **Supply Chain Agreement** (Pillar II) became the first-of-its-kind multilateral treaty to officially enter into force, establishing a "Crisis Response Network".

Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI)

It is **India's open, non-treaty-based global initiative** launched to manage the maritime domain through collaborative efforts.

Launched by Prime Minister Modi at the **14th East Asia Summit (2019)** in Bangkok, it serves as the practical implementation tool of India's **SAGAR** doctrine.

Core Pillars (7 Pillars)

1. **Maritime Security:** Ensuring safe sea lanes (Co-led by **India & UK**).
2. **Maritime Ecology:** Protecting the marine environment (Co-led by **Australia & Thailand**).
3. **Maritime Resources:** Sustainable use of ocean wealth (Co-led by **France & Indonesia**).
4. **Capacity Building & Resource Sharing:** Information exchange (Co-led by **Germany**).
5. **Disaster Risk Reduction:** Handling tsunamis/cyclones (Co-led by **India & Bangladesh**).
6. **Science, Technology & Academic Cooperation:** Ocean research (Co-led by **Italy & Singapore**).
7. **Trade, Connectivity & Maritime Transport:** Port infrastructure (Co-led by **Japan & USA**).

MAHASAGAR Doctrine (Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions):

It is a strategic upgrade of the 2015 **SAGAR** (Security and Growth for All in the Region) vision.

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While SAGAR focused primarily on cooperative security within the Indian Ocean, **MAHASAGAR** reflects India's transition from a regional maritime power to a **global maritime stakeholder and leader of the Global South.**

Core Pillars (The 3 Dimensions):

1. **Trade for Development:** Enhancing economic ties through technology-sharing, trade in local currencies, and supply chain resilience.
2. **Capacity Building for Sustainable Growth:** Supporting partner nations with infrastructure development, educational fellowships, and Blue Economy initiatives.
3. **Mutual Security for a Shared Future:** Transitioning from being a "Net Security Provider" to a **"First Responder"** for non-traditional threats like cyber-attacks, climate disasters, and illegal fishing.

Global governance of Sea Lines of Communication (SLOCs)

Legal and Institutional Architecture

- **UNCLOS (1982):** The primary legal framework defining maritime zones (Territorial Sea, EEZ, High Seas) and sovereign rights over resources.
- **High Seas Treaty:** Entering into force in **January 2026**, it provides a legal mechanism to create **Marine Protected Areas (MPAs)** in international waters.
- **International Maritime Organization (IMO):** The UN body responsible for the safety of shipping and the prevention of marine pollution by ships (MARPOL).
- **International Seabed Authority (ISA):** Regulates mineral-related activities in the "Area" (seabed beyond national jurisdiction) under the principle of "Common Heritage of Mankind."
- **ITLOS:** The Hamburg-based judicial body that adjudicates disputes arising from the interpretation of UNCLOS.
- **FAO (Port State Measures Agreement):** The first binding international agreement to specifically target **Illegal, Unreported, and Unregulated (IUU) fishing**.
- **Commission on the Limits of the Continental Shelf (CLCS):** Experts who facilitate the implementation of UNCLOS regarding the outer limits of the continental shelf.

Recent News

- **High Seas Treaty Entry into Force (Jan 17, 2026):** Reached the required 60 ratifications; the first **COP for BBNJ** is scheduled for late 2026.
- **Red Sea Security Crisis (2024-25):** Houthi attacks on commercial shipping in the Bab-el-Mandeb.
- **Deep Sea Mining Deadlock:** The ISA failed to finalize the "Mining Code," leading to a split between nations pushing for extraction and those calling for a "precautionary pause".
- **Plastic Treaty Breakthrough:** The UN Global Plastic Treaty (negotiated in 2025) began its first phase of implementation to stop marine plastic influx.

Major Challenges in Ocean Governance

- **Enforcement Vacuum:** Vastness of the High Seas makes monitoring and policing illicit activities almost impossible for national navies.
- **Geopolitical Weaponization of SLOCs:** Eg. **The Red Sea and Strait of Hormuz** became volatile zones for merchant shipping during regional wars.
- **The "Precautionary" Mining Gap:** Pressure to extract critical minerals for the "Green Transition" vs. unknown ecological impacts of deep-sea mining.

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- **Fragmented Sectoral Governance:** Multiple agencies (IMO, ISA, FAO) often work in silos, leading to overlapping or contradictory regulations.
- **Undersea Cable Security:** 99% of global data travels via undersea cables, which lack a specific, robust international protection regime.
- **Sovereignty Disputes** lead to militarization and disregard for international tribunal rulings. Eg. **South China Sea dispute**.
- **Marine Plastic Pandemic:** Estimated 12 million metric tonnes of plastic enter oceans yearly, entering the human food chain via microplastics. Eg. The **Great Pacific Garbage Patch**.

Way Forward

- **Bridge the Security-Economy Divide:** Establish a "Global Maritime Domain Awareness" network to protect SLOCs from non-state actors.
- **Blue Finance:** Scale "Blue Bonds" to fund coral restoration and sustainable fisheries in developing coastal states.
- Create an international **convention** for the protection of undersea telecommunication cables.
- **Empower ITLOS:** Strengthen the enforcement power of maritime tribunals to make their rulings more than just "advisory" for major powers.
- **Decarbonize Shipping:** Mandate the shift to Green Ammonia and Hydrogen fuels via IMO-led global carbon levies on dirty bunker fuel.

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Chapter 8

Miscellaneous

PYQs

[2023] Indian diaspora has scaled new heights in the West. Describe its economic and political benefits for India. (10)
[2020] 'Indian diaspora has a decisive role to play in the politics and economy of America and European Countries'. Comment with examples. (10)
[2017] Indian Diaspora has an important role to play in South-East Asian countries' economy and society. Appraise the role of Indian Diaspora in South- East Asia in this context (15)

Soft Power diplomacy:

Coined by **Joseph Nye** in 1990, **Soft Power** is the ability of a country to persuade others to do what it wants without force or coercion.

It arises from three primary resources:

1. A country's **culture** (in places where it is attractive),
2. **Political values** (when it lives up to them at home and abroad).
3. **Foreign policies** (when they are seen as legitimate and having moral authority).

Key Instruments of India's Soft Power

1. **Yoga & Ayurveda:** Institutionalized through the International Day of Yoga.
2. **Diaspora:** Over **32 million** diaspora act as cultural bridges and political influencers.
3. **Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI)** as a model for financial inclusion for the Global South.
4. **Bollywood & Creative Arts:** Indian cinema and OTT content.
5. **Spiritual Tourism:** Projects like the **Buddhist Circuit** and the Ramayana Circuit.
6. **Democratic Values:** India's identity as the **"Mother of Democracy".**
7. **Developmental Partnership:** Non-reciprocal aid, technical training (ITEC), and capacity building in Africa and Southeast Asia.
8. **Cuisine:** Eg. **International Year of Millets**.

Significance of Soft Power Diplomacy

1. **Global influence:** Soft power can help India to enhance its image and reputation in the world. Eg. **Indian values of Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam, Non-Aligned Movement.**
2. **Advancing Foreign Policy Goals and Interests:** Soft power can help in promoting regional stability and strengthening multilateral cooperation. Eg. **India's SAGAR initiative.**
3. **Building Strategic Partnerships:** Eg. **India's outreach to Pacific Island countries, Project Mausam, etc.**
4. **Strategic De-hyphenation:** Allows India to build deep ties with competing powers. Eg. India's relations with the **US (democracy) and Russia (History)**.
5. Positions India as a **"Voice of the Global South"**. Eg. Vaccine Maitri initiative.

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6. **Countering "Hard Power" Limitations** by winning "hearts and minds." Eg. India's goodwill in **Afghanistan** due to infrastructure projects like the Salma Dam.
7. **Tourism Attraction:** Eg. the **"Incredible India"** campaign.
8. **Diaspora Leveraging:** Eg. the role of the **Indian-American community** in pushing for the landmark Civil Nuclear Deal.
9. **Multilateral Influence:** Eg. broad international support for India-led initiatives like the **International Solar Alliance (ISA)**.
10. **Educational Hub Status:** Eg. the **"Study in India"** program targeting students from Africa and Central Asia.
11. **Maritime Security Cooperation:** Eg. cultural links under **Project Mausam** easing naval docking rights in the Indian Ocean.
12. **Global Agenda Setting:** Eg. popularizing the **"LiFE" (Lifestyle for Environment)** movement at the COP summits.

Limitations of Soft Power Diplomacy

1. From **a realist perspective** of international relations, soft power can complement hard power but cannot replace it.
2. **Budgetary Constraints:** Eg. The **ICCR** (Indian Council for Cultural Relations) operates on a highly limited annual budget.
3. **Domestic Social Strife:** Internal instances of intolerance diminish India's image as a pluralistic democracy. Eg. attack on African students in Delhi.
4. **Visa & Immigration Barriers:** Strict visa regimes for students and tourists from developing nations hinder people-to-people exchange.
5. **Lack of Coordinated Agency:** Soft power efforts are fragmented across different ministries (Culture, Tourism, MEA, AYUSH).
6. **The neglect of heritage sites** reduces their appeal as global cultural hubs.
7. **Information Warfare:** India's soft power is vulnerable to organized disinformation campaigns on social media. Eg. coordinated **online campaign** to portray India as an unsafe destination.

Way Forward

1. **Institutional Restructuring:** Create a "Soft Power National Security Council" to integrate cultural outreach with strategic goals.
2. **Boost Funding to** ICCR and the Ministry of Culture to match regional competitors.
3. Use the **"India Stack"** as a cornerstone for a new "Digital Soft Power" doctrine.
4. **Heritage Restoration:** Implement a "PPP model" for the maintenance of 100 top monuments to boost spiritual tourism.
5. **Vernacular Outreach:** Produce cultural content in local languages of Africa and Central Asia.
6. **Smart Power Integration:** Ensure soft power is always backed by reliable hard power and efficient economic delivery.
7. PP Chaudhary led Panel Recommendations:
   a. **MEA to lay out a PR plan for promoting Tourism.**
   b. **MEA to expand its network of tourism offices abroad.**
   c. **Work diligently to promote Indian Pharmacopoeia and get recognition for Ayurveda as a medical system.**

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Indian Diaspora:

PM Modi - "The Indian diaspora are our **cultural ambassadors** who carry the Indian ethos with them, contributing immensely to the countries they reside in".

Key Data Points

- **Total Population:** Approximately **35 million** spread across 200+ countries.
- **Remittance Inflows: $138 billion** in 2025-26.
- Diaspora-led **Global Capability Centers (GCCs)** in India contribute roughly **$46 billion** in annual revenue and employ over 1.6 million professionals.
- Over **300 persons of Indian origin** hold high-ranking political offices globally.

Significance of Indian Diaspora:

1. **Economic Powerhouse:** In 2025, India topped the remittances inflow list with **$138 billion.**
2. **Political Clout:** People of Indian Origin holding prominent political positions **in the US, UK, and PM rightly call them Rashtradoots.**
3. **Entrepreneurship:** Indian Origin CEOs of big Tech companies **like Alphabet(Sundar Pichai), Microsoft(Satya Nadella), IBM(Arvind Krishna), etc.**
4. **Bridge Builders:** Backchannel or Track II diplomacy, acting as intermediaries. Eg. **Indian diaspora role in facilitating the 123 Agreement with the US.**
5. **Cultural Ambassadors: The Times Square Yoga Day** celebration attracts thousands of participants annually.
6. **Philanthropy:** Eg. **Indira Gandhi Institute of Technology (IGIT), Sarang, funded in part by donations from Indian expatriates.**
7. **Knowledge Transfer:**
   a. **Initiatives like TiE (The Indus Entrepreneurs)** promote mentoring and networking between diaspora professionals and Indian startups.
   b. **Indian-American astrophysicist Subrahmanyan Chandrasekhar's theories** inspired generations of Indian researchers in physics and space science.

Challenges faced by indian diaspora:

1. **Reduced remittance** growth rate: **Due to post-pandemic recovery leading to Tight Labor Markets in countries like the U.S, UK, and Singapore.**
2. **Economic slowdown and protectionism: Eg. "America first" and H-1B visa restrictions**.
3. **Increase in hate crimes:** Eg. the 2017 hate crime against Indian engineer **Srinivas Kuchibhotla in Kansas,** who was killed in a racially motivated shooting.
4. **Issues with labor laws:** Certain labor laws in West Asia**, like Kafala and Nitaqat,** exploit Indian workers and violate their human rights and dignity.
5. **Security threats:** Instability and civil wars in countries like **Bahrain and Yemen** pose risks to the safety and security of Indian workers.
6. **Support for separatist movements:** Some sections of the Indian diaspora, **particularly in Canada,** provide funding support for separatist movements **like Khalistan.**
7. **Heterogeneous diaspora:** The diverse diaspora from different countries has varied needs and priorities, **making it challenging to devise a unified diaspora policy.**

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Initiatives taken by government:

1. **Pravasi Bharatiya Divas (PBD):** Biennial event to institutionalize engagement; confers the Samman awards.
2. **OCI Card Expansion:** Lifelong visa and property rights, with the **2026 Budget** further easing investment caps.
3. **VAIBHAV Fellowship:** Bringing diaspora scientists to Indian labs for collaborative R&D.
4. **MADAD Portal:** A digital platform for time-bound grievance redressal of overseas Indians.
5. **Know India Programme (KIP):** Reconnecting diaspora youth (ages 18-30) with their Indian roots through 3-week tours.
6. **e-Migrate System:** A digital ecosystem to protect low-skilled workers from fraudulent recruitment agents.
7. **Pravasi Kaushal Vikas Yojana (PKVY):** Skill certification for the workforce seeking overseas employment.
8. **Global Capability Centers (GCC) Policy:** Fiscal incentives to encourage diaspora leaders to set up centers in India.
9. **Direct Capital Access:** 2026 reform allowing NRIs to invest directly in listed Indian companies through a regulated PIS route.
10. **Operation Kaveri/Vande Bharat:** Large-scale evacuation missions.

Way Forward:

1. **Establish a Diaspora Bond:** Launch long-term "Infrastructure Bonds" specifically for the diaspora to fund national projects.
2. **Consider "Voting Rights" Reforms:** Explore secure digital voting for NRIs to enhance their stake in India's democracy.
3. **Negotiate Social Security Agreements:** Expand bilateral pacts to ensure Indian workers can "totalize" and export their pension benefits.
4. **Streamline Philanthropy:** Create a "Green Channel" for diaspora-funded development projects to bypass bureaucratic hurdles.
5. **Focus on "Brain Circulation":** Incentivize short-term "teaching residencies" for diaspora academics in Indian universities.
6. **Strengthen Consular Presence:** Open more consulates in "migration hubs" to provide real-time support to the blue-collar workforce.
7. **Standardize Domestic Skilling:** Align India's vocational training with G-20 standards to ensure "better-wage" migration.
8. **A Unified Diaspora Policy:** Create a comprehensive "White Paper" to synchronize the 4Cs: Care, Connect, Celebrate, and Contribute.

Energy Diplomacy

Energy Diplomacy is the use of foreign policy to secure energy supplies, attract investment in the energy sector, and export domestic energy technologies.

India is the world's **third-largest** energy consumer and is projected to account for **35% of future global demand growth**.

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4 Strategic Pillars of 2026 Energy Diplomacy

The "Realism" Pillar (Fossil Fuel Resilience)

1. Navigating a fractured West Asia & energy diversification.
2. **Recent Move:** At **India Energy Week 2026 (Goa)**, India reinforced long-term LNG and crude partnerships with the UAE and Canada.
3. Eg. Negotiating "Sanction-exempt" humanitarian windows for Indian-flagged tankers in the Strait of Hormuz during the 2026 regional crisis.
4. India now imports crude from **41 countries.**

The "Green Leadership" Pillar (ISA & OSOWOG)

1. **Objective:** Leading the Global South in the transition to renewables through the **International Solar Alliance (ISA)**.
2. **Recent Move:** The **"One Sun, One World, One Grid" (OSOWOG)** aiming to link regional grids across Asia and Africa.
3. Eg. **providing** concessional credit lines to African nations (Eg. Senegal, Mozambique) for solar-powered irrigation and mini-grids.

The "Hydrogen Diplomacy" Pillar

1. **Objective:** Positioning India as a primary exporter of **Green Hydrogen** and its derivatives (Green Ammonia).
2. **Recent Move:** India's push for green hydrogen at **Davos 2026 (WEF)** summit, with major MOUs signed with Germany and Japan for industrial-scale supply chains.
3. Eg. **setting** up "Hydrogen Corridors" with the Netherlands and Norway for port-to-port green fuel transport.

The "Nuclear Revival" Pillar

1. **Objective:** Diversifying the energy mix through civil nuclear cooperation and emerging technologies.
2. **Recent Move:** The **India-France Joint Statement (Feb 2026)** fast-tracked collaboration on **Small Modular Reactors (SMRs)** and Advanced Modular Reactors.
3. Eg. finalizing technical specifications for the Jaitapur Nuclear Power Plant while exploring MRO facilities for advanced engines.

Major Initiatives

- **India Energy Week (IEW) 2026:** Held in Goa, it served as the premier global forum for "Energy Addition," focusing on dual-track investment in both fossil and green fuels.
- **Global Biofuel Alliance (GBA):** Launched during the G20, it reached a milestone in 2025 with **19% ethanol blending** achieved nationwide, targeting 20% by ESY 2025-26.
- **One Sun One World One Grid (OSOWOG):** Initiated inter-continental grid-linkage trials to share solar power across time zones, primarily with Middle Eastern and ASEAN neighbors.
- **10-Year UAE Energy Pact for** crude and LPG.
- **International Solar Alliance (ISA) Expansion:** Shifted focus to **"Solar for Health"** and "Solar for Irrigation" in LDCs.
- **Strategic Petroleum Reserves (SPR) Phase II:** Fast-tracked the development of new underground storage in **Odisha and Karnataka** for a 90-day buffer.
- **Green Hydrogen Corridors:** Signed MOUs with Germany, Japan, and the EU to establish maritime routes for exporting Indian-produced Green Ammonia.
- **Nuclear Energy Mission 2026:** Focused on **Small Modular Reactors (SMRs)** in collaboration with France and the US to decentralize carbon-free power.

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- Joined the **Mineral Security Partnership (MSP)** and signed bilateral pacts with Australia and Argentina for Lithium and Cobalt.

Significance of Energy Diplomacy

1. **Strategic Autonomy:** Reducing reliance on single-source suppliers or volatile trade routes to prevent domestic economic shocks.
2. **Macroeconomic Stability Shield:** Protects the Indian Rupee and Current Account Deficit from volatile global oil price spikes. Eg. A $10 **rise in oil prices** can widen India's CAD by 0.4% of GDP.
3. **Global South Advocacy:** Eg. **leading** the **Global Biofuels Alliance** to create a low-carbon pathway for agrarian economies.
4. **Counter-balancing Regional Hegemony:** Strategic investments in overseas energy assets act as a check on competitors' (China) resource-grabbing strategies.
5. **Neighborhood First Policy:** Creating a "South Asian Power Pool" fosters regional interdependence and stability. Eg. Exporting **hydro-power from Nepal and Bhutan.**
6. **Climate Justice Positioning:** Demanding affordable climate finance from the Global North as a prerequisite for accelerated decarbonization.

Major Challenges

1. **Geopolitical Volatility Chokepoints:** Over 60% of oil and 90% of LPG imports transit through the vulnerable **Strait of Hormuz**.
2. **Critical Mineral Dependency:** Eg. **China's control (70-90%)** over mineral processing creates a concentrated supply risk for Indian EV manufacturers.
3. **Financing the Transition:** India requires nearly **$350 billion** by 2030 for its RE goals.
4. **Secondary Sanctions Risks:** US/EU sanctions on Russia and Iran complicate India's ability to pay and engage in joint ventures.
5. **The Coal Paradox:** Eg. India's refusal to sign the **"Coal Phase-out"** pledge due to domestic development and energy poverty imperatives.
6. **Regulatory Hurdles: multiple compliance requirements** across different government departments.
7. **Limited Domestic Manufacturing Capacity:** Eg. **over 50% of solar cells** and modules are imported from China.

Way Forward

1. Prioritize energy corridors via **IMEC** and Arctic routes to bypass the volatile Strait of Hormuz
2. **Transition from large solar parks to decentralized solar** (PM-KUSUM) to minimize land-use conflicts.
3. **Standardize Global Green Hydrogen:** Lead the world in creating a unified "Certificate of Green Origin" to facilitate seamless hydrogen trade.
4. **Green Sovereign Bonds** to attract global investments.

Disaster Diplomacy:

Disaster diplomacy refers to the strategic use of humanitarian aid and disaster relief operations to build, strengthen, or repair diplomatic relations.

It involves the deployment of specialized personnel (like the NDRF), medical teams, and relief material to affected nations, grounded in the civilizational philosophy of **"Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam"**.

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Key Pillars of India's Disaster Diplomacy

1. **First Responder Doctrine.**
2. **Non-Intrusive Aid:** focusing purely on humanitarian needs without political strings.
3. **PM Modi's 10-Point Agenda**, which calls for greater cohesion in international response.
4. Integrating disaster relief into the **Security and Growth for All in the Region** maritime policy.
5. **Institutionalized Multilateralism:** Leveraging platforms like **CDRI** to lead global policy.
6. **Capacity building:** Eg. South Asia Satellite for early warning systems and hazard mapping.
7. **Whole-of-Government Approach:** Coordination between the MEA, MHA, and Armed Forces.

Significance of Disaster Diplomacy

1. **Soft Power Projection:** Fosters global goodwill and portrays India as a compassionate, responsible global stakeholder. Eg. **Operation Dost** in Turkey-Syria (2023).
2. **Countering Hegemonic Influence:** Offers an alternative to China's "debt-trap" diplomacy by providing transparent, grant-based humanitarian assistance.
3. **Regional Stability:** Prevents state collapse or mass migration in the neighborhood. Eg. post-earthquake reconstruction aid to **Nepal**.
4. **Operational Readiness:** Overseas deployments serve as "live drills" for India's own disaster response agencies (NDRF/Navy).
5. **Maritime Leadership:** Consolidates India's status as the "Net Security Partner" in IOR. Eg. **Operation Sagar Bandhu** (2025) in Sri Lanka after Cyclone Ditwah.
6. **Global South Leadership.**
7. **Ethical Global Governance:** Signals India's readiness for a **Permanent Seat at the UNSC**. Eg. evacuation of **27 different nationalities** during the Yemen crisis (Operation Raahat).

Major Challenges in Disaster Diplomacy

1. **Geopolitical Hostilities:** Eg. **Pakistan's rejection** of Indian aid during the devastating 2022 and 2024 flood seasons.
2. **Funding Constraints:** India's relief budget is a fraction of major powers like the US/Japan.
3. **Logistical Bottlenecks:** Dependency on limited heavy-lift aircraft (C-17 Globemasters) for long-distance relief operations.
4. **Post-Disaster Neglect:** India often excels in "Rescue" but falls behind in "Rehabilitation" and long-term economic recovery. Eg. slow pace of **housing projects in Sri Lanka**.
5. **Limited Impact**: Eg. strained India-Nepal relations despite India's post-EQ reconstruction aid.

Way Forward

1. **Institutionalize HADR Guidelines:** Formally adopt the **October 2024 NDMA Guidelines** for all overseas operations.
2. Use the **Quad's "HADR Partnership"** to pool resources for high-cost hospital ships and heavy-lift assets.
3. Create a **"Disaster Volunteers Corps"** of doctors and engineers to supplement the military.
4. **Hyper-Local Warning Systems:** Export the **Common Alerting Protocol (CAP)** to all BIMSTEC nations for zero-casualty targets.
5. **Strengthen CDRI:** Shift focus from "Relief" to "Resilient Infrastructure" to prevent disasters from becoming catastrophes.

As natural disasters become more frequent, India's disaster diplomacy will remain a crucial instrument of its global strategy.

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India's Strategic Autonomy:

Strategic Autonomy is a nation's ability to pursue its **national interests** and adopt independent foreign policy positions without being constrained by formal military alliances or external coercion.

Important Quotes

1. "Strategic autonomy is not about fence-sitting; it is a deliberate method to navigate contested arenas on our own terms." - **Syed Akbaruddin** (Former UN Representative)
2. "Autonomy is not isolation; it is the **resilience** to matter to the greatest number of countries as a critical partner." - **C. Raja Mohan**

Origin and Evolution

1. **Era of Non-Alignment (1947-1991):** Under Nehru, India avoided Cold War blocs to focus on internal development and decolonization.
2. **The 1991 Pivot:** Following the USSR's collapse and economic crisis, India pragmatically opened its economy and moved toward a unipolar engagement with the US.
3. **Pokhran-II & Nuclear Autonomy (1998):** Testing nuclear weapons despite global sanctions asserted India's right to define its own security architecture.
4. **Multi-Alignment Era (2014-Present):** Shifted from "avoiding alliances" to "managing multiple partnerships" (Eg. simultaneous membership in **Quad** and **BRICS/SCO**).
5. **Transactional Realism (2025-2026):** In a world of trade wars and tariffs, India now practices interest-based diplomacy rather than ideological alignment.

Key Pillars of Strategic Autonomy

1. **Principled stance on global issues:** Eg. support for a 2-state solution.
2. **Sovereign Decision-Making:** Refusing to join military alliances & collective defense obligations
3. **Atmanirbhar Bharat (Self-Reliance)** in economy.
4. **Diversification of defence imports.**
5. **Global South Leadership:** Eg. Voice of Global South Summit (2023), G-20 presidency.
6. **Issue-based partnerships based on "Enlightened Self-Interest" (S. Jaishankar).**
7. **Multi-Vector Diplomacy:** Engaging rival blocs simultaneously (Eg. maintaining Russia ties while building the **iCET** with the US).
8. **Data Sovereignty:** Independent norms for AI and data privacy to avoid "digital colonialism."
9. **Energy Diversification.**

Significance of Strategic Autonomy

1. **National Interest Primacy:** Eg. importing **discounted Russian oil** in 2024-2026 despite heavy Western pressure and tariff threats.
2. **Balancing Great Power Rivalry:** Eg. participation in the **Quad** for maritime security while engaging China through the **SCO** for Eurasian stability.
3. **Rule-Maker Status:** Eg. India's leadership of the Global South in the WTO.
4. **Energy Security Resilience:** Eg. Utilizing the **Rupee-Rial/Ruble mechanisms** to bypass Western-dominated SWIFT banking channels for trade.
5. **Defense Diversification:** Eg. Operating **S-400 missiles** (Russia), **Rafale jets** (France), and **Predator drones** (USA) simultaneously.
6. **Global South Credibility:** Eg. Successful inclusion of the **African Union** in the G20 during India's presidency.

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7. **Economic Risk Mitigation:** Diversifying trade partners protects India from "weaponized interdependence" and sudden supply chain disruptions.
8. **Conflict Mediation Potential:** Neutrality makes India an acceptable mediator for warring parties that don't trust the West.
9. **Safeguarding the Diaspora:** Eg. ensuring the safety of Indians in **Israel and Iran** through balanced, non-combative diplomacy.

Major Challenges

1. **Rise of Bipolarity:** The emergence of strategic rivalry between **G-2 (USA-China),** leading to pressure to align. Eg. membership of QUAD.
2. **Defence dependency:** India is the 2nd largest arms importer globally (SIPRI).
3. **Secondary US Sanctions:** American laws like CAATSA threaten to penalize Indian companies for engaging with Russia or Iran.
4. **The "China Asymmetry":** Growing economic and military gap with China forces India into "unwilling" closer alignment with the West.
5. **Technological Dependence:** Lack of domestic "core tech" like high-end semiconductors makes India vulnerable to foreign export controls.
6. **Rising protectionism and transactional diplomacy:** Eg. **50% tariffs** by the US for energy ties with Russia.
7. **Russia's growing dependency on China** complicates India's "time-tested" relations with Moscow.
8. **Institutional Capacity:** A relatively small diplomatic corps (IFS) struggles to manage the complexities of "multi-alignment" globally.

Way Forward

1. **Weaponize the Market:** India must become a critical market for the world, making the cost of sanctioning India too high. **(C. Raja Mohan)**
2. **Accelerate Defense Indigenization** by promoting the private sector via PPP.
3. **Hedge via Minilaterals:** Focus on groups like **I2U2 and Quad** to achieve specific goals without the baggage of formal treaties.
4. **Recalibrate China Ties:** Maintain a "cold peace" at the border while aggressively decoupling from Chinese critical tech.
5. **Institutionalize Foreign Policy:** Create a "National Security Strategy" document to ensure continuity across different governments.
6. **Strategic Resource Stockpiling:** Build 90-day reserves of oil and 1-year reserves of critical minerals like Lithium.
7. **Empower the Diaspora:** Engage the diaspora as a "force multiplier" for Indian interests in Western capitals.

India's technology Diplomacy

It is the use of a nation's technological assets, innovation ecosystem, and digital standards to build international partnerships, influence global governance, and secure national interests.

It involves "Tech-Cooperation" (sharing tools like UPI) and "Tech-Governance" (shaping AI and 6G norms).

Important Quotes

1. "Technology is the new frontier of diplomacy; the nation that sets the standards, sets the global agenda." - **S. Jaishankar** (The India Way)

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2. "India's Digital Public Infrastructure is not just a domestic success; it is a diplomatic bridge to the Global South." - **Nandan Nilekani**
3. "We are moving from a world of 'strategic depth' to 'technological depth' as the measure of sovereignty." - **C. Raja Mohan**

Recent News

- During PM Modi's visit to the US in February 2025, iCET was rebranded as **TRUST - Transforming Relations Utilizing Strategic Technologies**, to advance cooperation across space, defence, AI, semiconductors, and biotechnology.
- **Microsoft pledged $3.7 billion** for data centres in Telangana; **Amazon committed $12.7 billion** in cloud infrastructure by 2030. **Google plans a $6 billion, 1 GW data centre in Visakhapatnam**
- India and the UK launched the **Technology and Security Initiative (TSI)**. It focuses on seven critical technologies like telecoms, critical minerals, AI, semiconductors, etc.
- **Indian astronaut Shubhanshu Shukla** flew to the International Space Station aboard the **Axiom-4 mission** in 2025.
- In 2025, **UPI surpassed Visa in digital payments**. UPI is already integrated with Singapore (FavePay, PayNow), UAE, France, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Bhutan, Mauritius, and Malaysia.

Key Pillars of Technology Diplomacy

1. **Digital Public Infrastructure:** Exporting the "India Stack" (UPI, ONDC) as a public good.
2. **Critical Minerals Security:** Securing Lithium, Cobalt through the Mineral Security Partnership.
3. **Space Diplomacy:** Offering cost-effective launch services and sharing "Space-Based Information" for disaster management.
4. **Semiconductor Resilience:** Building "Trusted Supply Chains" to reduce dependency.
5. **Shaping international ethics and safety standards** for transformative technologies.
6. **Cyber-Diplomacy.**
7. **Green Tech Exchange:** Sharing solar and green hydrogen technology under the International Solar Alliance (ISA).
8. **Human Capital Mobility:** Negotiating "Migration and Mobility Partnerships" for India's high-tech workforce.

Significance of Technology Diplomacy

1. **Global South Leadership:** Eg. implementing **UPI-based payment systems** in Mauritius, Sri Lanka, and several African nations.
2. **Countering Digital Colonialism:** Offers an "Open-Source" alternative to the "Closed" proprietary models of Western or Chinese companies. Eg. **"India Stack"**.
3. **Strategic Autonomy Enhancement:** Eg. developing **indigenous 5G/6G stacks**.
4. **Security of Supply Chains:** Eg. **India-Japan Semiconductor Supply Chain** partnership.
5. **Defense Modernization Leap:** Eg. Co-production of **GE-F414 jet engines** in India under the iCET framework with the USA.
6. **Moral Standard Setting:** Eg. India's chairmanship of the **Global Partnership on AI (GPAI)** focusing on human-centric innovation.
7. **Economic Growth Catalyst:** Tech-exports transition India from a "Services-only" economy to a high-value "Product and IP" economy. Eg. Exporting **India's indigenous 5G testbeds**.

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8. **Financial Inclusion Globalizer:** Eg. Linking **Singapore's PayNow with India's UPI** to facilitate low-cost, real-time cross-border remittances.

Major Challenges

1. **Hardware Dependency:** Eg. over **70% of components** for Indian-assembled smartphones are still imported from Chinese suppliers.
2. **Intellectual Property (IP) Gaps:** Eg. A low percentage of **standard-essential patents (SEPs)** are held by Indian firms in 5G/6G domains.
3. **Digital Protectionism:** Eg. US concerns over **India's Data Protection Law** impacting the "free flow of data" across borders.
4. **The "Dual-Use" Dilemma:** Eg. tensions over **drone technology exports** that could be repurposed by hostile non-state actors.
5. **Global "Tech-Decoupling"** (US vs China) forces India to choose sides. Eg. pressure to **exclude Chinese vendors** (Huawei/ZTE) from telecom infrastructure projects.
6. **Human Capital Brain-Drain:** Eg. A high percentage of **IIT graduates are still** opting for Silicon Valley over domestic R&D startups.
7. **Cyber-Security Vulnerabilities:** Increasing tech-integration makes national infrastructure more prone to state-sponsored ransomware and sabotage.
8. **Standardization Rivalries:** Competing global standards create "Tech-Islands," making interoperability difficult. Eg. Challenges in aligning **India's NavIC** with global GPS standards.
9. **Resource Inequity:** Lack of domestic "Critical Mineral" processing capabilities makes tech-diplomacy vulnerable to market price manipulation.

Way Forward

1. **Institutionalize 'Tech-Attachés':** Appoint dedicated technology experts in Indian missions in key hubs like San Francisco, Tel Aviv, and Tokyo.
2. **Accelerate 'Design in India':** Shift focus from "Assembling" to "Designing" core IPs and semiconductors to reduce import-dependency.
3. **Bridge the Global South Gap:** Create a "Digital Development Fund" to help LDCs adopt the India Stack for free.
4. **Strengthen 'Cyber-Hardening':** Treat cyber-security as a primary pillar of national defense.
5. **Harmonize AI Regulations:** Work with the EU and US to create a "middle-path" for AI that balances innovation with safety.
6. **Invest in 'Deep-Tech' R&D:** Increase domestic R&D spending to 2% of GDP to foster indigenous breakthroughs in Quantum and Biotech.
7. **Form a 'Critical Minerals Alliance':** Build a "Buyer's Bloc" with Japan and South Korea to counter China's processing monopoly.
8. **Focus on 'Trust' as a Product:** Market India as a "Neutral, Democratic, and Transparent" data-vault for the world.

India's digital diplomacy, rooted in inclusion and sovereignty, must evolve into a **strategic pillar of its foreign policy architecture.**

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India's Defence Diplomacy

"India's strategic culture has matured from non-alignment to multi-alignment," and defence diplomacy today forms a vital pillar of India's global engagements, driven by partnerships, production, and peacekeeping.

Recent News

- October 2025, **India and the US** signed a 10-Year **Defence Cooperation Framework**.
- On 28 April 2025, India and France signed an **Inter-Governmental Agreement (IGA)** to procure **26 Dassault Rafale Marine** fighter jets for the Indian Navy.
- India delivered the **first battery of BrahMos** to the Philippines Marine Corps in April 2024.
- India conducted **Exercise Tarang Shakti 24**, its largest-ever multilateral air exercise, at Air Force Stations Sulur and Jodhpur.

Region	Initiatives
United States	✔ **2+2 Dialogue**, COMCASA, BECA, LEMOA agreements. ✔️ **GE-HAL jet engine manufacturing deal (2023).** ✔️ **Malabar naval exercise** (with Japan & Australia). ✔️ Defence Trade > $22 billion (2024).
Russia	✔️ **BrahMos JV, AK-203 rifles (Amethi).** ✔ Licensed production of **Su-30MKI, T-90 tanks.** ✔️ Over **40% of India's arms imports are still** from Russia (SIPRI 2023). ✔️ Annual **INDRA** military exercise.
Europe (France, UK, Germany)	✔️ **Rafale deal, Scorpène submarines** with France. ✔ Defence Roadmaps with **France & UK.** ✔ Cooperation on **UAVs, cyber defence**, naval logistics. ✔️ EU-India **Defence and Security Dialogue** (annual).
Africa	✔️ **India-Africa Defence Dialogue** at DefExpo. ✔ Supply of patrol vessels, radars, field hospitals. ✔️ Training at NDA, IMA, DSSC for African officers. ✔️ Deployment of **UN Peacekeepers from India** in Congo, South Sudan.
ASEAN	✔ ADMM-Plus **participation, Shakti, Surya Kiran, Samudra Shakti** drills. ✔️ Naval outreach under **SAGAR & Act East Policy.** ✔ BrahMos export to Philippines. ✔ Shared interests in the South China Sea.
South Asia	✔️ **Sampriti (Bangladesh)** & **Surya Kiran (Nepal)** exercises. ✔ Supply of aircraft, patrol boats to **Sri Lanka, Maldives.**

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Region	Initiatives
	✔ Military infrastructure support to Bhutan. ✔ HADR and cyclone relief operations (Eg. Mocha 2023).

Major Impediments in India's Defence Diplomacy

1. **Overdependence on Limited Partners:** India relies heavily on countries like **Russia (~40%)**, France, and Israel for critical platforms and spares.
2. **Technology Transfer Barriers:** India faces reluctance from Western partners (esp. US and EU) to share critical tech, due to **export control regimes** and **non-alignment history**.
1. **Lack of Defence Industrial Strength:** Low R&D investment (0.65% of GDP) & Limited capability in high-end technologies restrict export potential.
2. **Bureaucratic Red Tape:** Delays in MoU implementation, clearances for joint production, FDI, and arms export licensing. Eg. The GE-HAL jet engine deal took over a decade.
3. **Underutilization of Multilateral Platforms**: India's role in ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting Plus and Africa Defence Dialogue is limited to event participation, not agenda-setting.
4. **Limited Defence Export Base:** Dependence on foreign components and lack of after-sales infrastructure weaken long-term partnerships with Global South nations.
    a. **Low Maritime Outreach Compared to China**: Despite **SAGAR** and **Milan**, India's naval base access is restricted compared to China's Djibouti base or port deals across Africa and IOR.

Way Forward to Enhance India's Defence Diplomacy

1. Formulate a National Defence Diplomacy Strategy similar to the UK's Defence Engagement Strategy.
    a. Strengthen **Make in India-for the world** with enhanced funding to **iDEX**, **Defence Corridors**, and **private sector-DRDO collaboration**.
2. Expand Military Training Diplomacy: Create structured India Defence Fellowship programs for officers from Africa, ASEAN, and Latin America.
3. Strengthen Maritime Defence Diplomacy: Sign more logistics and access agreements (LEMOA-type) with Gulf, East African, and ASEAN nations.
4. Create a Dedicated Defence Attaché Cadre: Recruit domain experts in defence procurement, arms export regulation, and military technology as part of foreign missions.
5. Simplify Export Licensing: Implement a single-window clearance system under DG Defence Export Promotion.
    a. Insist on **co-development and joint intellectual property (IP) sharing** in major deals (Eg. GE-HAL, Barak-8, Akash-NG).

South-South Cooperation

South-South Cooperation refers to **collaborative partnerships among developing countries** in the Global South for **economic, technological, social, and political development**, without hierarchical donor-recipient models.

India's approach to South-South Cooperation emphasizes **mutual benefit, non-conditionality, respect for sovereignty**, and aligns with **India's soft power and strategic diplomacy**.

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Key Pillars of India's Approach

Dimension	India's Role
Development Finance	➢ Over **$30 billion in concessional Lines of Credit** to 70+ countries (via EXIM Bank). ➢ Infra projects: Rail (Mozambique), energy (Bangladesh), agriculture (Sudan).
Capacity Building	➢ **ITEC Program** (since 1964): 15,000+ trainees from 160+ countries annually. ➢ Special programs for Africa, BIMSTEC, ASEAN.
Technology Transfer	➢ Export of **India Stack** (UPI, CoWIN, Aadhaar) to countries like Mauritius, Sri Lanka, Philippines. ➢ Digital Public Infrastructure Repository (G20 2023).
Health & Humanitarian Aid	➢ **Vaccine Maitri**: Supplied 200M+ COVID-19 doses to 100+ countries. ➢ HADR operations: **Operation Dost (Turkey), Samudra Maitri (Indonesia)**.
Peace & Security	➢ Among top 3 contributors to **UN Peacekeeping**, especially in Africa (Congo, Sudan). ➢ Training missions and military aid to the Global South.
Climate & Energy	➢ **International Solar Alliance (ISA)** co-founded with France, aimed at tropical developing countries. ➢ Leads **Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI)**.
Trade & Multilateralism	➢ Vocal in **WTO** for **TRIPS waiver** on COVID vaccines (with South Africa). ➢ Opposes unfair subsidies and agricultural protectionism by developed nations.
UN and Global Governance	➢ Demands **UN Security Council reform** to reflect the Global South's rise. ➢ Leads G-77 positions on equity, development, and climate justice.
Climate Negotiations - UNFCCC	➢ Spearheaded concept of **"Common but Differentiated Responsibilities (CBDR)"**. ➢ Advocates climate finance and technology transfer for developing countries.

Major Impediments

Impediment	Explanation
LoC Utilization Delays & Defaults	Only **45-50% of committed Lines of Credit (LoCs)** by EXIM Bank have been disbursed.
Underfunded Development Diplomacy	India's **Development Partnership Administration (DPA)** under MEA handles multi-billion-dollar projects with a lean staff (~100 officers).
Project Execution Bottlenecks	Several Indian-funded projects in **Myanmar (Kaladan), Sri Lanka (housing)** face local protests, land acquisition issues, or delays by Indian contractors.

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Impediment	Explanation
Lack of Diplomatic Footprint	India has embassies in only **43 of 54 African nations**, limiting outreach. By contrast, **China has embassies in all 54**.
China's Parallel Influence Structures	India offers grants/LoCs, but **China combines aid with military bases, telecom (Huawei), political influence**, often creating policy capture in nations like the Maldives and Zambia.
Poor Post-Project Visibility	Once projects are inaugurated (Eg. Parliament building in Gambia), there is little **public diplomacy or media follow-up**, unlike China's high-profile Belt and Road promotion.
Bureaucratic Delays in Approvals	Defence export licenses for Africa or ASEAN partners take **6-12 months**, reducing India's competitiveness in small arms and HADR gear.
Skewed Focus on English-speaking Countries	Programmes like ITEC and ICCR scholarships favour **Anglophone countries**; Engagement with **Francophone Africa and Latin America** remains thin.
Security Concerns in Host Countries	In volatile states (Eg. South Sudan, Afghanistan), Indian projects and personnel face risks without adequate military/diplomatic protection or evacuation planning.

Way Forward

Strategy	Measures
Strengthen Institutional Capacity (DPA)	Upgrade the **Development Partnership Administration (DPA)** with more staffing, project management experts, and an independent **South-South Monitoring Unit**.
Strategic Branding of Aid Projects	Introduce a unified branding framework: Eg. **"India for Development"** akin to China's "Belt & Road."
Expand Diplomatic Presence in the Global South	Open more missions in **Francophone Africa, Latin America, Pacific Islands**. Leverage regional groupings (Eg. **CARICOM, FIPIC, ECOWAS**) for regional diplomacy.
Digital empowerment	Leverage UPI, CoWIN, and Aadhaar stack via **Digital India Abroad** strategy.
Align with SDG and Global Goals	Sync all development projects with **SDGs (especially Goals 1, 4, 7, 9, 13, 17)**.
Promote Global South Leadership in Multilaterals	Lead reforms at WTO (Eg. food security), UNFCCC (climate finance), and **push for UNSC representation of developing countries**. Continue initiatives like **Voice of the Global South Summit** annually.

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Erosion of Multilateralism

Speaking in the **Rajya Sabha**, PM Modi acknowledged the emergence of a **new world order**, stating that multilateral structures are "withering away" as power politics and transactional relationships reshape global governance.

What is Multilateralism?

Multilateralism is the process of organizing relations between three or more states based on **generalized principles of conduct**.

Key Features:

1. **Indivisibility:** A threat to one member is treated as a threat to the collective. Eg. Article 5 of NATO.
2. **Non-Discrimination:** Rules apply equally to all members. Eg. the WTO's MFN principle.
3. **Diffuse Reciprocity:** Members expect to benefit from the system over the long term, rather than requiring an immediate "quid pro quo" for every action.
4. **Rule of Law:** International law and treaties take precedence over the unilateral whims of powerful nations.

Forms:

1. **Hard Multilateralism:** Binding treaties with enforcement. Eg. WTO Dispute Settlement Body, UNSC Chapter VII resolutions.
2. **Soft Multilateralism:** Non-binding voluntary frameworks. Eg. Paris Agreement NDCs, G20 declarations.
3. **Minilateralism:** Smaller coalitions on specific issues. Eg. QUAD on Indo-Pacific security, I2U2 on food and energy.

Key Institutions of Multilateralism

Institution	Founded	Purpose	Current Status
United Nations	1945	Peace, security, human rights	UNSC paralysed by P5 veto.
World Trade Organization	1995	Rules-based global trade	Appellate Body non-functional since 2019.
International Monetary Fund	1944	Global financial stability	Voting shares imbalance. Legitimacy deficit.
World Bank	1944	Development financing	Challenged by China-led alternatives like AIIB, NDB.
World Health Organization	1948	Global health governance	US withdrawal (2025). Credibility concerns post-COVID.
International Criminal Court	1998	International criminal justice	Major powers absent. Weak enforcement.

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Institution	Founded	Purpose	Current Status
G20	1999	Global economic coordination	Consensus increasingly elusive. Diluted declarations.
BRICS	2009	South-South cooperation	Expansion with internal fragmentation.

Reasons Behind the Weakening

Structural

1. **Outdated Architecture:** Institutions reflect outdated power hierarchies, undermining legitimacy. Eg. UNSC is based on 1945 power dynamics.
2. **Enforcement Deficit:** Compliance depends on state will, not binding authority. Eg. ICC warrant against Putin remains unenforced.
3. **Democratic Deficit in Institutions:** Traditional bodies have failed to reform voting shares to reflect the rise of the **Global South**. Eg. **IMF/World Bank quotas.**

Political

1. **Populism & Sovereigntism:** Domestic politics override multilateral commitments, weakening cooperation. Eg. “America First,” Brexit, Hungary blocking EU aid.
2. **Democratic Backsliding:** Declining democratic norms reduce support for rules-based order. Eg. Israel’s war in the Middle East.
3. **Transactional Foreign Policy:** Nations view multilateral rules as constraints on sovereignty. Eg. The **"Don Doctrine"** emphasizes reshoring and bilateral trade over universal WTO consensus.
4. **Rise of Minilateralism:** Shift toward small "coalitions of the willing" instead of universal forums. Eg. **Multi-Party Interim Appeal (MPIA)** has effectively replaced the WTO Appellate Body for select members.

Economic

1. **Globalisation Backlash:** Unequal gains fuel anti-trade sentiment and institutional distrust. Eg. US Rust Belt deindustrialisation driving anti-WTO politics.
2. **China’s Distortions:** State-led capitalism undermines fair trade norms within the WTO framework. Eg. steel dumping and subsidised exports.
3. **Financial Attrition:** Eg. The UN faced a **$1.6 billion** shortfall in unpaid assessed contributions by late 2025.
4. **Securitization of Trade:** "Economic security" is now used to justify unilateral tariffs, bypassing the rules-based framework of the GATT.

Impact of Weakening of Multilateralism

1. **"Zombie multilateralism"**: International organizations (like the WTO, G20, or APEC) survive and continue to meet, yet fail to function effectively or produce substantive agreements.
2. **Global Economic Fragmentation:** Trade costs rise as "one-size-fits-all" rules are replaced by multiple conflicting bilateral treaties.
3. **Stifled Voice of the Global South:** Smaller nations command less leverage in bilateral "power-based" negotiations than in rules-based forums.
4. **Security Fragmentation: C. Raja Mohan** points out that "deterrence" has replaced "globalization" as the organizing principle. Nations are now prioritizing military alliances (like **NATO** or **AUKUS**) over collective UN security frameworks.

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5. **Weakening of International Law:** "Force replaces law," leading to what diplomats describe as a return to "global barbarism." Eg. US intervention in Venezuela.
6. **Human Rights Accountability Void:** collapse of multilateral monitoring emboldens authoritarian regimes to ignore international norms without consequence. Eg. Israel's bombing of Gaza.
7. **Regional Conflict Escalation:** Without a "credible neutral arbiter," local disputes rapidly descend into wider kinetic wars. Eg. **The Iran-Israel war**.
8. **Paralysis in Climate Action:** US withdrawal from the Paris Agreement framework politicizes climate science and halts cross-border green financing.
9. **Decline in Global GDP:** Reduced investment flows and trade certainty lead to long-term economic stagnation for weaker nations.
10. **Vulnerability of SMEs** due to decline of WTP. Eg. MSMEs face **40% higher compliance costs** in a rules-free global market.
11. **Public Health Inequity:** Fragmented pandemic responses lead to "vaccine nationalism" and broken medical supply chains.

Challenges Created for India

1. **Strategic Autonomy Contraction:** Great-power rivalries (US-China-Russia) narrow India's maneuverability. Eg. balancing the **Quad** (security) with **BRICS/SCO** (continental stability).
2. **Global South Leadership Dilution:** As China uses "investment-led diplomacy," India struggles to match the material dominance in regional forums.
3. **WTO Dispute Settlement Paralysis:** The collapse of the Appellate Body leaves Indian exporters vulnerable to unilateral trade barriers. Eg. EU's CBAM
4. **UNSC Reform Deadlock:** Persistent "veto-lock" on global conflicts prevents India from securing the permanent seat its global stature warrants.
5. **Weaponization of Supply Chains:** Eg. China's **2025 halt on rare earth magnets** exposed India's 70%+ dependency in the aerospace sector.
6. **Climate Finance Execution Gap:** Weakened global cooperation slows the flow of the $300 billion annual investment India needs for transition.
7. **Digital Sovereignty Conflicts:** The lack of global AI/Data standards leaves India's **Digital Public Infrastructure** (DPI) vulnerable to Western platform monopolies.
8. **Diaspora Vulnerability:** Lack of global labour protections exposes Indian workers to unilateral policies. Eg. Gulf workers without binding safeguards.

Opportunities for India

1. **Rise as a "Third Pole":** Eg. India's **"Multi-aligned" approach** makes it an indispensable partner for the US, Russia, and the Global South.
2. **Global Manufacturing Pivot (China+1):** Companies moving away from China are choosing India for its large market and stable democracy.
3. **Leadership of the Global South:** Eg. successfully including the **African Union in the G20** cemented India's role as a "System-Shaping" partner.
4. **Strategic Energy Autonomy:** Transactional diplomacy allows India to buy affordable energy based on national interest rather than bloc pressure.
5. **Accelerated Trade Deals:** Instead of waiting for global WTO rules, India is signing fast, effective bilateral trade agreements. Eg. **The India-EU Trade Agreement**.
6. **Climate Leadership through Innovation:** India is leading global green initiatives like the International Solar Alliance (ISA).

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Way Forward

1. **"World-Minus-One" Cooperation:** If the US or other powers withdraw from certain bodies, the rest of the world (led by India, EU, and Brazil) should continue to cooperate.
2. **Multiplexity over Minilateralism:** patchwork of overlapping, issue-specific groups rather than relying on a single, failed global body. Eg. **ISA** for solar, **IPEF** for trade.
3. **Champion UNSC Reform:** Lead G4 push using diplomatic platforms for incremental change. Eg. leverage 2028 UNSC seat for veto reform advocacy.
4. **Revive WTO Dispute System:** Build coalitions to restore or replace binding dispute resolution. Eg. MPIA participation with EU, Brazil.
5. **Lead AI Governance:** Shape global AI norms leveraging non-aligned positioning. Eg. "AI for development" at GPAI and ITU.
6. **Proactive Multilateral Strategy:** Shift from reactive to agenda-setting diplomacy. Eg. institutionalising G20-style leadership approach.

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